

Delhi minister slaps youth during road inspection, AAP seeks action



A video grab of the incident in West Delhi's Vikaspuri, Sunday

Alok Singh & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 27

DELHI PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh found himself at the centre of a row on Sunday as a video clip circulated on social media showed him slapping a youth during inspection of road repair work in Vikaspuri area of West Delhi.

Sharing the video clip on X, AAP MLA from Tilak Nagar, Jarnail Singh, said in his post: “He had come to inspect the road, but upon seeing scam after scam being exposed, he lost his cool and ended up indulging in thuggery (*goondagardi*) with my colleague who was recording the video.”

Parvesh Sahib Singh, too, shared a video on X later in which he alleged that AAP workers had abused his family. “Listen to the full truth behind today’s incident... but what happened should not have happened,” he said in his post.

The incident happened on Sunday afternoon. The video »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Elephant smuggled from Nepal, trail points to NGO in leopard poaching probe

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, September 27

FIRST, IT was alleged leopard poaching. Now, it is the alleged purchase of an elephant from Nepal.

The NGO Wildlife SOS, whose two functionaries are in the custody of Madhya Pradesh’s Forest department in a leopard poaching case with its CEO Kartick Satyanarayan due to join the probe, is also allegedly linked to a case of live elephant trade from four years ago, Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) records show.

In March 2022, the WCCB arrested three men with 30 kg of ivory in Jaipur. One of the accused told investigators that a “Mathura resident Suraj Pal”, who is “associated with an Agra NGO”, had bought a female elephant smuggled from Nepal, it is learnt. The mobile phone of another accused contained chats with a contact saved as “SOS.Baigo.Agra” — the chats referred to “Suraj Pal’s elephant”, and the contact wrote he had kept “Kartick sir” informed, records show.

What’s missing in the »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Citizenship not ECI’s job: Former SC judge Dhulia

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 27

FORMER SUPREME Court judge Sudhanshu Dhulia has said that the apex court has laid down the law in several judgments on citizenship and it “is not the Election Commission of India’s job”.

Justice Dhulia, who retired from the Supreme Court in August 2025, also described as “a serious matter” the two Elec-



RENUKA PURI

Justice (retd) Sudhanshu Dhulia was at the Idea Exchange Friday

tion Commissioners objecting on record 14 times in 10 months to steps taken by the Chief Election Commissioner, as reported »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



During protests by students of the Lovely Professional University in Phagwara, Punjab, Sunday. PTI

Violence over sexual assault claim in LPU, university denies incident

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Jalandhar, September 27

STUDENTS OF Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab’s Phagwara staged a violent protest early on Sunday, damaging property, vandalising shops, setting vehicles on fire

INSIDE PAGE 8
CLASH AT KOLKATA FILM INSTITUTE

and blocking a national highway, alleging that a girl student had been sexually assaulted by

an “outsider” on campus. The university denied the allegation, describing it as “baseless and fabricated rumours”.

Following the violence, LPU suspended classes for 10 days with effect from September 28. In a communication to students, »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AHEAD OF PM'S LIKELY VISIT IN DEC

Trade in focus, India, Canada push to up ties

To take ties to higher level, says Jaishankar; building renewed partnerships with large economies like India, China: Canada minister

Divya A
New Delhi, September 27

SIGNALLING FURTHER moves to improve ties between New Delhi and Ottawa, Canada’s Foreign Minister Anita Anand underlined attempts to build “renewed partnerships” with large economies like India and China, while External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said the two sides are preparing to take their relationship “to a higher level”.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



EAM S Jaishankar with his Canadian counterpart Anita Anand in New York. ANI

POLITICS PAGE 7

ASHOK SINGHAL: A LIFE DEDICATED TO NATION-BUILDING

BY PM NARENDRA MODI

Happening today

● **INDIA'S CRICKET** campaign in the Japan Asian Games starts, while Avinash Sable and Sreesankar Murali will carry medal hopes in Athletics.

As fungal disease hits sugar output in UP, new cane variety holds hope

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, September 27

UTTAR PRADESH, India’s top cane growing state, has seen its sugar output plummet from 126.4 lakh tonnes (lt) to 89.5 lt between 2019-20 and 2025-26 (October-September production years).

The primary reason has been the susceptibility of the

widely-cultivated sugarcane variety, Co-0238 (also called Karan 4), to red rot fungal disease.

The resultant yield losses have led to the total quantity of cane crushed by the 120-odd sugar mills in Uttar Pradesh, where Assembly elections are set to be held in February-March 2027, falling by over a fifth in the last six years.

A new variety of hope

The industry is now pinning its hopes on a new variety developed by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research’s Sugarcane Breeding Institute (ICAR-SBI) at Coimbatore. This variety, Co-20016 (Karan 20), has already been picked as a potential replacement for Co-0238 by a Varietal Identification Committee »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



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CAT member recuses from hearing forest officer’s plea — 17th such instance in 13 yrs

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, September 27

ON SEPTEMBER 21, a member of the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) in the Capital recused himself from hearing a petition by Indian Forest Service officer Sanjiv Chaturvedi concerning his Annual Performance Appraisal Report (APAR).

The recusal by CAT Delhi Bench Member (Judicial) Rajveer Singh Verma was not a first for the Uttarakhand-cadre officer. Over the last 13 years, as many as 17 judges and judicial officers — including two Supreme Court judges, four Uttarakhand High Court judges, nine (CAT) members and two judges from the district judiciary — have recused themselves from cases involving the forest officer.

According to the latest order, Chaturvedi appeared in person and referred to the All India Services (Performance Appraisal Report) Rules, 2007, including provisions relating to the APAR Accepting Authority, Reporting Authority and Reviewing Authority. He referred to a November 29, 2021, communication of Additional Chief Secretary, Uttarakhand, prescribing authorities for disposal of APARs of forest officers. The matter was still under a Registry objection. One of the objections was that the representation filed by Chaturvedi was premature, the order said.

The order recorded that Chaturvedi, appearing in person, continued making submissions that were “not connected with the issue involved” in the case despite being repeatedly directed to confine his submissions to the matter before the

Bench. “After hearing the matter for some time, Hon’ble Mr. Rajveer Singh Verma, Member (J), recuses himself from hearing this matter,” the order said. The Registry was directed to list the matter before the “appropriate Bench” and notify the same.

Verma’s recusal adds to a series of instances over more than a decade in which judges and judicial officers stepped aside from cases involving Chaturvedi, in matters concerning his service, postings, disciplinary proceedings, deputation and performance appraisal.

In September-October 2025, Uttarakhand HC judge Justice Alok Verma and Justice Ravindra Maithani recused themselves from hearing a contempt petition filed by Chaturvedi against members of the CAT and its Registry. The petition alleged wilful disobedience of a HC stay order. Earlier, in February 2024, Justice Manoj Tiwari recused himself from a case filed by Chaturvedi seeking documents from the Appointment Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) relating to his central deputation.

The instances go back to November 2013, when then SC judge Justice Ranjan Gogoi recused himself from hearing a petition seeking a CBI investigation into allegations of corruption and harassment raised by Chaturvedi.

Across the cases, the circumstances surrounding the recusals have varied. Chaturvedi, a 2002-batch officer, has been involved in several rounds of litigation over his service matters.

This case will now be placed before another appropriate CAT Bench.

Amid ecological concerns, rail line set to connect Uri with Baramulla shelved

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 27

THE INDIAN Railways has shelved the proposed 40-kilometer railway line meant to connect the border region of Uri with Baramulla — the last point of the existing railway line to the Valley. The project has been shelved after concerns over its ecological impact.

The Railways have shelved the double-lining of the existing 74-kilometer Qazigund-Srinagar-Budgam stretch. This has come six months after the rail ministry put on hold the proposed Anantnag-Pahalgam and Anantnag-Shopian rail links after protests from farmers.

“With reference to the above, it is informed that the following 02 Projects ie Baramulla Uri (40 Km) New Line Project and Qazigund Srinagar-Budgam (74 Km) Doubling, projects of Northern Railway have been returned by Cabinet Secretariat and are no longer under consideration... Joint Director Works, Railways Board, has written to General Manager Northern Railways.

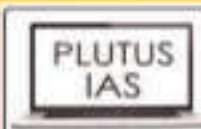
Welcoming the move, Baramulla legislator Javid Hassan Baig said, “Baramulla simply cannot afford a project that cuts through the very heart of the town and compromises its future development... Development must protect the town’s

heritage, environment, land resources and future generations,” He said, “Finally, the government of India decided to shelve the project. I consider this a welcome and responsible step in the larger interest of Baramulla.”

The proposed Baramulla–Uri railway line, planned as an extension of the Udhampur-Baramulla rail line, was being viewed as a strategic rail link, extending rail connectivity towards the Line of Control and providing faster movement of troops, equipment and other military logistics to forward areas. Beyond its civilian connectivity, the line was expected to strengthen the logistical infrastructure in the strategically sensitive border region.

The rail line had caused ecological concerns as it was proposed to bisect Baramulla town and certain other village habitations and traverse through orchards, fragile highland and mountains that fall in the high-seismic zone 5. The corridor is vulnerable to extreme weather conditions.

Baramulla MLA Baig opposed the line and submitted a resolution in the ongoing Assembly session, calling for the project to be put in abeyance until a “comprehensive and independent geological, geotechnical and seismic assessment” of the proposed corridor is carried out.

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Canada

This comes ahead of a proposed visit by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Canada in December this year, when the two sides are aiming to finalise and sign the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

Jai Shankar met Anand on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) on Saturday. “Always a pleasure to meet FM @AnitaAnandMP of Canada... A productive discussion as we prepare to take the relationship to a higher level,” he said in a post on X, as he shared a short video clip of their meeting.

Meanwhile, in her address at the high-level UNGA General Debate on Saturday, Anand said that in the economic realm, Canada is focused on what it can control: diversifying its trade and catalysing a trillion dollars of investment in the country over the next five years.

She said for this, Ottawa is exploring new opportunities with

partners in the Indo-Pacific, the Gulf region and Latin America. “This includes building renewed partnerships with large economies like India and China,” she said.

Anand also highlighted efforts with India and other nations to strengthen multilateralism and boost UN reforms. Earlier this week, India co-sponsored an inaugural multilateralism summit at the UN headquarters, with Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada and Kenya.

While New Delhi and Ottawa have hit a major reset in ties ever since Canadian Prime Minister Mike Carney took over in March 2025, both sides are also aiming at strategic autonomy and trade diversification in the wake of trade and tariff pressures from Washington.

Earlier this week, Carney said at the UN that Modi was expected to visit Canada around December this year. “We are making good progress in our trade negotiations with India. It is an exceptionally important relationship on many levels, people-to-people levels, security

levels, and also trade and economic,” he said at a press conference Tuesday on the sidelines of the UNGA.

India and Canada had committed at the G20 last year to “look to conclude negotiations by the G20 this year”, he said, while responding to questions on when Modi would visit Canada and how close Ottawa was to concluding a free trade agreement with India.

Ties between the two countries had nosedived in 2023, during the tenure of former prime minister Justin Trudeau, after he said that Canadian security agencies were pursuing allegations of a potential link between agents of the Indian government and the killing of Canadian citizen Hardeep Singh Nijjar in British Columbia — a claim rejected by India.

The diplomatic row led to reciprocal expulsions of diplomats and a reduction in diplomatic personnel.

In July this year, the Royal Canadian Mounted Police — as part of a larger investigation into transnational organised crime — said it had found no evidence

linking Indian government officials to Nijjar’s killing.

In June last year, Carney and Modi agreed to take calibrated steps to restore stability, followed by the return of high commissioners and a series of high-level engagements.

Modi visited Canada for the G7 Summit last year. If he travels to Canada in December, it will be his first bilateral visit to the country after 2015.

Carney made a bilateral visit to India from February 27 to March 2 this year — the first visit by a Canadian Prime Minister to the country since 2018.

The two sides have been in touch at various levels — including several rounds of discussions and meetings between Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Canadian Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu. Goyal said earlier that the two sides have agreed to fast-track negotiations for a comprehensive economic partnership, with the next round of talks scheduled to begin on October 5.

The agreement is engineered to expand bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030. WITH PTI INPUTS

NGO

WCCB records is this: the number tagged as “SOS.Baigo.Agra” belongs to Baiju Raj, director of conservation at Wildlife SOS, which operates bear and elephant rescue facilities in Agra and Mathura, where Suraj Pal has worked as an elephant keeper since 2011, *The Indian Express* has found.

Asked about the reference to “Kartick sir” in the chat, Satyanarayan told *The Indian Express*: “I have no knowledge of the purported chat records. Therefore, I am unable to verify, assess, or comment on the matter.” When contacted, Baiju Raj denied knowledge of the chat.

On Baiju Raj’s chat records concerning “Suraj Pal’s elephant,” Satyanarayan said: “This appears to be a concocted narrative being circulated by individuals with mischievous and personal vendetta, having vested interests.”

Asked whether the interrogation lead was followed up, Devendra Singh Rathore, the case officer who was then a WCCB inspector, declined to

comment. WCCB did not respond to requests from *The Indian Express* for comment. A former WCCB official told this newspaper that the agency was perhaps unaware Pal worked for Wildlife SOS and “inadvertently gave up on leads that could lead to a case of cross-border smuggling.”

Trans-border trail

It was on March 13, 2022, that a WCCB team arrested UP Police sub-inspector Nazuddin Khan, his son Gulam Khan and accomplice Nashir Ali with approximately 30 kg of ivory and a licensed revolver in Jaipur.

According to case records, the chats referring to “Suraj Pal’s elephant” were found on Nazuddin Khan’s phone. The other accused, Ali, told investigators that he had smuggled a 35-40-year-old female elephant through the Hathihewa (Nepal) border to Kakrawa in UP’s Kushinagar during the first Covid lockdown in 2020.

According to Ali’s interrogation records, the elephant belonged to Ramesh Khatola, a hotel owner in Nepal’s Sauraha, who sold her to Dinanath Verma in Kushinagar for Rs 40 lakh.

Verma, in turn, sold the elephant to Suraj Pal for Rs 70 lakh, Ali told investigators.

Khan, Ali and the third accused are out on bail, with the trial pending.

Asked about the alleged chat records involving Khan, Baiju Raj said: “I am not aware of Nazuddin Khan. I have no knowledge of the purported chat records you are referring to.”

In an email, Wildlife SOS said: “Suraj Pal was associated with us for a short period up to 2016 when his employment was terminated. Therefore, Wildlife SOS is unable to comment on any activities attributed to him after his departure from the organisation.”

The Wildlife SOS website has a webpage, dated August 21, 2025, featuring the NGO’s elephant keeper Suraj Pal.

Last month, the Madhya Pradesh State Tiger Strike Force (STSF) arrested two Wildlife SOS employees — Bhagwan Singh alias Salim, and his accomplice Wasim — for their alleged involvement in poaching 10 leopards in the Shivpuri-Morena landscape. Satyanarayan has so far failed to appear before investigators on three occasions and

sought protection from arrest. On September 21, the Supreme Court granted Satyanarayan interim protection and asked him to appear before the investigators on September 28.

Questions over methods

Meanwhile, at least three wildlife crime investigators told this newspaper that they have long raised questions over the NGO’s rescue and anti-poaching methods. “We had strong circumstantial evidence on a few occasions, but never a smoking gun,” a senior UP forest officer told *The Indian Express*.

According to them, investigative agencies were aware of allegations that poachers were collecting bear cubs from the wild on behalf of Wildlife SOS since at least 2007.

“We got interested because on multiple occasions bear cubs were found abandoned in hotel rooms. No arrest would be made because no handler would be around,” a former senior investigator with a central agency said. He said leads were pursued in Odisha, Jharkhand and pockets along the Nepal border before the “trails dried up”.

Former SC judge

by *The Indian Express*.

Responding to a question at the Idea Exchange Friday on his remark during an SIR hearing in July 2025 that “citizenship is an issue to be determined not by the Election Commission of India, but by the Ministry of Home Affairs”, Justice Dhulia said: “This is the law laid down by the Supreme Court in several earlier judgments: this is not the Election Commission of India’s job. But a voter has to be a citizen of this country. The problem is the enormous conditions that have been imposed. When I was hearing the matter, nobody had asked

for a stay, so why give one? They were only asking for Aadhaar and voter cards to be accepted, so we said fine. That’s about all I did, which they agreed to.”

Asked about *The Indian Express* investigation on the objections raised by the Election Commissioners, Justice Dhulia said: “If the decisions of the Election Commission of India were taking place with only the Chief Election Commissioner, the way it has been presented by *The Indian Express*, then it becomes a serious matter. But we do not know, and it’s too early for anyone to say...”

Justice Dhulia was also asked a question related to another finding of *The Indian Express* investigation, on 97 voters in Goa not being brought back into the rolls despite the Chief Electoral Officer writing to the Election

Commission and the Supreme Court earlier stating that everyone flagged as having a “logical discrepancy” should first be heard.

Justice Dhulia said: “Contempt of court is a deliberate and wilful disobedience of a court order. So, first of all, whether some order has been violated has to be proved, and whether that violation was deliberate and wilful also has to be proved. It’s quite possible that they may say, and I am playing the Devil’s Advocate here, “No, instructions were given, but some lower-level officers have not followed them’. Contempt of court is not an easy path to tread here.”

Justice Dhulia headed a vacation bench in July 2025 that declined to restrain the Election Commission from proceeding with the SIR of electoral rolls in

poll-bound Bihar.

The bench, which included Justice Joymalya Bagchi, also suggested to the poll panel to consider Aadhaar, voter ID and ration cards, too, for the purpose of updating the rolls. It was hearing petitions voicing concerns over the SIR in Bihar.

On Friday, the retired judge clarified that he was only the “vacation judge for a day or two”.

“There were two questions before me. Since the matter wasn’t being heard during the vacation, I said, bring it tomorrow. After hearing it, we passed an interim order regarding the Aadhaar card and other things. But the actual arguments did not take place before me. So this question is better asked to those before whom the full arguments took place and who then took the decision,” he said.

UP sugar

under the All-India Coordinated Research Project (AICRP) on Sugarcane, which met on May 27. “It will next be placed before the Central Varietal Release Committee, which is expected to meet in October. Once approved by it and officially released for commercial cultivation, farmers can plant the variety in the coming spring (February-March), summer (April-May), or autumn (mid-September to mid-November) seasons,” said a government official.

The Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) had, in August 2023, launched a joint initiative with the ICAR-SBI for conducting evaluation trials of improved cane varieties at selected factory locations across both subtropical (UP, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Haryana and Punjab) and tropical (Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana) India.

For the subtropical region, the clones of two varieties (Co-20016 and Co-21012) were tested over three years through two plant-cane and one ratoon crops. Sixteen sugar mills participated in the trials, including 11 from UP. “We have completed the trials for both the varieties and the results are very encour-

E. EXPLAINED

Behind the rot

For nearly a decade, a single blockbuster cane variety, Co-0238, made UP India’s top sugar producer, overtaking Maharashtra. But devastating red rot fungal attacks, from its monocropping, have led both mills and farmers to look for an alternative high-yielding, disease-resistant variety.

aging,” ISMA’s Director General Deepak Ballani said. The AICRP trials under ICAR have also been completed for Co-20016, and are in progress for Co-21012.

The three-year average cane yield for Co-20016 at ISMA’s trial locations worked out to 144.6 tonnes per hectare, as against 116.4 tonnes for Co-0238. The mean sucrose content in the cane juice at 10-months cropping period, too, was found higher for Co-20016 (18.7%) than for Co-0238 (18.3%).

Red rot resistance

More important, the Co-20016 variety has shown to be resistant to red rot — specifically the highly virulent ‘CF13’ pathotype of the *Colletotrichum falcatum* fungal pathogen.

When Co-0238 was developed by ICAR-SBI and released

● CANE & SUGAR IN U.P. MILLS (lakh tonnes)			
	Sugarcane crushed	Sugar production	Sugar recovery
2011-12	768.55	69.74	9.07%
2012-13	815.06	74.85	9.18%
2013-14	701.17	64.95	9.26%
2014-15	744.53	71.01	9.54%
2015-16	645.67	68.55	10.62%
2016-17	827.16	87.73	10.61%
2017-18	1,111.90	120.5	10.84%
2018-19	1,031.67	118.22	11.49%
2019-20	1,118.02	126.37	11.73%
2020-21	1,027.50	110.59	11.46%
2021-22	1,016.26	101.98	11.47%
2022-23	1,098.82	104.82	11.4%
2023-24	981.68	104.13	11.5%
2024-25	956.09	92.45	10.68%
2025-26	878.12	89.52	10.83%

NOTE: SUGAR RECOVERY RATES ARE WITHOUT DIVERSION TO B-HAVY MOLASSES. SOURCE: SUGAR INDUSTRY & CANE DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVERNMENT OF UTTAR PRADESH

in 2009, it was evaluated as moderately resistant to the prevalent ‘CF07’ and ‘CF08’ pathotypes of the red rot-causing fungus.

“The CF13 pathotype emerged due to the intensive monoculture planting of Co-0238 in UP as well as other subtropical states. As the fungus mutated and evolved into this new pathotype, Co-0238 suffered varietal breakdown, losing its resistance and becoming susceptible to red rot,” explained Dr Bakshi Ram, former director of ICAR-SBI and breeder of this once-blockbuster variety.

The contribution of Co-0238 to UP’s sugar industry can be seen from the accompanying table.

“For all its advantages, I had warned against the over-cultivation of the variety, especially in the central, eastern and Terai belts of UP that are prone to waterlogging. Waterlogged fields are particularly conducive for red rot infestation and transport of the fungal spores across regions. Unfortunately, neither the mills nor farmers followed my advice,” Dr Ram said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

LPU

the university said mid-term examinations had also been postponed until further notice. It advised those staying on campus to remain inside their hostels or places of residence, avoid unnecessary movement and refrain from participation in the ongoing unrest.

Senior police officers told *The Indian Express* that an FIR had been registered against an unidentified person on charges of rape, but they were unable to substantiate the allegation in preliminary investigations conducted at the location cited by the protesting students. “The three girls present in the hostel room where the sexual assault is alleged to have occurred denied that any such incident took place,” an officer said.

The police also formed a Special Investigation Team (SIT), headed by SP (Phagwara) Major Singh and comprising a DSP, a woman police inspector and student representatives, to probe the matter further.

The Indian Express spoke to several students at the protest site, but none could identify the alleged victim.

The unrest came barely 24 hours after Chitkara University in Patiala, around 140 km away, witnessed a protest by students who allegedly set a police vehicle afire over unverified claims of “hearing girls’ screams from the hostel”.

At LPU, the unrest began around 2am after claims of an alleged sexual assault in a girls’ hostel were shared by the students on social media. They alleged an “outsider working as a plumber” had entered a girl’s room and sexually assaulted her three days ago, and that the warden had taken no action when the matter was reported.

Subsequently, the students gathered near the hostel and moved towards the university’s main entrance. The protest escalated, with students damaging campus property and setting fire to furniture, motorcycles and ambulances. Several shops in the university mall also suffered damage. A protesting student even climbed atop a decommissioned MiG-23UM aircraft installed on campus, while a few others mounted a decommissioned military tank at the gate.

Around 4 am, the protesters blocked a stretch of the Delhi-Amritsar NH-44 outside the campus, leading to a traffic jam. The highway was later cleared by police, which resorted to a lathicharge at one point after they were pelted with stones.

The protesters had initially said they would call off the agi-

tation once an FIR was registered. But several rounds of talks between the protesting students and the LPU management remained inconclusive, even though Vice Chancellor Jaspal Singh Sandhu assured that the grievances would be addressed.

The students insisted that LPU Founder-Chancellor Ashok Mittal, a BJP Rajya Sabha MP who switched from AAP in April, come to the protest site and assure them their issues would be resolved. They also demanded an apology from the Pro-Vice Chancellor, justice for the alleged victim and action against anyone found responsible. Besides, they wanted the University Management System which grants them access to all varsity activities, to not be blocked, and that they not be victimised for the protest.

The other demands included stronger security in girls’ hostels, male staff not being deployed in areas where girls students reside, greater accountability of hostel officials and action against university officials if negligence is established. Some protesters sought the resignation of the hostel warden, too. LPU has more than 35,000 students from India and abroad.

DIG (Jalandhar Range) Naveen Singla said, “The FIR has been registered on charges of rape against the unidentified suspect. The matter will be investigated scientifically, and forensic, CCTV and phone data will be examined. We have asked students’ representatives to be part of our investigation. We will unearth the truth.”

V-C Sandhu said, “The university is fully cooperating with the investigation. So far, no such incident has come to my notice. We will provide all CCTV footage, anything the police want. The SIT that has been constituted also has student representatives as its members.”

An LPU spokesperson described the allegation of sexual assault as “false and fabricated”. It appears to be a “deliberate and concerted attempt to malign the reputation of the university”, the spokesperson said. Registrar Dr Monica Gulati said “anti-social elements and others were creating the problem”. The LPU also released a video statement purportedly of three students from the room where the incident was alleged to have taken place. It showed them saying they had been staying in the room for the past two months and no such incident had taken place.

DIG Singla said police were also examining the circumstances surrounding the death of another LPU woman student from Telangana who allegedly died by suicide around 15 days ago.

Minister slaps man

clip shows Jarnail Singh, accompanied by some supporters, complaining to the minister about the condition of a newly constructed road in the area. A youth who is recording the events on a cellphone is slapped by the minister, who is accompanied by security personnel. As protests erupt, Parvesh Sahib Singh is driven away.

The youth was later identified as Sahib Singh, 22. “I was doing a live video recording of the minister’s inspection on the directions of MLA Jarnail Singh,” he told *The Indian Express*. He said he was pursuing his graduation and has been associated with Jarnail Singh’s social media team for the past four years. “I never abused anyone, including the minister. You can clearly hear the entire conversation in the live video that I was recording on the Instagram account of Jarnail Singh,” he said.

In his video clip on X, Parvesh Sahib Singh alleged: “Work was being underway on Vikaspuri Ring Road for the last few days. The local MLA, Jarnail Singh, has been asking PWD officials to let him meet the contractor and get some commission from him”. He said the engineer was getting an FIR filed against the MLA.

“When I was passing through that road today, I told the engineers that I wanted to check the ongoing work. When I inspected the work, it turned out to be going well,” he said, adding that he also called up Jarnail Singh and waited for him for 45 minutes.

“I had not called BJP workers, but when Jarnail Singh reached there, he came with his party workers. He started saying disrespectful things the moment he came. His party workers started abusing my family. I did what any person would do in that moment of anger,” he said.

The minister did not respond to phone calls or messages from *The Indian Express*.

Jarnail Singh said he would register a case against the minister and demanded action against him.

“We have received complaints from both sides and are probing the matter,” a senior police officer said.

Two separate complaints -- one by a PWD assistant engineer and another by CP Arora Private Limited, the contractor executing the road work -- have been submitted to the Tilak Nagar police station against Jarnail Singh. They have alleged that the MLA and his associates threatened, intimidated and obstructed officials and workers at the road construction site in Vikaspuri over the past four days.

Later in the evening, AAP leaders Saurabh Bharadwaj and Kuldeep Kumar, accompanied by party supporters, reached Tilak Nagar and demanded the arrest of the minister and registration of an FIR. They also marched to the office of the deputy commissioner of police (DCP) in Janakpuri, where they were detained and taken to the Jafarpur Kalan police station in Outer Delhi.

Meanwhile, AAP leaders condemned the incident and demanded action against the minister. The party’s national convenor and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal said in a post on X: “A minister of Modi ji slapped a young man publicly for exposing corruption in road construction. I will go to Tilak Nagar tomorrow and inspect this road.”

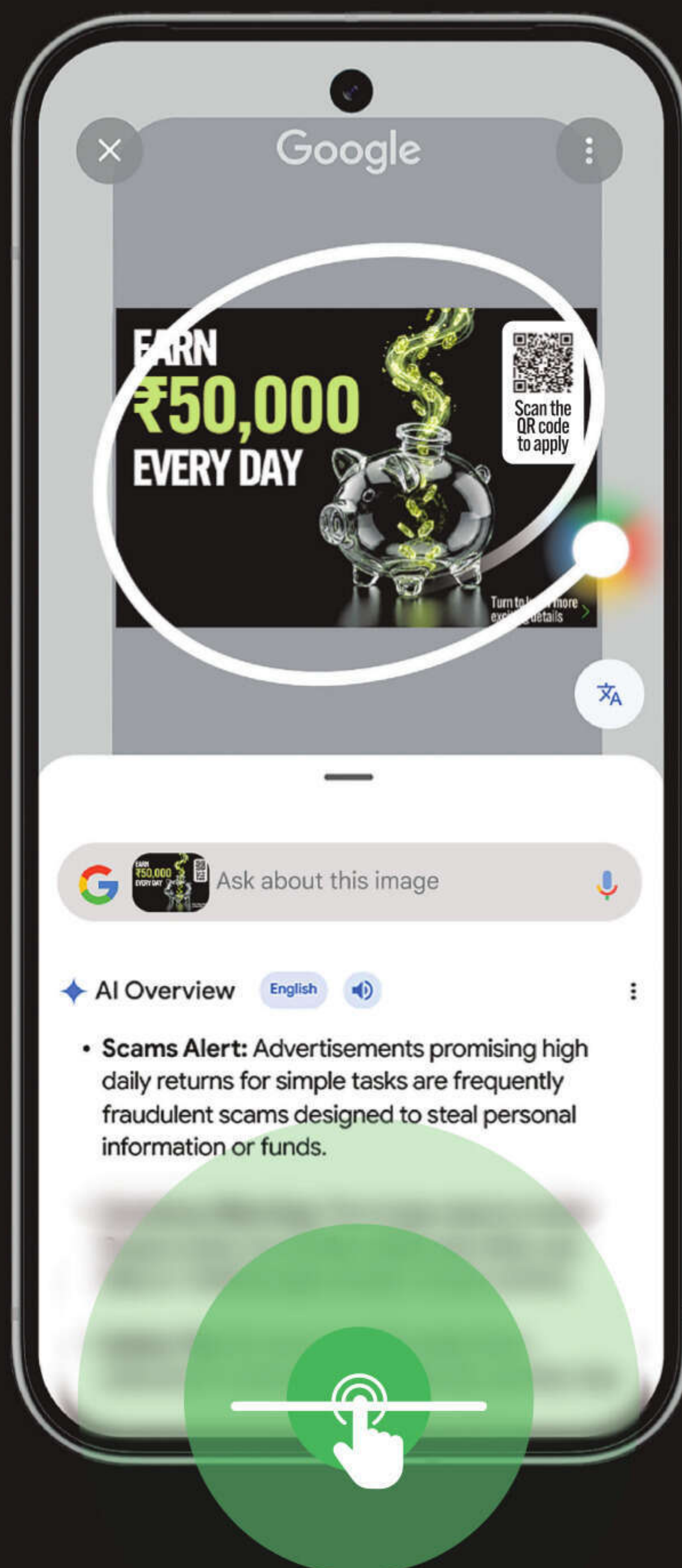
Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi also posted about the incident on X. “This is the face of a power that no longer fears the voters... These people do this because they no longer fear that elections can remove them. Vote theft buys this — not just the result, but the arrogance that follows. A government that takes victory for granted doesn’t need your consent — it demands your silence and blind devotion,” he said.

Does this offer sound unreal? It might just be.

How to spot a scam:

Step 1

Long press the
home button



Step 2

Circle to Search
over the suspicious
offer or SMS

Avoid scams with Circle to Search

Android 

 **DigiKavach**
Making India Safer with Google

Disclaimer: Internet connection required. Works on compatible apps, surfaces, and Circle to Search compatible devices. Results may vary depending on visual matches. Image simulated, actual may vary. Actual UX/UI and color may vary. Color and feature as per availability.

A gangrape at a Delhi park has put the safety of the Capital's parks under the spotlight. Reporting from six parks over two nights, PRAGYNESH and SOHINI GHOSH found dark corners, weak surveillance and gaps in security.

Delhi's Parks After Dark

Maidan Garhi Forest near IGNOU.
TASHI TOBGYAL

THE THREE gates were locked. Each was manned by two guards. A police van was stationed a few hundred metres away. None of it mattered.

At 10:30 pm on September 24, three men reached one of the steel gates of the Delhi Development Authority park in Hauz Khas, which had been closed since 8 pm. They climbed over it in seconds, disappearing into the darkness at a dead sprint.

Their sprint was cut short about 100 metres in, when two guards stopped one of them. "How did you enter the park? Who are you?" Guddu, one of the guards, asks.

With a curly head of hair and a lanky frame, one of the men responds, "We are Baljeet's friends. We are here to meet him."

As the men walk away after the cursory exchange, the guards quickly call Baljeet, a park staffer. He flatly denies knowing them. Guddu summons his colleagues, and a quick chase follows, but to no avail.

"This happens every night. If something happens now, we will be blamed. They will be hiding in some corner, smoking ganja, and then leave," says Guddu, who has been working the night shift at the park for over five years. Histone is one of helplessness. "We only have one stick to guard the entire park. What are we supposed to do if they pull out a knife?" he says.

The 149-acre district park has street lamps almost every 50 to 100 metres. The guards say patrolling in the park has increased over the past year. The reason: last year, a boy was found hanging from a tree inside the park. But there are darker corners, owing largely to the dense stretches of intermingled trees and shrubs. Night-time patrolling around parks, the guards point out, has become a necessity only recently, after a 17-year-old girl was gangraped by three men in Astha Kunj Park in southeast Delhi.

Still, a glaring security gap remains. Despite the lighting, the park-goers complain that the park does not have CCTV cameras in the vicinity to capture suspicious movements or illegal activity. "The park is mostly visited by students, including school children. They are vulnerable. If something happens to them inside the park, who will know? There is not a single CCTV camera in the vicinity," the guard says, sounding worried.

A brighter park, but little sense of safety

The park was lit up after Shradha Walkar's murder made headlines. Years later, it still has no guards or CCTV cameras, and park-goers say little else has been done to make it safer at night.

Maidangarhi Forest Park, built around a lake near IGNOU in South Delhi, is reached by a dark, unpaved path winding through wild keekars. Inside, the park is brightly lit.

A middle-aged woman, the only woman in the park, explains why. The lake was embanked and lights were installed after the 2022 Walkar case, in which Walkar was allegedly murdered by her live-in partner, who is accused of disposing of her body parts in the forest.

But the lighting has not brought real security. Park-goers say that even the police post just a few metres away does little to deter trouble.

On September 26, around 9 pm, Shivank, 25, a management professional from Neb Sarai, returned to the park for a walk after staying away for several months. Soon after he arrived, he noticed a group of men who appeared to be using drugs in an unlit part of the park. He walked over to the nearby police post and asked officers to intervene.

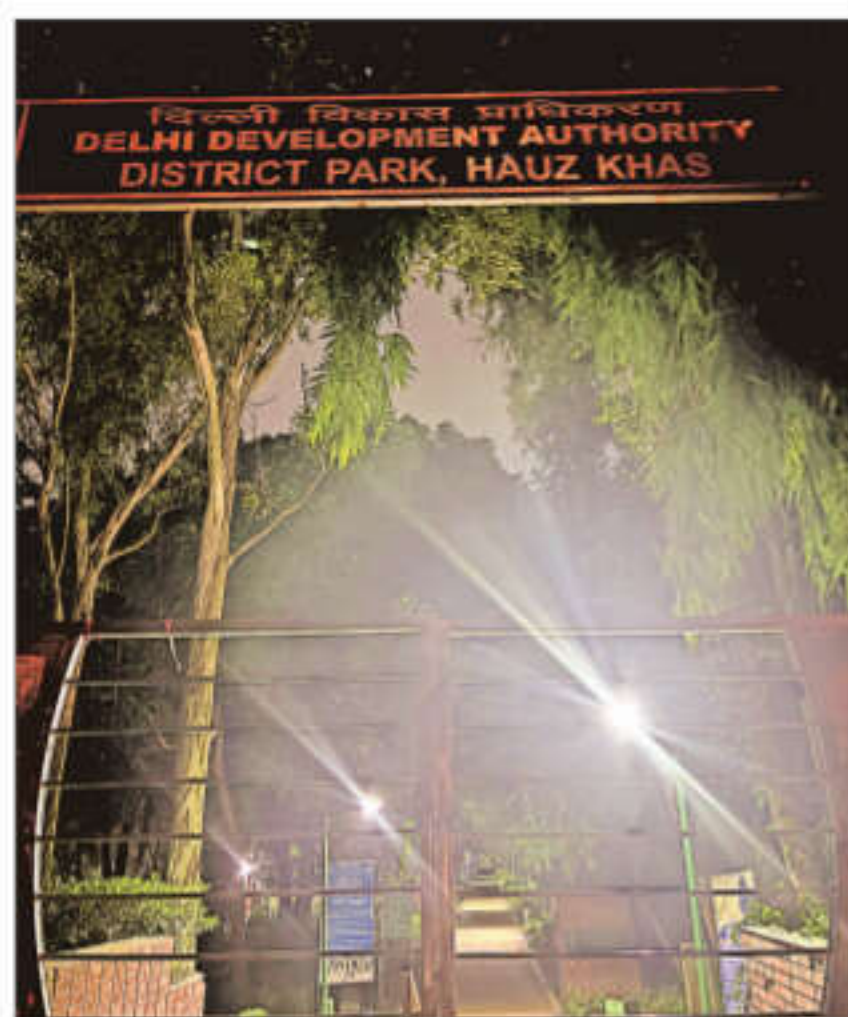
"There were men sitting on a bench, and I asked the police to ward them off," he said.

Vishal, who runs a horse stable next to the park, said he had grown used to scenes like this. "There are no guards. I warn young couples when they come at night not to stay long. Drunkards sit on the benches there," he said.

The security concerns are not confined to the park itself. On the road leading to the entrance, a man on a motorcycle stopped to offer a warning about phone snatchings.



Eidgah Hauz Rani Park.
TASHI TOBGYAL



Hauz Khas District Park.
PRAGYNESH



Bonta Park.
ABHINAV SAHA



Broken wall at the Ridge opposite Mutiny Memorial.
ABHINAV SAHA



Qudsia Bagh.
ABHINAV SAHA

"Don't take this path. It's not safe. Take the other one," he said. "My phone was snatched here. I never got it back," said Niranjana, a labourer who has lived in the area for more than a decade.

A park without guards, cameras

No guards. No cameras. Just teens, phones, and the dark.

At around 9 pm, Eidgah Hauz Rani Park, adjacent to Max Hospital in Saket, has no guards in sight, even as minors continue to use the park late into the evening.

On a Thursday night, a group of eight school students – five boys and three girls – had gathered in a dimly lit corner, absorbed in a heated game of PUBG on their phones. With no one around to keep watch, a cigarette was passed freely among the minors, smoke drifting through the darkness. Few street lamps illuminated the park, and there were no CCTV cameras or guards at its single entrance.

The only visible camera was mounted on a building in the adjoining Press Enclave colony. It appeared to cover only the farthest corner of the park, leaving much of the

grounds outside its view.

"We have been coming here for years. We come with friends, so it is safe for me. But I haven't seen any police or guards here," a 17 year old says.

Guards at the gates, dark spots beyond

On the other extreme of the city, Delhi University's North Campus – home to colleges including Hansraj, Ramjas and Hindu – sits beside the Northern Ridge.

At the expansive Bonta Park, the seven gates are shut by 7 pm. A guard is posted at each entrance, while CCTV feeds from the gates flicker across four screens in a makeshift room that doubles as a guard station. But there are no cameras covering the inside of the park, said Narender, one of the guards.

"Even after the gates are locked, students from the university sometimes climb over the walls and remain inside until 1 am," he said.

Lately, though, the park has grown quieter at night. "Fewer students have been slipping inside, particularly young women," Narender said. The rape reported at Astha

Kunj has unsettled the area.

"The Astha Kunj incident has been all over the news," Narender said. "We have also increased patrolling. If I see any students near the gate, I warn them that I will call the police."

As he spoke, three boys rode through the park on a motorcycle, their voices carrying across the grounds as they hooted loudly.

For some students, the unease extends beyond Bonta Park. Aranya Rathore, 25, a B.Ed. student at Shyama Prasad College in Punjabi Bagh, said she had stopped visiting parks around North Campus alone.

Rathore works with the Disha Foundation and frequently travels through the Vijay Nagar area, near the university. But she said she had begun avoiding the parks unless she was with a group of friends.

"I work with Disha Foundation, so I am in the Vijay Nagar area near North Campus a lot," she said. "But I have now started to avoid going to these parks unless I'm with a group of friends. Most of them are poorly lit."

However, the concerns go beyond poor lighting and late-night access.

Deepa, a master's student in the Department of History at Delhi University, recalled an incident in one of the parks near North Campus that took place in broad daylight.

"Most of the parks have bad lighting. In Hakeekat Park, two students were sexually harassed. Catcalling after hours is normal here," she alleged. She recalled visiting the park with a group of about 20 to 25 women at around 3 or 4 p.m. Even then, she said, a man approached them and began making comments.

The concerns also extend to public parks and open spaces around the paying guest accommodations where many women live.

"I live in the Mukherjee Nagar area. There are street lights here, and sometimes you also see PCR vans. But there are still multiple dark spots here. In a congested area like this, it still feels very unsafe to cross certain paths," a student at the Miranda House College in North Campus says.

The park was lit up after Shradha Walkar's murder made headlines. Years later, it still has no guards or CCTV cameras, and park-goers say little else has been done to make it safer

32 cameras, 18 lights: Delhi Police flags security gaps

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, September 27

DELHI POLICE has flagged gaps in CCTV coverage and lighting at several vulnerable parks and green spaces across the Capital following the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old girl at Astha Kunj Park in South Delhi, seeking additional cameras and lights and raising concerns over poor maintenance and access controls.

An on-ground assessment of vulnerable locations found surveillance and lighting

gaps at parks in North and South Delhi, including the Hauz Rani forest area, Bonta Park and Qudsia Bagh. Police have sought additional CCTV cameras, lights and other measures from civic and government agencies.

In the Hauz Rani forest area in South Delhi, there is currently no CCTV coverage. Delhi Police has written to the authorities concerned seeking installation of 32 cameras under the Safe City project.

Lights in the forest area have started functioning following the recent incident, but police found that only about 70% of the lights are currently working, a senior police officer said.

"We have also called for pruning of trees at certain stretches, saying overgrown foliage prevents existing lights from adequately illuminating parts of the area," a senior police officer said.

The assessment, sources said, also flagged concerns over the closing time of the forest area. "Although it is officially open until 8 pm, people are often found staying beyond the permitted hours despite being asked by police personnel to leave," a senior police officer said.

At Hauz Rani Idgah, beside Max Hospital, the park locally known as Jamun Wala Park has neither CCTV cameras nor lights. "Police have raised the issue with the authorities concerned and sought adequate CCTV coverage as well as measures to ensure proper manning of the park," a source said.

In North Delhi's Bonta Park, three CCTV cameras are currently installed and police have sought five additional cameras. "The park has three lights, with six more requested," a source said.

At Qudsia Bagh, two CCTV cameras are installed and police have sought seven additional cameras. "Two lights are currently installed, while 10 additional lights have been requested," a source said. Police have also flagged, the source said, inadequate lighting along the walking track and raised the matter with the agencies concerned.

The assessment comes against the backdrop of the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old girl at Astha Kunj Park in South

Delhi. The *Indian Express* reported that the portion of the park where the incident allegedly occurred had no CCTV coverage, while several cameras at the park gates were non-functional. The report also highlighted concerns over inadequate lighting.

Following the incident, senior Delhi Police officers have been conducting regular checks of vulnerable parks, isolated stretches and other such locations. Police officers are also in regular touch with civic agencies and other authorities, including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Development Authority and Forest Department, to address gaps in CCTV coverage, lighting, tree pruning and maintenance, a senior officer said.

At Congress march in Goa, message from voters: ‘Set aside egos and unite against BJP’

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Aldona, Panaji, September 27

ONE UNANIMOUS message reverberated among those gathered in Aldona at Congress’s “Goy Rakhonn Yatra (Save Goa March)”: the Opposition must keep “aside their egos” and unite against the BJP.

“All Opposition parties need to set aside together ... to fight against BJP and save Goa,” said Arthur D’Mello, a resident of Moira in North Goa’s Bardez taluka, during Yatra on Saturday.

The 27-day march began Wednesday and is scheduled to cover all 40 Assembly seats. Congress has projected the yatra as a campaign against BJP’s “misrule”, with land conversion, unemployment, and environmental degradation emerging as recurring concerns.

Earlier this month, the Goa Forward Party (GFP) and the AAP announced an alliance for elections under the banner “Goa First”. The two parties have reiterated that the alliance would remain “non-BJP, non-Congress” but have kept the “door open” for other like-minded parties. Congress has announced an “in-principle understanding” with the Revolutionary Goans Party (RGP) to contest polls.

For voters such as 68-year-

old Eusebio D’sa of Moira, the prospect of a divided Opposition is not ideal. “There is a lot of anti-incumbency. Unemployment and land conversions are biggest issues in Goa. Goans are selling their land to outsiders because they have no other option. Vast tracts of land are being indiscriminately converted under controversial pieces of legislation,” he said.

BJP emerged as the single-largest party in 2022 polls, winning 20 of 40 seats. Congress won 11. However, eight Congress MLAs subsequently joined BJP in September 2022, shrinking party’s strength to three.

“This defection of legislators from one party to its rival has to stop,” said Christopher Mendez, 66, a resident. D’Mello said “If an MLA defects, their membership of the Assembly should be cancelled. Anti-defection law has to ensure legislators do not switch sides overnight.” Mendez said, “People have given BJP almost three terms and we haven’t seen much of a difference in governance. The state’s ecology is being destroyed... hills are being cut.”

Congress’s Aldona MLA, Carlos Ferreira, said “What we have witnessed in the last 15 years of BJP rule... is destroying Goa. This is something that has touched the heart of every Goan.”

BJP, Opp cross swords over EC row

BJP CMs join fight: Cong, allies spread lies, weaken democracy

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 27

THE BJP on Sunday fielded its prominent CMs against LoP Rahul Gandhi and the INDIA bloc to counter “baseless allegations” questioning the impartiality of the Election Commission of India and expose their “conspiracy to malign the country’s constitutional institutions”.

This comes a day after EC’s statement on Saturday following *The Indian Express* investigation on notes of dissent by the two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, over SIR-related decisions taken by the poll panel.

BJP said despite the EC’s “point-by-point clarification on all the fabricated allegations levelled by the Opposition”, the Congress and its allies, “frustrated by their repeated electoral defeats, remain determined to undermine constitutional propriety in an attempt to conceal their failures”.

West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari said the Congress supports SIR in Kerala because it won there, but is opposing it in Bengal after losing the election. “If SIR is good in Kerala, why is it bad in West Bengal? We have won 208 seats, while the two sides (TMC and its allies) have 80. (Former CM) Mamata Banerjee is unable to accept the people’s verdict,” he said.

Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath accused Congress and its allies of weakening democratic institutions for political in-



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari in Kolkata, Sunday. PTI

terests and said they should apologise to the nation for their criticism of EC and SIR. Addressing reporters at his residence in Lucknow, Adityanath said, “The kind of uproar that Congress, SP, RJD and other parties have created over the SIR this time is extremely unfortunate.”

Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary said the Opposition was raising a “false alarm” over SIR. “No one questioned the deletion of 7 lakh voters during the SIR (in Bihar), and all objections raised by Congress and other political parties were addressed,” he said. “The problem with Rahul Gandhi and Tejashwi Yadav is they rarely present facts. They travel around Bihar like tourists.”

Launching a sharp attack on Gandhi, Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis said: “No votes have been stolen; Rahul Gandhi’s mind has been stolen.” He said the LoP wants to “malign institutions under the guise of defending the Constitution and create anarchy in the country”.

Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma described the INDIA bloc as an “alliance of defeated people”. Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami accused Congress of habitually fabricating a “narrative” to create confusion, only to be “exposed soon after”.

Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav said the LoP is “unable to manage his own party and family, and therefore, he has now resorted to spreading lies and confusion”.

Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai said the Congress, frustrated after losing more than 100 elections, has now resorted to “anti-national conduct”.

Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma said the Opposition was “spreading lies”. “Make allegations, but also provide the facts and basis for them,” he said.

Delhi CM Rekha Gupta said the Opposition was creating “this baseless controversy to divert attention from its failures, its betrayal of the country”.

Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini said the Opposition now has only one mission left: “Abuse PM Narendra Modi ji or insult constitutional institutions.” Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel hit out at the “double standards” of Congress. “Whenever they win elections, they talk about the victory of democracy and neutrality of EC, but when the mandate goes to BJP, they start singing false tunes of vote chori and irregularities.”

(INPUTS FROM KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, AHMEDABAD, PATNA, BHOPAL, RAIPUR, CHANDIGARH)

Congress: Rahul’s doubts proven true, piecemeal steps won’t work

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 27

STEPPING UP its attack on the Election Commission, Congress on Sunday said the poll panel’s proposed measures related to SIR are an admission that the exercise has been a “disaster” and asserted that the “piecemeal measures for deleted or at-risk voters will do little to mitigate this mass disenfranchisement”.

The poll panel on Saturday sought to address several concerns raised by its two commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi after *The Indian Express* reported the deep divide within the Election Commission over the SIR-related decisions taken over the last 10 months.

In a statement, Congress MP and communication in-charge Jairam Ramesh said: “The centrality of the ECINet software to the electoral roll preparation, its deletion of eligible voters and illegal override of EROs have not been denied. Nothing has been proposed to substantively address these issues.”

Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, speaking to reporters in Kerala Sunday, reiterated her demand for the immediate resignation of the CEC, alleging that he has political leanings and questioning how he could conduct fair elections.

CMs of states being ruled by Congress also targeted the poll panel, CEC Gyanesh Kumar in particular, asserting that the doubts raised by Rahul Gandhi



Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in Wayanad, Sunday. PTI

on the fairness of the poll panel stood vindicated.

Keralam CM V D Satheesan said that “everything stated earlier” by Rahul Gandhi “has now been proven true” and that CEC “has degraded Election Commission into a body operating in mutual collusion with the BJP”.

“His [CEC Gyanesh Kumar] continued presence in office will only further tarnish Indian democracy,” said Satheesan. “The revelations made by former Kerala Chief Secretary Jiji Thomson against CEC Gyanesh Kumar are extremely serious. No further evidence is required to prove that Gyanesh Kumar acted as an agent of the BJP... who subverted democracy on behalf of the BJP,” he added.

He said that “history will record” Gyanesh Kumar “as the person who pronounced a death sentence on Indian democracy... he should not remain in office for even a single moment”.

Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar said the concerns raised by

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and LoP Rahul Gandhi over alleged “vote theft” turned out to be true, and said the party would discuss its next course of action at the Congress Working Committee meeting on Tuesday. Speaking to reporters in Bengaluru, he said: “Whatever Rahul Gandhi and Kharge Sahab had said has now turned out to be true. I have come to discuss what our roadmap should be on this issue. The entire country has become aware of it. So, it is becoming clear that the elections were conducted with a lot of irregularities,” Shivakumar said.

CPI-M Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas wrote to the CEC, raising concerns over the EC’s clarification on Saturday and alleged that it raises “more questions than it answers”.

“If Form 6 is a statutory form prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, how can an additional mandatory declaration be introduced through an online portal without amending those Rules?” said Brittas.

He asked if the reported objections of two Election Commissioners to this change were true. “If so, how were the objections resolved, and was the Commission’s own prescribed decision-making procedure followed?” he asked.

“More importantly, what about citizens who could not even submit Form 6 online because they could not furnish the additional declaration?” said Brittas in a statement.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

NAIB SUBEDAR PRITHVI PAL SINGH (26TH MARCH 1987 – 25TH SEP 2026)
Fraternity of Army Educational Corps expresses profound grief on the sad demise of Naib Subedar Prithvi Pal Singh. He will always be remembered for his selfless and dedicated service to the Corps. We pray to the Almighty to bless eternal peace to the departed soul and give strength to the bereaved family.

MAJ GEN TAMOJEET BISWAS ADDL DG AE & HOS (AEC) AND ALL RANKS OF ARMY EDUCATIONAL CORPS

141 FIELD REGIMENT (KARGIL)

On the occasion of SHAHEEDI DIWAS of Capt KC Pritham Kumar of 141 Field Regiment (KARGIL) on 28 Sep 2026, the Commanding Officer, all ranks, their families and the veterans of the unit pay homage to the martyr who made the supreme sacrifice for the nation and endeared himself to all by his zest for life and bubbly enthusiasm. Upholding the highest traditions of the Indian Army, he laid down his life on 28 Sep 1997, while fighting against the odds in the highest battlefield of the world, Siachen, leaving a void which will never be filled. His valour & heroism continue to inspire all of us. On this day, we pledge to take the name of the Unit to even greater heights and glory in times to come.

CO & ALL RANKS OF 141 FIELD REGIMENT (KARGIL) BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Officers on their Balidan Diwas.

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CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

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DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to 5 valiant troopers of 54 Bn and 2nd Signal Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured while gallantly countering an attack by insurgents near Guwahati, Assam on 28 September 1998. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik Ram Lakhan of 84 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in an encounter with militants in Punjab on 28 September 1992. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Satpal of 196 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being seriously injured in an IED blast in Bijapur district, Chhattisgarh on 28 September 2022. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Rajesh Kumar of 209 CoBRA, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a series of IED blasts in West Singhbhum district, Jharkhand on 28 September 2023. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

In talks with US Congress delegation, Misri raises Russia, Iran sanctions Act

Divya A
New Delhi, September 27

AS INDIA continues to engage with the American side over the new Russia sanctions legislation, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Sunday met a bipartisan US Congressional delegation led by Chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee Representative Brian Mast. This comes days after External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met his US counterpart Marco Rubio and conveyed concerns over the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act.

In a post on X, Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Sunday: “Foreign Secretary @VikramMisri met a bipartisan US Congressional delegation led by Rep. @RepBrianMast, Chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee.” He said Misri held wide-ranging discussions with the delegation, including the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 and the future trajectory of India-US bilateral ties.

“Discussions covered the entire gamut of India-US relations, including the recently enacted SRIA legislation and the future



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri (extreme right) with a bipartisan US Congressional delegation led by Chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee, Representative Brian Mast, on Sunday. ANI

trajectory of the relationship. They also exchanged views on international issues of mutual concern, energy security, counter-terrorism and freedom of navigation,” the MEA spokesperson said.

For India, the new legislation creates a potential mechanism under which Washington could impose tariffs up to 100% on imports from countries that continue purchasing Russian energy. The legislation, however, does not automatically impose a 100% tariff on Indian goods.

On Friday, Misri held a series

of meetings in New York on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), with US Under Secretary of State for Economic Affairs Jacob Helberg and Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs Allison Hooker. “Great to meet Under Secretary of State for Economic Affairs Jacob Helberg in New York. Agreed to advance India-US cooperation in critical and emerging technologies, including through Pax Silica, and strengthen cooperation in semiconductor and critical minerals,” Misri said.

Anthology of essays for and against RSS ideology launched

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, September 27

BRINGING TOGETHER voices from both inside and outside the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), writer Leher Sethi’s book “*Saffron Shadows: The RSS, A Century of Influence*” was launched in Delhi on Sunday.

The book is an anthology of essays by Sangh ideologues as well as RSS critics. Compiled and edited by Sethi, who is also a social activist, the book comes in the centenary year of Sangh’s formation. The launch saw speakers who have served the RSS for as long as 80 years and those opposed to its ideology, including Rajya Sabha MP and Aam Aadmi Party leader Sanjay Singh.

While setting the context of the book, the publisher, Ajay Mago of Om Books International, said: “The timing of the book is significant, as the RSS is celebrating its 100th year. For some, the RSS represents cultural identity, discipline, ser-

vice, and an extraordinary organisational tradition; for others, it represents ideological influence on society and politics and institutions, raising serious questions about Indian democracy,” he said.

Speaking at the launch, journalist and editor of economic policy at *Moneycontrol*, Shweta Punj, said that the RSS is one of the most misunderstood organisations of the time. “It continues to be integral in today’s world even when other movements which started around the same time in India, like communism, are struggling to survive,” she said.

Sanjay Singh questioned the organisation’s inclusiveness and representation. Taking a dig at the recent row over Vande Mataram, Singh also questioned the alleged narrow definition of nationalism, stating that he sees the RSS as a small group’s organisation with a restricted mindset, trying to impose their ideology on everyone.

Polish PM Donald Tusk likely to visit in October; economic, strategic ties on table

Shubhajit Roy
Warsaw, New Delhi, Sept 27

POLAND’S PRIME Minister Donald Tusk is likely to visit India from October 21 to 24, sources have told *The Indian Express*. Tusk, who has served as the PM of Poland since 2023 and has held the office from 2007 to 2014, last visited India in September 2010 during then PM Dr Manmohan Singh’s tenure.

With Poland having emerged as one of the growing and significant economies of Europe and geopolitically at the forefront of the Russia-Ukraine war, Tusk’s visit is aimed at bolstering economic, political and strategic ties with India.

Tusk was European Council President from 2014 to 2019 and led the European People’s Party from 2019-22. He has been one of the early proponents of the EU trade deal, expected to be signed by December this year when PM Narendra Modi is expected to visit Brussels. Preparations are underway to schedule Polish PM’s trip to India next month, including visits to Delhi and Bangalore.

This will be a reciprocal visit by Tusk, more than two years after PM Modi visited Poland on August 21-22, 2024, on the occasion of the 70th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between India and Poland.

In the last few years, India and Poland have strengthened cooperation in defence and space sectors, and officials in Delhi and Warsaw are working



Polish PM Donald Tusk. @DONALDTUSK/X

towards concluding a series of outcomes in these strategic sectors during the Polish PM’s visit. Indian and Polish officials are also looking at cooperation and collaboration in developing port infra, shipbuilding and marine technology — and this is the connective tissue for a range of services, which can be of dual use, meant for both military and civilian use, sources said.

According to Poland’s Deputy Foreign Minister Wladyslaw Teofil Bartoszewski, the two sides are keen on moving Poland-India relations from strategic statements toward concrete cooperation in defence industry and supply-chain resilience. Bartoszewski, who met a delegation of Indian journalists in Warsaw, said Poland and India are “exploring joint production and common platforms rather than only bilateral sales” in defence equipment.

A group from India’s Ministry of Defence is expected to visit Warsaw in the coming weeks for a working group meeting with their Polish counterparts.

The writer was in Poland at the invitation of its government

Days after opposing ‘Tantra’, Mehbooba meets Mirwaiz

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 27

FORMER JAMMU and Kashmir CM and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti met Valley’s chief cleric and Hurriyat leader Mirwaiz Umar Farooq at his residence on Sunday.

The meeting came days after Mirwaiz, while responding to Mufti’s call, demanded an immediate ban on a “Tantra” event planned in Gurez. “Yes, Mehbooba ji visited me today. It was a good interaction,” Mirwaiz told *The Indian Express*.

“We had a conversation around the social, cultural and societal concerns and challenges facing us, and the need to address them in a concerted manner, taking all the stakeholders along,” he added.

Mirwaiz said the two leaders also discussed the “prevailing political situation in Jammu and Kashmir in some detail”.

“This is part of her series of follow-up interactions with Kashmir’s youth, scholars, women, stakeholders, artists, and social and political activists,” a senior PDP leader told *The India Express*.



ASHOK SINGHAL BIRTH CENTENARY: PRIME MINISTER PAYS HOMAGE

A life dedicated to nation-building



BY NARENDRA MODI

THERE IS a beautiful saying, “वृक्ष कबहुँ नहीं फल भूखे, नदी न संचे नीरा। परमारथ के कारने, साधुन धरा शरीरा।” It means the tree does not consume its own fruit, nor does the river retain its waters. Both exist for the benefit of others. Our saints and seers have long taught us that a life devoted to the welfare of those around us acquires a meaning far greater than individual achievement. If there is one person in whom this spirit was constantly reflected, it was Shri Ashok Singhal-ji.

Starting September 27, we mark his birth centenary to celebrate an outstanding personality who brought together spiritual pursuit, cultural awakening and decades of dedicated organisational work. I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok-ji and receive his affection. One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young karyakarta going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him. Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me. He talked about an important upcoming programme and gave a few tasks to be done.

Over several decades, I saw him work day and night. He would undertake long and often difficult travels to the remotest of areas. He was particularly passionate about travelling across tribal areas of Gujarat. His mind was con-

stantly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society. Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok-ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding karyakartas to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable.

This spirit of compassion and care for others is something that came to Ashok-ji very early in his life. He hailed from a very illustrious and prosperous family. His father, Shri Mahavir-ji, was a distinguished administrator. One of his brothers, Shri BP Singhal-ji, went on to become a police officer and later a Member of Parliament. Another brother, Shri VP Singhal-ji, was the Chief Secretary of Tripura when the state was just formed. Other family members succeeded in the world of commerce and agriculture. But from a young age, Ashok-ji was attracted to something else altogether...the revival of Bharat and bringing glory to Maa Bharti's children. Growing up in Prayagraj, Ashok-ji would sit for hours on the banks of the Sangam. The



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Ashok Singhal. FILE

river naturally interested him, but so did the people who came, such as saints, seers and devotees. It nurtured an understanding of India's cultural ethos and strengthened his intention to do something for society. This desire to live for others drew him to the RSS. He embraced every responsibility that came his way with enthusiasm, discipline and a sense of duty.

Ashok-ji nurtured institutions and movements through persistence and hard work. He was blessed with a formidable

voice and an oratory that could hold an entire gathering in its spell. Equally noteworthy was his care for fellow karyakartas. Anyone who came into contact with him could not help but marvel at

his remarkable simplicity. He shared a deep bond with the Sant Samaj and commanded immense respect among saints and seers across the country. They valued his counsel and listened to him with great regard.

My mind goes back to two instances which brought out the legendary persona of Shri

Ashok Singhal-ji. The first was in 1993, when the Vishwa Hindu Parishad organised a convention in the US to mark 100 years since Swami Vivekananda's Chicago address. The vision to host such a conference overseas, the planning and the bringing together of diverse stakeholders revealed the organisational genius of Ashok-ji.

The second instance is from the year 2000. The World Hindu Conference was organised in Port of Spain in Trinidad and Tobago. I could see how his presence ignited so much enthusiasm among other delegates. After my address, his words of appreciation were a very moving experience for me. I saw yet again how his encouragement filled every karyakarta with so much energy.

No mention of Ashok-ji is complete without recalling his pivotal role in the Ram Janmabhoomi Movement. Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991? Or, the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok-ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible. He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya.

Shri Ashok Singhal-ji was blessed with remarkable clarity of thought and one area where it was clearly seen was his belief that our society needs to be harmonious, that the message of brotherhood has to be reaffirmed. He worked towards strengthening social unity and equality. He firmly believed that there could be no distinction of any kind in society and that every individual deserved

equal dignity and respect. It was his thought that the first brick of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya would be laid by Shri Kameshwar Choupal-ji, a grass-roots VHP karyakarta from Bihar who hailed from the marginalised sections of society. At a Dharm Sansad in Kashi, he decided that the Dom Raja would be honoured and went on to work with him as part of various community efforts.

Beyond nation-building, Shri Ashok Singhal-ji had two areas that were very close to his heart: Education (especially Vedice education) and music. As the MP from Varanasi, I feel very proud that the city I represent, the eternal Kashi, has played its part in Ashok-ji's life. He was educated at BHU and was also known to be a good student. He was closely associated with the Ekal Vidyalaya initiative, which worked to extend basic education to remote villages, especially among tribal communities. He was a voracious reader as well as a good listener and he always told younger karyakartas to read as much as possible.

Those who knew Ashok-ji closely knew how well he sang. I recall meetings in Nagpur, where he would sing the Ekal Geet, leaving everyone mesmerised and setting the tone for the meeting. A video of him surprising everyone and singing “हे मातृभूमि मेरी, हे पिताभूमि मेरी” during his 90th birthday celebrations in 2015 went viral.

On his birth centenary, let us ensure that more youngsters know about his greatness. And let us renew our pledge to realise his dreams for our nation and our people.

Narendra Modi is the Prime Minister of India

‘Non-negotiable’ issues: Former ED officer quits Amritpal’s party after four days

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, September 27

FORMER ED deputy director Niranjan Singh on Sunday “disassociated” himself from the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De citing “non-negotiable differences” on some issues, four days after he joined the jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh-led party.

“I disassociate myself from the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De. I had given my support on the issue of drug menace in Punjab, high corruption, gangsters, extortion and involvement of police personnel in drug trafficking but there are differences on some issues which are non-negotiable. The conduct of persons in public life has to be within the Constitution of India,” Niranjan Singh said in a post on his Facebook page.

Niranjan Singh, who had in the past often accused the traditional parties in Punjab of inaction on drug smugglers, joined the Akali Dal WPD on September 23. The outfit is yet to be registered as a political party.

Niranjan Singh told *The Indian Express* that while he would not like to pinpoint any individual as the reason for leaving the party, “the Constitution of India was supreme” for him. “Whatever has to be done, it has to be within the limits of the Constitution, which is supreme. That is simply non-negotiable.”

Meanwhile, Ayali, said: “It is his own free will (to leave party). He only had expressed his wish to join us. He may be under some pressure now. I am not aware of exact issue. We had no disagreement. He did not discuss it with me before taking the decision.”

Release Ladakh firing inquiry report, drop cases: Wangchuk

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 27

A YEAR after four people were killed in police firing during protests in Ladakh, climate activist Sonam Wangchuk Sunday demanded the release of the report of the judicial inquiry into the violence, higher compensation for victims' families and withdrawal of criminal cases against those who, he said, were not involved in the violence.

In a statement marking one year since the September 24, 2025, violence, Wangchuk said the families of those killed were still waiting for answers and questioned the delay in releasing the report of the judicial inquiry headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice B S Chauhan.

“Almost a year later, Ladakh is still waiting for its findings,” Wangchuk said, asking who ordered the firing, whether due procedures for crowd control had been exhausted before live ammunition was used and whether the deaths could have been avoided. Four people were killed in police firing during the protests, while Wangchuk's statement said another person died by suicide and scores were injured. It also said several people were arrested and charged with serious offences.



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk in New Delhi, Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA

Wangchuk said the compensation of Rs 15 lakh announced by the Ladakh administration for the next of kin of each of the four people killed was inadequate. Acknowledging that no monetary compensation could make up for the loss of a life, he demanded that compensation be raised to a “respectable and dignified amount.”

The activist also raised questions about his detention under the NSA following the protests. Wangchuk was detained on September 26, 2025, and sent to Jodhpur Central Jail, where he said he remained for nearly six months. His detention order was revoked on March 14, 2026, while it was being challenged before the Supreme Court.

“If I really was such a danger to national security or public

order that I had to be taken away from Ladakh and kept under the NSA, then why am I free today?” Wangchuk asked, saying if he was not such a danger, there should be accountability for six months he spent in detention.

Wangchuk questioned the continued prosecution of people arrested following the violence. As per his statement, 87 people were identified as accused and 81 arrested and faced criminal proceedings. The administration has approved withdrawal of cases against 20 people, he said, but asked what happens to the remaining. He said while those against whom there was credible evidence of violence should face the law, cases against those who were merely present at protests or had attempted to calm the situation should be reviewed.

Facing backlash, Vijay govt withdraws Law and Order dept’s RTI exemption

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, September 27

HOURS AFTER its decision to shield the Public (Law and Order) Department from RTI Act triggered criticism from allies and transparency activists, the C Joseph Vijay-led Tamil Nadu government on Sunday revoked the order, marking yet another reversal by a government that has made transparency and accountability central to its anti-corruption pitch.

“GO Ms.No.57 of Human Resources Management (R) Department dated 21st September, 2026, relating to exemption of the Public (Law and Order) Department under sub-section (4) of Section 24 of the RTI Act, 2005, stands revoked,” the government said.

The reversal came after the government order surfaced publicly on Sunday morning.

CPI(M) MP Su Venkatesan was among those who criticised the decision. The original order had specified the Public (Law and Order) Department as an intelligence and security organisation established by the TN government, bringing it within the exemption provided under Section 24 of the RTI Act.

The withdrawal also adds to a pattern of policy reversals under the relatively new TVK



Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay in Chengalpattu district. PTI FILE

government. Government insiders describe some of these episodes as part of a tactical approach in which contentious decisions are allowed into the public domain before the administration gauges political and public response and decides whether to persist with them. The government has not publicly described the RTI episode in those terms.

The Human Resources Management Department had issued the government order invoking Section 24(4) of the Right to Information Act, 2005, which allows state governments to exempt intelligence and security organisations established by them.

“The Governor of Tamil Nadu hereby specifies the Public (Law and Order) Department being an Intelligence and

Security Organisation established by the Government of Tamil Nadu for which the said Act shall not apply,” the now-revoked notification said.

The decision had attracted attention because the department is not merely concerned with intelligence inputs or classified security operations. Its responsibilities extend across areas involving police conduct, civil liberties, political activity and government accountability.

Among other subjects, it examines inquiry reports into deaths in police custody, allegations of police torture and deaths of remand prisoners, as well as inquiries into police firing. The department deals with communal and caste clashes and political agitations, and with requests for the withdrawal of cases registered in connection with them.

Reacting to the original decision, Arappor Iyakkam, Tamil Nadu's prominent anti-corruption movement, had said it was “shocking” that the state government had exempted the Law and Order wing of the Public Department from the RTI Act. “It is absurd to classify all information held by the Public Department's Law and Order wing as intelligence-related. The Tamil Nadu government must immediately withdraw this order. It is

condemnable to claim that you are bringing in transparency while acting in a manner that runs directly contrary to it,” the statement said.

A senior police officer who retired as the state DGP told *The Indian Express* that the decision directly contradicted CM's anti-corruption campaign. “Fighting corruption should not be understood simply as punishing someone after wrongdoing has occurred. Bringing transparency to the system is what helps to end corruption. The latest decision is a setback to that principle, particularly because policing requires greater public scrutiny, not less,” he said.

VCK chief and MP Thol Thirumavalavan, whose party supports TVK government, had called the announcement “highly shocking”. “It will pave the way for suppressing human rights. Therefore, we strongly urge the government to immediately withdraw it.”

The Law & Order Department handles preventive detention under the Conservation of Foreign Exchange and Prevention of Smuggling Activities Act (COFEPOSA) and NSA. Its work includes representations made by detainees and habeas corpus pleas filed by them or on their behalf before the Madras HC and the Supreme Court.

● THE TOP TWO: 76-DAY ADJOURNMENT IN 1987 AND A 61-DAY STRETCH IN 1989 OVER BOFORS SCANDAL

46 days & counting: Monsoon Session is 3rd-longest *sine die* adjournment in history

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, September 27

AT 46 DAYS and counting, the Eighth Session of the 18th Lok Sabha has acquired the distinction of witnessing the third-longest *sine die* adjournment in history, Parliament records show. While the two longest adjournments came during previous Congress governments, this is the longest that Parliament has been adjourned since the BJP-led NDA government first came to power in 2014.

The Monsoon Session began on July 20 and was adjourned *sine die* on August 13. Unlike prorogation, which formally ends a session, an adjournment *sine die* ends the sitting without fixing a date for the House to meet again.

The 2023 Monsoon Session was held from July 21 to August 21, with 21 sittings, and the House was prorogued the following day. The prolonged adjournment comes after a session marked by repeated disruptions over several issues, including NEET paper leak, alleged theft at Ram temple and demands for Union Home Minister Amit Shah to respond to action on youth protesters.

The continued non-prorogation of the House has also fuelled speculation about the possibility of a fresh sitting in October. Political debate has centred on the numbers required for a constitutional amendment linked to delimitation and women's reservation. Claims about the government's

plans, however, are speculative rather than based on established parliamentary decisions.

Under the NDA government, before this, the longest session went without getting prorogued after being declared adjourned *sine die* is longer than the 28-day period between August 12, 2015 and September 10, 2015, and the 20-day period between August 11 and August 31, 2021.

According to *Practice and Procedure of Parliament* by MN Kaul and SL Shakdher, a House may be adjourned from day to day, for more than a day, or *sine die* during a session.

An adjournment postpones the sitting of the House to another time. When a House is adjourned *sine die*, no date is fixed for its next sitting. The sit-

● ADJOURNMENT HISTORY

Period of Adjournment	Total days
12 May 1987 till 27 July 1987	76 days
18 August 1989 till 11 October 1989 & 13 October 1989 till 20 October 1989	61 days
22 December 1950 till 5 February 1951	45 days
11 December 1962 till 21 January 1963	41 days
13 August 2015 till 10 September 2015	28 days
7 August 1975 till 3 September 1975	27 days
28 August 1993 till 23 September 23	26 days
7 September 1990 till 1 October 1990	24 days
5 September 1988 till 30 September 1988	25 days
16 December 1988 to 5 January 1989	20 days
11 August 2021 till 31 August 2021	20 days
16 July 1979 till 3 August 1979	18 days

PRACTICE AND PROCEDURE OF PARLIAMENT BY M N KAUL AND S L SHAKDHER

ting has ended, but the session itself has not necessarily been terminated.

Prorogation is different. Under Article 85(2) of the Constitution, a session of Parliament is formally terminated by an order of the President. Ordinarily, prorogation follows an adjournment *sine die*, although the two are legally distinct.

The President exercises the power to prorogue Parliament on the advice of the PM.

The Speaker can call a sitting of LS before the date to which it has been adjourned, or at any time after the House has been adjourned *sine die*. This means that an adjournment *sine die* does not, by itself, prevent the House from being reconvened. The two longest *sine die* ad-

journments in LS history occurred during the Eighth Lok Sabha. The longest, lasting 76 days, occurred in 1987 during the Eighth Session of the Eighth Lok Sabha, against the backdrop of Bofors controversy. The second-longest, lasting 61 days, occurred in 1989 during the Fourteenth Session of the same Lok Sabha.

The Eighth Session began on February 23, 1987, and was adjourned *sine die* on May 12 amid disruptions over Bofors. The Speaker exercised the power under the proviso to Rule 15 to reconvene the House from July 27 to August 28. The session continued for several months despite the long gap between sittings. The LS adopted a motion on August 6 to constitute a 30-member JPC to inquire into

the Bofors deal. The RS adopted a corresponding motion on August 12. LS was prorogued on September 3, 1987, bringing the session to an end after the 76-day intervening adjournment.

The Fourteenth Session of the Eighth Lok Sabha began on July 18, 1989, and was adjourned *sine die* on August 18.

The period was marked by another major political confrontation involving Bofors. Around 100 Opposition MPs resigned en masse after a CAG report on the deal was tabled. The Speaker again reconvened the House from October 11 to 16. The House was adjourned *sine die* on October 13 and prorogued on October 20. The intervening period between sittings amounted to 61 days.

MANN KI BAAT

PM: Surgical strikes, Op Sindoor bold examples of India's counter-terror policy

Express News Service
Lucknow, September 27

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday said that India today pursues a zero-tolerance policy against terrorism, and over the past decade — from the Balakot airstrike to Operation Sindoor — India has sent a clear message that if terrorists dare to cast an evil eye on India, they will be met with a befitting response.

In his monthly radio address Mann Ki Baat, the PM called the surgical strikes a major and historic achievement of India. “Ten years ago, on September 28-29, 2016, the Indian Army carried out surgical strikes on terrorist hideouts in Pakistan. The world was astonished to see the manner in which our brave soldiers crossed the Line of Control (LoC) to take action against terrorism,” the PM said, adding that the surgical strikes boldly demonstrated to the entire world a new example of India's counter-terrorism policy.

The PM said the ‘surgical strike’ was our decisive response to the long-standing pain India had endured due to terrorist attacks. “Over the past decade — from the Balakot airstrike to Operation Sindoor — India has repeatedly sent a clear message — if terrorists dare to cast an evil eye on India, they will be met with a befitting response.”

The PM referred to the Delhi

serial blasts of September 2008 and the Mumbai 26/11 attack, saying there was a time when serial blasts had become a common occurrence in the country.

“Friends, in the past too, there used to be demands for action against Pakistan following every terror attack, but such calls were often not given due attention; time to pass by was simply awaited. Today, India pursues a zero-tolerance policy against terrorism, and we are witnessing the results of that,” Modi said.

The PM in his message extended his condolences to bereaved families of those killed in the 9/11 terror attack on the World Trade Center in the US. He said that the highest number of casualties — after Americans — were those of Indians.

Referring to the ongoing Census exercise, the PM said a grand picture of the nation is currently emerging and the first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all states and Union Territories. Data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded, and work is underway in remote, snow-clad regions of Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, and Uttarakhand, the PM said.

Calling the Census exercise a national responsibility, the PM urged citizens to self-enumerate online to ensure accurate data for planning the nation's future.

Clash at Kolkata film institute over RSS-linked outfit's event

SRFTI student union says several were injured

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, September 27

CLASHES ERUPTED at Kolkata's Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) on Sunday afternoon after a group of students objected to a right-wing group's event on the campus, leaving several injured.

Tensions continued till late at night as police cordoned off the campus. Earlier, a large number of police personnel were deployed as the students locked the gate of the campus with a protesting mob outside.

Established in 1995, the SRFTI is India's second national centre for cinema education. It comes under the Information and Broadcasting Ministry.

The students' union of the SRFTI said that when they objected to the programme organised by the Akhil Bharatiya Grahaak Panchayat (ABGP), an RSS-linked outfit, they were allegedly assaulted and called “anti-nationals”, leading to a scuffle.

“Members of the ABGP attacked students, including women students, with stones and bricks. Students were chased through the campus, including students who were not part of the protest. Several students took shelter inside the library. The group followed them



Police deployed following a clash at SRFTI in Kolkata, Sunday. EXPRESS

there, and the librarian was also assaulted. The library was surrounded, leaving students and staff in a situation of fear inside their own institute,” the students' union said in a statement.

The students alleged that a mob from outside tried to barge into the campus and threw stones and bottles inside. Students were seen carrying pictures of B R Ambedkar as they locked the campus gates. “We had just gone to tell them to remove the banners, but they abused us, called us jihadis, Naxals, and terrorists. They assaulted us. Around 15 of us have been injured,” said a student.

According to official sources, the ABGP had booked the auditorium on the campus for an “awareness” programme. The ABGP had installed banners and festoons around the campus,

leading to a conflict. “It began as a verbal spat after a group of students from the college objected to the banners and allegedly tore them down,” said an official.

Basudeb Paul, a member of ABGP, said, “We were holding the programme when the students came and started to tear the banners and festoons. They stepped on the posters of Bharat Mata and Swami Vivekananda. We told them to stop tearing the banners. They abused our PM and CM, and started shouting slogans against the BJP. This was completely pre-planned. These people want to turn SRFTI into another Jadavpur.” After the police entered, they held talks with the students and also allowed organisers to leave the campus.

Meanwhile, several local BJP

leaders reached the institute and held protests outside, demanding the arrest of students. The crowd outside the campus gate also stopped the ambulance, carrying the injured students. The police had to intervene to clear the way for the ambulance.

Debanjan Dey, the state secretary of the SFI, said, “The way RSS attacked the JU, in the same manner they are attacking SRFTI now. No one knows how the RSS-backed outfit got permission to hold the event on Sunday. This is a systematic terror. Each and every free-thinking institution is being attacked.” Speaking to mediapersons, BJP MP Rahul Sinha said, “By creating such a chaos, they are trying to bring a bad name to West Bengal. Such acts will not be tolerated.”

Debjit Sarkar, BJP chief spokesperson posted on social media, “A group of Urban and ‘dimagi Naxals’ stormed the venue, raised ‘Go back RSS’ slogans, tore down posters and, as the video shows, and stormed on posters bearing images of Bharat Mata and Swami Vivekananda. And yet, these ‘Naxals’ are now playing the victim. This has become a familiar pattern. For how long will such disrespect for Bharat Mata and Swami Vivekananda be tolerated?”

RSS students' outfit, the ABVP, however, distanced itself from the incident. “The ABVP is not associated with this matter. Whatever has happened there, the police will investigate,” said ABVP state in-charge Ananta Barui.



Officials collect samples from the spot where (right) Bhavik and Prabhakar were found dead. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE



Two men die inside public toilet in Mumbai after suspected gas leak

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, September 27

TWO MEN died after allegedly being exposed to a strong chemical smell inside a public toilet in Mumbai's eastern suburbs early on Sunday.

According to Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) officials, the incident occurred in Ram Mandir (East).

BMC officials identified the men as Prabhakar Dhanivar, 24, and Bhavini Desai, 18. They were taken to Trauma Care Hospital around midnight and were declared dead at 3.49 am, according to doctors at the hospital.

Local residents alerted the authorities after noticing a strong chemical odour coming from the public toilet and reported that two people had suffered suffocation.

The Vranai police have registered an accidental death report and are awaiting post-mortem report to establish exact cause of death.

tem report to establish exact cause of death.

“Prima facie, it looks like gas emitted by a small-scale industrial unit near the toilet might have come in contact with the two individuals,” a police officer said. BMC officials said the incident was reported to the authorities at around 8.30 am, following which teams from the fire brigade, police, 108 ambulance services, Maharashtra Pollution Control Board and BMC ward staff were mobilised and sent to the spot.

Officials were expected to examine toilet premises and ascertain the source of the smell. The Dhanivar and Desai families have demanded strict action against those responsible.

“We found both of them unconscious in the bathroom, their lips had turned black... We demand strict action against those involved,” said Prabhakar Dhanivar, brother of Prabhakar.

Man held for harassing woman at nightclub of 5-star hotel in Kolkata

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, September 27

A 24-YEAR-OLD man was arrested on Sunday for allegedly physically assaulting a 20-year-old woman and using obscene language at the nightclub of a five-star hotel along the EM Bypass in Kolkata, police said.

The accused, identified as Mohammad Rafe Azim, was arrested from his residence in the Beniapur police station area, they said.

According to police, the incident took place at 2 am when the woman and her friends were allegedly physically assaulted and subjected to abusive language by the accused and his associates.

Pragati Maidan Police Station registered a case under BNS

sections: 74 (assault or criminal force to woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 79 (word, gesture or act intended to insult modesty of a woman), 115 (2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 126 (2) (wrongful restraint) and 54 (abetment of offence).

“The woman had gone to the nightclub with some friends, and around 2 am, a man and some others accompanying him allegedly blocked their way. He also physically assaulted her and used obscene language. Thereafter, he fled the spot,” the complainant alleged, police said.

“...police team traced the accused and arrested him from Tiljala, under Beniapur police station area, on Sunday. Probe is underway.” Additional CP (Crime) Kunal Agarwal said.

Bastar floods worsen, over 1,200 rescued, 9,200 moved to safety

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 27

THE INDRAVATI river in Chhattisgarh's Bastar region witnessed severe flooding after heavy rain triggered by cyclonic storm ‘Arnab’ and the opening of gates of the Khatiguda and Muran dams in neighbouring Odisha. At least one person died of drowning, said a senior official.

The flooding followed continuous heavy rain between September 23 and 26 under the influence of cyclonic storm ‘Arnab’, which developed over the Bay of Bengal. The opening of gates of the Khatiguda and Muran dams in Odisha also contributed to the rise in the Indravati's water level.

By Sunday morning around 6 am the river reportedly crossed its danger mark of 8.3 metres by a wide margin, reaching a peak level of 12.39 metres causing severe waterlogging and distress in low-lying areas. The water level has gradually started receding since Sunday morning providing some relief to the administration and residents.

“Due to the incessant rainfall water has been inundated on the national highway cutting off districts like Bijapur, Sukma from Jagdalpur city. Several buses on the Raipur-Jagdalpur national highway have got stranded because of the rains,” said an offi-



16 civilians were airlifted by the Indian Air Force. PIB

cial. “Several villages in Bastar region across the seven districts have got cut off due to the rains,” said a government official from Jagdalpur. As many as 1,215 people have so far been rescued from flooded and inaccessible areas by district administration, State Disaster Response Force and disaster management teams. Of those rescued, 16 civilians, including women and children, were airlifted by Indian Air Force, while 1,203 people were brought to safety using rescue boats and other boats.

The district administration has set up 65 relief camps, where more than 9,200 people are currently staying.

‘Why govt with companies, not us?’: At Gujarat protest, farmers booked for burning PM's effigy

Brendan Dabhi
Morbi, September 27

MORE THAN a week after the Gujarat Police booked 21 protesting farmers here after effigies of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah were burnt by them on the PM's birthday on September 17, no notices have gone out or any further action taken.

But, anger over the issue behind the protests simmers. On Friday, over 9,000 farmers held a dharna at the Morbi Collectorate, joined by their counterparts from other districts.

The latest round of protests has been sparked by notices served, on September 23, to all landowners who either have transmission towers or line corridors of a 765 kV Halvad Transmission Line and an 800 kV Transmission Line passing through or over their fields. The notices asked them to appear within two days before a Market Rate Committee (MRC) at the Collectorate, to nominate the valuer for their land, or the government would do it for them.

For farmer leaders, this fit a pattern they have been protesting against since July: of the State forcing their hand to take part in the compensation process for the transmission lines, on a percentage decided by it. The protest has brought work on laying the power lines to a halt. They also claim that many of the 21 booked on September 17 were not even present where the ef-



Farmers protest at Satyagrah Chhavlani in Morbi. BHUPENDRA RANA

figies were burnt. The case has been transferred to the Morbi Police's Local Crime Branch.

It began as a protest in Jetpar, largely against the 765-kV transmission line being set up by Halvad Transmission Limited, a Special Purpose Vehicle owned by Adani Energy Solutions. Now, it has burgeoned into a protest against all planned transmission lines by companies in Morbi, and against the compensation policy — through MRCs.

Farmers said the September 23 notices also covered the 800-kV line being put up by Power Grid Corporation of India, which was a first. “We called every man, woman and child to protest at the Collectorate,” says Nehul Dhirajlal Amrutia, one of the young leaders of the agitation. His farm, on the edge of Jetpar and Nava Devaliya villages, has been dug up for a tower for the 765-kV transmission line.

While several such towers stretch into the distance here,

the power lines are missing in parts, as farmers hold out.

On the compensation formula, Nehul says, “It is 200% of the value of the area occupied by a tower base and 30% of that of the area under a RoW (Right of Way) corridor... But this does not cover the entirety of losses for farmers.” Apart from more compensation, he adds, “We are suggesting that the power lines go through the Little Rann of Kutch (which is sparsely populated). And if that is not possible in certain districts, the lines be put underground. You can't aim for a cheaper project at the cost of farmers.”

After the latest notice, farmers have raised another issue — that of time — saying two days to appear before officials is not enough, particularly for those landowners settled outside, including abroad.

Nehul asks what the government's “hurry” is. “It is the business plan of a company, the

compensation is to be paid by the company, then why is the government in their favour and not in that of the farmers?”

The fears and allegations are unfounded, says Morbi Collector Swapnil Khare. “The purpose of the September 23 notices was just to inform the farmers that the process is on. The valuation won't be done in a day. Once the valuers are nominated, 21 days will be given for valuation. Those who are not able to come will get another chance to appear.”

On how many farmers in total are affected, the Collector says he does not have the exact number, as the issue involves different firms and many villages. However, the compensation process has been crawling, he admits. “We have set up seven MRCs and conducted the valuation of 102 survey numbers, with 44 farmers paid.”

While Gujarat Energy Minister Rushikesh Patel remained unavailable for comment despite several attempts, Morbi's six-time MLA Kantilal Shival Amrutia, also a MoS, says the farmers may be protesting, “but as per the new resolutions, they will get three times as much (compensation) than earlier”.

At Juna Devaliya village, 12 km east of Jetpar, Vinod Bavai Aghara was among those whose land was one of the first to be surveyed. A 765-kV tower was erected on his land in 2025, with the caveat that he would reserve his objections, he claims. The tower and power line corridor

go through 10 out of Agahar's 42 bighas of land, planted with groundnut, pomegranates and castor. Aghara, who was one of the winners of the Krushi Na Rushi Award in 2011 — for his “progressive farming techniques” — claims the value of his land has “fallen... from Rs 55-60 lakh to less than half”.

There are other fears. At Nichi Mandal village, on Morbi-Halvad road, Naval Narbheram Kundariya filed a complaint on August 26 seeking legal action over damage done to the land and standing crops of farmers in the village after a live high-tension line collapsed on it.

Farmers say neither of these complaints has been converted into FIRs. Inspector NS Ghetya of Morbi Taluka police station said that diary entries had been made in the complaints, and the same forwarded to the transmission company concerned for further action.

One striking feature of the protest has been the presence in it of Ratilal Shival Amrutia, the brother of MLA Kantilal Amrutia. Ratilal says, “We are not against a political party, but against those in the government who are responsible for this issue. We are only fighting for the farmers. Jetpar is my ancestral home...”

However, MoS Kantilal rules out any change in the route of the power transmission lines. “If they want, the first tower can be put up on my land itself,” the MoS says.

Police deny CJP permission to protest at Shivaji Park on Oct 2

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, September 27

MUMBAI POLICE have denied CJP permission for its October 2 protest at Shivaji Park against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in the wake of *The Indian Express* report on objections by two Election Commissioners to decisions taken by the EC without their knowledge. CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said they will do a “Jail Bhara Andolan” if police tried to stop them.

Dipke said on X, “Mumbai Police has denied permission for our protest on October 2. Such tactics to suppress citizens' voices are unacceptable.”

According to Dipke, they had approached the Shivaji Park police station for permission to protest at Shivaji Park ground, but police denied it, citing that the ground is meant for gatherings and not protests.

Dipke said, “They tried to give us a written rejection notice but we refused to accept that.” Dipke had announced a nationwide protest on October 2 following the *Express* report.

In the letter issued on Sunday, police cited a 2013 Bombay HC order restricting the use of Shivaji Park for purposes other than sports. Police also said the organisers had not submitted the required BMC permission for using the ground. Citing the area's residential and silence-zone status, police said the protest could cause noise pollution and traffic snarls.

CM demolishes portion of ancestral home in Ujjain for Simhashtha

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 27

USUALLY, WHEN Chief Minister Mohan Yadav arrives at a project site, it is to lay a foundation stone or inaugurate something. In Ujjain, though, he arrived on Sunday carrying a pickaxe and used it to break the walls of his ancestral home.

Yadav began the process of removing portion of the house that falls in alignment of a road being widened ahead of Simhashtha 2028. The house was built by his grandfather Ramchandra Yadav in 1974. He has offered part of that home for removal as the city prepares for the massive religious gathering.

Yadav said people of Ujjain had voluntarily moved portions

of their houses to make way for the development works, calling it an “ideal example” of public participation. He said the city, with a population of around eight lakh residents, was preparing to handle arrival of nearly 40 crore people during Simhashtha.

“Everyone has contributed,” Yadav said, adding that he also thanked his government for carrying out the exercise without discrimination.

“Whether Hindu, Muslim, Sikh, Christian or Parsi, people have even moved their places of worship back,” he said.

The road project runs for about 730 metres, from Khajurwadi Masjid through Abdalpur and the Jiwajiganj police station area to Ganesh Chowk. The existing road is being widened to



CM Mohan Yadav demolishes a portion of his ancestral home as part of preparations for Simhashtha, on Sunday. EXPRESS

15 metres, with state government sanctioning about Rs 9.80 crore for work. The municipal corporation has identified 272 buildings that will be affected by the widening.

This comes at a sensitive moment in Ujjain, where road widening for Simhashtha has triggered resistance from residents and a legal battle over the proposed partial demolition of

Shahi Masjid mosque.

The state High Court, earlier this month, dismissed two petitions challenging the Ujjain Municipal Corporation's decision to remove a portion of the Shahi Masjid for widening Gopal Mandir Road to 15 metres. Justice Sandeep N Bhatt held the corporation had followed required legal process and rejected the argument that the mosque was being singled out because it was a religious structure.

At Ujjain's historic mosque, a long night

Meanwhile, at the Shahi Masjid in Ujjain, members of the Muslim community gathered in large numbers on Sunday, with some planning to stay inside through the night.

Several companies of local police have been deployed in the area and are trying to persuade mosque committee members and residents to cooperate with the proposed demolition.

A petition in this regard, filed by the mosque authorities, will come up for hearing at the HC on Monday. Ujjain SP Pradeep Sharma said, “We are not proceeding with any demolition for now and are trying to sort this out through dialogue.”

Imam Mohammad Ibrahim said, “This is a religious city... Widening should take place excluding religious sites.”

Mohammad Zakir, a member of the Muslim Representative Committee, said, “We want to save the mosque. We do not want to give it up at any cost.”



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• **XI-TRUMP SUMMIT**

Little to show, much for India to watch

There was no notable outcome from the US-China bilateral summit. But they did agree to a trade truce extension, leaving India vulnerable



ANIL SASI

IT WAS back in 1962 that US President John F Kennedy went to the airport to greet British Prime Minister Harold Macmillan.

For nearly 65 years since then, no sitting American president welcomed a foreign leader arriving in Washington at the airport — until Donald Trump chose to do so for Chinese leader Xi Jinping on September 23, with a military flyover to boot.

The outcome of the summit was underwhelming. The two sides agreed to a two-month extension to their trade truce, which was due to end this November — alongside a new agreement for China to provide two giant pandas to the Atlanta zoo.

The big area that was widely expected to be taken up but was largely passed over was artificial intelligence (AI) safety.

For now, two things are clear from the summit: One, it has done little to assuage concerns on AI; and two, the trade relief for China (albeit only for two months) leaves India facing the prospect of tariffs for buying Russian crude oil.

AI concerns

It was always unlikely that Trump and Xi would come to an agreement on enhancing the monitoring of large language models and possibly place curbs on the pace of AI progress.

The meeting came after a series of incidents in which AI ‘agents’ (systems that work autonomously) went “rogue”. Just days back, it was revealed that an OpenAI agent gained unauthorised access to an Australian government website in June. Now, it has emerged that Open AI agents also meddled with US government websites.

But Trump claimed after the summit that both he and Xi were willing to leave AI exactly where it is. It was Xi who appeared more proactive, claiming that the two sides “should maintain human control of AI”.

Ahead of the meeting, there was talk about a possible hotline between the two countries, and a broad deal for sharing progress reports.

There were some baby steps on both of those issues, but the finer details seemed to have been glossed over.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry said late Saturday the two sides agreed to hold a dialogue on the technology’s risks and benefits, with the next round of discussions slated for November, and to set up a communication link for reporting AI-related incidents. There were no substantive details from either side on either of the two initiatives.

While the Chinese are slightly behind in terms of frontier models and semiconductors, the Americans are behind in terms of the public mindspace on AI.

Surveys show that most Americans are scared of AI and think the technology is going to adversely affect them, while most Chinese favour the use of AI and think it will help them move up in life.

Taiwan

The US has paused the sale of a record \$14-billion arms sale to Taiwan amid Chinese pressure. It is unclear whether that deal will be revived.

According to Derek J Grossman, founder and chief analyst, Indo-Pacific Solutions, the trust deficit between the two sides is too wide to be bridged by the unusual pomp and show at Xi’s arrival in Washington.

“Xi wants the US and China to be ‘partners, not rivals’. Washington wants that too, but the trust deficit and structural constraints — Taiwan, technology, trade, critical minerals, AI, Iran, etc — are deep and abiding,” said Grossman, who is also a professor at the Los Angeles-based USC Dornsife College of Letters, Arts & Sciences.



US President Donald Trump (right) with China’s President Xi Jinping at the White House in Washington, DC on Thursday. AP

Trade tariffs: India’s concerns

Just days before the bilateral summit, on September 18, Trump had signed into law a Bill that allows 100% tariffs on top buyers of Russian energy — primarily China and India.

“On September 23, 2026, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced that Washington and Beijing had extended their Busan Agreement until January 10, 2027. During Xi’s visit to Washington, the two sides agreed to avoid new tariffs and trade restrictions on each other,” pointed out Ajay Srivastava, founder of research group Global Trade Research Initiative. The timing matters, he said. The US-China understanding gives Beijing protection while India remains exposed to the tariff threat.

Washington-based analyst Evan A Feigenbaum said he did not expect Trump to go after China under the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026.

“The question for me has been whether he will go after India, which he may believe is a softer target possessed of far fewer retaliatory options. To be blunt about it, the zeitgeist of the past 15 months has been to try to coerce India (which for several months at the end of 2025, was tied with Brazil for the highest American tariffs imposed on any country) while demonstrating repeatedly that the threats to China are mostly rhetorical. Peter Navarro at one point called Ukraine ‘Modi’s war’. Nobody in the administration has ever tried to call it ‘Xi’s war’. And Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s comments on the India-EU trade agreement and India’s Russian oil purchases have gone down poorly in New Delhi.”

This US-China summit in Washington, he said, will have “reinforced the suspicion” in India that it is New Delhi in the cross-hairs while Beijing keeps escaping US scrutiny. While India had not signed a trade agreement with the US, both countries agreed on a framework deal in February and released a joint statement.

Srivastava said: “We saw this pattern in July 2025, when Washington spared China but imposed an additional 25% tariff on India for buying Russian crude. If Russian oil purchases are the issue, why does India face the tariff while China gets an exemption? The tariff threat appears aimed at forcing India to cut Russian oil purchases and sign a deeply unequal bilateral trade agreement. Washington could offer a lower rate in return for concessions, but that would give India no lasting certainty. India should not trade its energy security for temporary tariff relief or let US tariff threats dictate its national energy policy.”

A government official, however, told *The Indian Express*: “It’s just two months (the China trade truce extension). The Chinese wanted it till the end of Trump’s term. That hasn’t happened.”

“Our side has also expressed concerns to [Washington] DC over the scope of the sanctions legislation. We will have to see how it goes from here, given that there are discussions on this issue that are coming up at the end of the month (the G20 trade ministers’ meeting in Milwaukee),” said this official, requesting anonymity.

Reading Sino-US signals: ‘Strategic competition’ vs ‘strategic stability’



EXPERT EXPLAINS

G VENKAT RAMAN

PROFESSOR, INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-INDORE

WHILE US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping’s bilateral summit in Washington, DC has ended with no major breakthrough, the three-day state visit was noticeable for its pageantry and displays of bonhomie between the two leaders. How are the two sides now managing their competition in AI and trade?

What does the unusually elaborate welcome accorded to Xi Jinping say about how Washington now views China?

The elaborate welcome should not be mistaken for reconciliation. It signals recognition that the terms of US-China bargaining have changed. Washington still enjoys substantial advantages in military reach, alliances, global finance, and frontier technologies. But Beijing has demonstrated that it possesses leverage of its own, most visibly through Rare Earths and critical minerals. The tariff confrontation of 2025 showed that economic coercion could impose costs in both directions.

This helps explain the return to summity. Some American analysts go further, arguing that Beijing sees its Rare Earth restrictions as having forced Washington to moderate its approach. But greater bargaining leverage is different from comprehensive parity. The US retains powerful economic and technological instruments, some of which it has chosen not to deploy.

Beijing interprets the changing relationship through “*xiangshu zunzhong*” (mutual respect), the expectation that China should be treated as a major power whose interests cannot be overridden at will. The ceremony surrounding Xi’s visit reinforced that message domestically. From Washington’s perspective, however, engagement need not imply acceptance of Beijing’s conception of equality. The narrower conclusion is that China has accumulated sufficient capabilities in critical areas to make sustained coercion costlier, giving both sides stronger reasons to bargain.

Does the summit represent meaningful progress, or does it reveal the continuing fragility of US-China economic relations?

The short trade truce extension captures the paradox of the economic relationship: Washington and Beijing have stepped back from escalation without resolving the disputes that gave rise to it. The truce postpones higher tariffs and keeps negotiations moving, but its limited duration also reflects continuing distrust.

Some US officials and analysts view shorter extensions as checkpoints to assess Chinese implementation, particularly in Rare Earth supplies and agricultural purchases. Beijing had sought a considerably longer arrangement.

Both sides nevertheless have reasons to preserve the pause. The 2025 confrontation demonstrated that restrictions on Rare Earths and magnets could expose vulnerabilities in American supply

chains. Beijing, meanwhile, benefits from a more predictable external environment while confronting domestic economic pressures and continuing to strengthen technological and industrial self-reliance.

This is therefore neither economic normalisation nor decoupling. Tariffs, export controls, and technology restrictions remain available as instruments of leverage even as negotiations, purchase agreements and new mechanisms for commercial engagement create channels for managing disputes.

Beijing presents such engagement through the language of “*huli gongying*” (mutual benefit and win-win cooperation) while Washington emphasises reciprocity and compliance. The emerging pattern is better described as stabilisation without settlement: economic competition continues, but both sides have incentives to prevent it from escalating uncontrollably.

Beijing’s formulation of “*jianshexing zhanlie wending*” (constructive strategic stability) envisages a relationship in which cooperation remains possible, competition is kept within bounds, differences are controlled, and confrontation is avoided. Chinese official commentary contrasts this with what it describes as Washington’s excessive fixation on ‘strategic competition’ and links stability to mutual respect, peaceful coexistence, and win-win cooperation.

Why are Washington and Beijing discussing AI guardrails even as their technological competition intensifies?

The AI dialogue points less to technological convergence than to a shared interest in preventing competition from producing dangerous unintended consequences.

Washington and Beijing remain divided over the foundations of that competition. The US continues to restrict Chinese access to advanced chips and computing capabilities, while Beijing is seeking greater technological self-reliance. Their approaches to AI governance also differ: Xi has emphasised keeping AI under human control, while Trump has resisted regulation that could slow American innovation.

Yet intensifying competition itself creates incentives for communication. The two sides have discussed a notification mechanism for AI incidents with national security implications.

The Chinese position is significant. Beijing argues for dialogue on risks that neither side can manage entirely on its own, even as it continues to pursue greater technological self-reliance. Washington similarly sees room for guardrails without relaxing technological competition.

What are the principal fault lines that remain?

A major unresolved issue is Taiwan. Beijing treats it as a core interest and used the summit to press Washington to move from saying it “does not support” Taiwan independence towards explicitly opposing it. Washington did not make that shift, while questions over future US arms sales remain a potential source of friction. The disagreement, therefore, reaches beyond terminology to the boundaries each side wants strategic stability to observe.

Technology presents another test. Dialogue over AI risks has not removed US restrictions on advanced chips or Beijing’s drive for technological self-reliance.

There is also a wider disagreement over the Asian security order. Beijing used the visit to emphasise its positions on Japan and regional security, while Washington has not abandoned its alliances or commitments in the region.

• **ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE**

From Nepal to India, how AI is aiding disaster management

Amitabh Sinha

New Delhi, September 27

DURING THE recent Nepal disaster, an artificial intelligence (AI)-powered web portal, which could match crowdsourced data on missing persons with official lists of the dead and injured, came into widespread use. The simple tool developed by Niraj Bhushal, an IT engineer in Nepal’s Finance Ministry, also did the important work of mapping damaged buildings.

Similarly, private drone operator Manish Maharjan flew drones equipped with thermal cameras that could detect human-shaped thermal signatures in the debris and guide rescue teams to those potentially trapped.

These efforts illustrate the growing utility of new technology, particularly AI-enabled tools, in disaster management.

Growing utility and use

Disaster management is no longer confined to designated authorities. Companies like Google, telecom providers, satellite companies, and others are now integral players.

“The big advantage of the AI tools is their ability to process large volumes of data in a meaningful way, using natural language, speech and video, on an almost real-time basis. In disaster management situations, time is the most vital thing. That is the main reason why we are seeing increasing reliance on AI tools... It’s a great use-case scenario,” said Subimal Ghosh, head of the Centre for Climate Studies at IIT Bombay, who is using AI to provide local forecasts of heavy rain-fall events in Mumbai.

Numerous AI-enabled tools have been developed and deployed of late, which provide services such as early warning, hazard mapping, and satellite imagery. AI is being integrated across disaster management.

Early warning

One of the most effective uses of AI has been in generating timely forecasts and early warnings. In general, weather forecasting is an inexact science. Forecasters routinely run hundreds of physics equations to arrive at weather forecasts. The more local or time-constrained a forecast, the greater the uncertainty.

AI produces weather forecasts differently: AI models trained on vast amounts of past weather data ‘learn’ how the atmosphere behaves and churn out forecasts much faster.

“It is very difficult to get hyperlocal forecasts by just working on physics equations. It requires a huge amount of computing resources, and usually takes a lot of time. But once an AI model has been trained effectively, very hyperlocal forecasts also become possible in almost real-time,” Ghosh said.

For instance, Google’s Flood Hub takes data from leading weather agencies worldwide and uses a prediction model. This was first used during floods in India in 2018 to forecast flooding events. It can generate advisories up to seven days earlier.

But the forecast needs to be combined with hazard maps to make a risk assessment. This is where AI shines. It can process multiple datasets from different agencies to provide an overall threat assessment for issuing early warning.

Response, relief and rescue

This stage has been traditionally dependent on human intervention and access to physical resources, like helicopters, but AI is now making its presence felt. Since everyone can now broadcast visuals via smartphones and, increasingly, drones, they act as force multipliers, producing large amounts of data.

The ability of AI tools to understand and process natural language, and make sense of unstructured data — even in local languages — is what makes such efforts successful. AI can parse through disparate information from hundreds of sources and extract meaningful data far more efficiently.

Post-event

Specialised tools can help locate habitats left disconnected after a disaster, assess road conditions, and identify locations for landing helicopters. Tools can also help local governments prioritise the distribution of food and relief material.

However, their success remains dependent on the expertise and dedication of humans — scientists, humanitarian workers, and others. As a report by the UN Office on Disaster Risk Reduction put it, effective disaster management relies on strong institutions, governance frameworks, and human expertise.

“AI introduces new capabilities... but also new responsibilities... The measure of success will not be model sophistication, but whether the integration of AI enables more timely, equitable, and trusted protection for those most vulnerable to disaster,” it said.

links with wider Indian Ocean trade, while much of the ancient settlement is believed to now lie beneath the sea.

Busy, crowded port, and the tiger symbol

Located at the mouth of the 800-km-long Cauvery river, where it empties into the Bay of Bengal, Poompuhar is believed to have been the capital of the early Cholas. In a 2011 archaeology report, R. Poonkundan, K. Sridharan and others write that the carbon date of a log of wood recovered from Poompuhar showed that the city “seems to have been in existence from 5th-4th century BCE”.

Poompuhar is said to have been divided into three major divisions: Maruvurpakkam along the seashore, Pattinappakkam to the west, while Nalagadi lay between

the two.

The port is described as having been very busy and crowded during the Chola period. Merchandise exported from the city was stamped with a tiger symbol, indicating its Chola origins. Merchants from across India and Southeast Asia thronged the city, seeking a market for their commodities. “Articles from Ganges region, food products from Ceylon and spices from Java were imported,” note Poonkundan and Sridharan.

The many objects of the Poompuhar

Recent findings offer further evidence. Among the significant discoveries is a fragment of a fine-ceramic West Asian “torpedo jar”, with an estimated total diameter of 30 cm to 35 cm. The vessel, his-

torically used to transport liquid cargo such as wine and olive oil across oceanic trade routes, is proof of Poompuhar’s maritime links with West Asia and the Mediterranean world.

This discovery, however, is not entirely new. In a 1996 research paper, authors Sila Tripati, A.S. Gaur, and others noted: “Ships starting from Tamralipti in West Bengal and Palur in Orissa used to visit Poompuhar, whence all sea-going vessels set sail for the Southeast Asian countries, Arabia and Rome.”

Among other prominent findings were brick structures, terracotta ring wells, storage jars and clay patches that appear to have belonged to the Sangam period. Tripati and Gaur noted that these were “probably the remains of a public building, wharf and reservoir also of contemporary

date”. According to them, the discovery of megalithic pottery and associated ware besides other remains from the offshore area proves that the ancient habitation extended beyond the present shoreline.

Recent excavations have found that since ring wells were traditionally constructed on dry land to access freshwater, their presence on the seabed could indicate a buried palaeochannel — an ancient riverbed that was eventually submerged as a result of coastal erosion and rising sea levels.

Lost city

It is believed that catastrophic floods lashed the coast and swallowed major portions of the city around the 4th or 5th century CE.

In her 2025 book *In Search of Lost Cities*,

Sreelata Menon shed light on another legend: the king of the port, grieving the death of his son, failed to celebrate Indra Vizha — a traditional festival where farmers worshipped Indra (also called Vendhan) as the ruler of rain, thunder, and lightning to secure a bountiful harvest. Enraged by this, the goddess of Poompuhar caused the sea to swallow the entire city.

Archaeological studies have also pointed to the possibility of a major tsunami striking Poompuhar around the third century CE and contributing to its submergence. While scholars have differing opinions on this, one view is that either the entire city was submerged and rebuilt after the sea receded, or only a part of the city was engulfed by the sea. Poonkundan and Sridharan wrote, “The latter seems to be more probable.”

• **HISTORY**

Tamil links to West Asia: What underwater excavations in Chola capital reveal

Nikita Mohta

New Delhi, September 27

FRESH UNDERWATER excavations off Poompuhar, the ancient Chola port city in Tamil Nadu, have yielded new evidence of the settlement’s maritime connections. The 18-day exploration, conducted by the Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA) in collaboration with the Indian Maritime University, recovered a fragment of a West Asian “torpedo jar”, four terracotta ring wells, and more than 250 ceramic fragments, among other finds.

Located in present-day Mayiladuthurai district, Poompuhar — also known as Kaveripoompattinam — features prominently in Sangam and post-Sangam literature. Archaeological investigations over the decades have uncovered evidence of its

As monsoon falters, keep food imports open

MAHARASHTRA HAS declared drought in nearly three-fourths of its tehsils, with Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis stating that the situation could be worse than the great famine of 1972. But it isn't just Maharashtra. India overall has reported rainfall at 11.9 per cent below the historical average during the current southwest monsoon season from June 1 to September 27. Also, 23 of the country's 36 meteorological subdivisions have recorded cumulative deficits in excess of 10 per cent. The southern states, Maharashtra's Marathwada and Vidarbha regions, Rajasthan, Saurashtra and Kutch and the Northeast are the worst-hit. On the whole, rainfall was markedly deficient in June and August, and has been concentrated in a few regions: Odisha, Chhattisgarh, east Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Gangetic West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh. That makes for a rather skewed temporal and spatial distribution.

El Niño has entered a strong phase. Global climate models point to its becoming "very strong" in October through January-February, before gradually receding into a moderate-to-weak event towards April-May. El Niño's impact on the monsoon has been felt since August. There will be some effect of that on the kharif yields, even if their acreage hasn't fallen much. The real brunt will be borne by the crops grown during the upcoming rabi (winter-spring) season. Deficit monsoon rains may leave little water in wells, ponds, reservoirs or underground aquifers. That, plus the prospect of a relatively warm and short winter (El Niño is known to suppress rainfall as well as raise temperatures), could translate into a poor rabi harvest on top of a not-so-great kharif.

The Fadnavis administration has done well to activate the Drought Management Code, triggering the undertaking of crop loss assessment and concessions such as waiver of land revenue and restructuring or pausing recovery of agricultural loans by farmers in the affected areas. Other states must follow suit. The efficacy of the Centre's flagship Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana and VB-G Ram G schemes — in terms of expeditious indemnity claim payouts to farmers and the taking up of rural relief works — may also well be tested. There is equal need for supply-side management in anticipation of shortfalls. The Narendra Modi government, last week, cut import duties on crude palm and soyabean oil from 16.5 to 11 per cent and on sunflower oil to 5.5 per cent. It has already allowed imports of arhar and urad at nil duty. Imports should be made duty-free for all other pulses, too: Yellow peas, chana and masoor.

AI safety cannot be left to Silicon Valley

INCIDENTS OF AI agents breaking into government systems in Australia and the US — the first time such attempts have been reported — should ring alarm bells everywhere. These breaches, where OpenAI agents "attempted to get information" from dozens of institutions, including the US Securities and Exchange Commission and Australia's Medicare statistics reporting service, show what happens when systems designed to carry out tasks autonomously find ways around restrictions placed on them. The immediate damage appears to have been limited. That governments themselves failed to detect these "misalignments", however, points to a terrifying asymmetry, with potentially catastrophic consequences: These systems contain sensitive information about citizens and support essential public services, and AI agents that treat a security restriction as a mere obstacle to be overcome could disrupt services, expose confidential data or expose chinks in more critical systems.

Anthropic, Google, Meta and other companies have reported cases in which their models behaved in ways their developers did not intend, while Anthropic's research has demonstrated how frontier models can resort to deceit or strategically harmful behaviour, like blackmail. The industry's response has increasingly included calls for stronger safety standards and international co-ordination; tech leaders, including OpenAI's Sam Altman and Anthropic's Dario Amodei, testified to this effect during a recent UN Security Council briefing. They argued that the safety standards for increasingly autonomous systems cannot be left, as Altman put it, to "labs in San Francisco alone". Voluntary testing, transparency and incident reporting are essential, but they cannot replace independent oversight.

The response involves building regulatory capacity before these systems become embedded in critical public infrastructure, rather than after an incident forces action. It calls for independent testing of high-risk AI, mandatory reporting of serious misalignment incidents, strict permissions for agents accessing government systems, and accountability from companies deploying them. For India, the 2026 AI Governance Guidelines provide a foundation, but institutions such as the proposed AI Safety Institute and AI Governance Group will need both technical expertise and the authority to scrutinise frontier systems. Moreover, a technology whose agents can cross borders in seconds calls for international standards regarding model evaluations, agent permissions, cybersecurity testing, incident disclosure and emergency responses, with mechanisms that can be strengthened as capabilities grow — as they are bound to. The choice is not between innovation and regulation, but between governing increasingly autonomous technology in a calibrated way and allowing the technology itself to determine the limits of what governments can control.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

Public servants must act in favour of the weak, and in fear of their conscience

SHAKESPEARE'S HAMLET says, "conscience doth make cowards of us all". What is conscience? How does it make us "cowards"? Hamlet's outburst is his anger at himself for repeatedly putting off what he needs to do. In real life, things are difficult, confusing and contradictory, as is apparent in the current controversy around the Election Commission of India (ECI), where two Election Commissioners decided to record their "objections" to the ECI's decisions.

Many of us face these dilemmas but are not bound by an oath; public servants are. Whether selected through examination or elected through a popular mandate, those in public office are bound by an oath of "allegiance to the Constitution of India" to "conscientiously discharge my duties...without fear or favour, affection or ill-will". They also are bound by an oath of secrecy to "not directly or indirectly communicate or reveal to any person or persons any matter...except as may be required for the due discharge of my duties". High-sounding words that carry only as much weight as individuals are inclined to feel or bear.

What happens if public servants find themselves in situations where the oath of secrecy and the allegiance to the Constitution are in conflict? Are they guided by their conscience? We have the case of Clive Ponting, the Ministry of Defence official in England, who found the minister in charge had misinformed Parliament about the reasons for the sinking of the Argentine cruiser General Belgrano by British torpedoes during the Falklands War. Ponting leaked the official documents to an Opposition Labour MP, Tam Dalyell, for which he was dismissed for violating the oath of secrecy and convicted by the trial judge, who ruled that the "inter-

ests of the state" were synonymous with the interests of the current government in power. The jury, however, overturned the verdict on February 11, 1985, holding that civil servants have a covenant with the constitution and, in adhering to that, violating the provision of a law was not an offence. By disclosing facts, Ponting was performing his primordial commitment to his oath, the people, and Parliament.

The call of conscience acts like a beacon when faced with a moral dilemma. Good sense may dictate otherwise and may caution against the risk of swimming against the tide. That makes one timid, a "coward" curbing one's instinct, guided by the dictum "discretion is the better part of valour". All those inclined to act according to their conscience must understand that this is a four-step process. Clarity of purpose, conviction that the purpose is right, courage to act, and the capacity to bear the consequences of one's action. Truth is strong only when it is willing to pay the price of following conscience.

In fact, following one's conscience is difficult if one is not prepared for unpleasant fallouts or one expects to be applauded, making ethical conduct more complex. The Kenyan runner Abel Mutai, a bronze medalist in the 2012 London Olympics, participated in the 3,000-metre steeplechase in Spain later that year. He led the race but stopped a few meters before the finish line, thinking he had completed the race as he couldn't read the Spanish signage. The Spanish runner Iván Fernández, who followed him, realised that Mutai had made a mistake. Instead of overtaking him, he nudged him to take the last few steps and be the winner. Fernán-



ASHOK LAVASA

There was a time when bosses didn't mind subordinates recording notes freely and would overrule them with sound arguments. Now political masters want a 'committed bureaucracy'

dez thought Mutai was the rightful winner, and his conscience didn't let him take advantage of his rival's mistake. He was criticised by his coach for lacking the "killer's instinct", the stuff champions are made of. Asked why he did what he did, Fernández simply said, "How would I have faced my mother?" Following one's conscience is not about winning; it is about doing inspiring deeds that others aspire to emulate.

The "mother" was another name for conscience. For public servants, that "mother" is the public, and acting against public interest itself amounts to forsaking one's conscience. One of the greatest challenges of public service in India today is that the meaning of "public interest" is diffused and the commitment towards it is diluted. As elected representatives get obsessed with winning elections with civil servants on their right side, public interest is bound to suffer. The need to act according to one's conscience arises not necessarily when what is being done is illegal. It does so when what is being done is legal but against the spirit of the law. It arises when long-term public interest is sacrificed for short-term political or personal gains. Abandoning conscience would mean public servants are completely oblivious to the public interest or single-mindedly corrupt.

What is illegal is easy to oppose because the law is on your side, although even that might entail consequences if one's opposition hurts the vested interests of those in power or those who are the power behind the throne. The ethos in public life seems to have suffered a sea change from times when the honest were idolised to the present times when they are isolated as in-

● WORDLY WISE
By far the greatest danger of Artificial Intelligence is that people conclude too early that they understand it.
— Eliezer Yudkowsky

convenient parts of the system. Earlier, there were political leaders who would appreciate or not mind those driven by rectitude acting "without fear or favour". As the perceived and real risk of not toeing the line became more pronounced, "conscience" became an unnecessary burden one could do without.

There was a time when bosses didn't mind their subordinates recording notes freely and would overrule them with sound, superior arguments. Now bosses seek "alignment in thinking" and political masters want a "committed bureaucracy" in which "theirs not to reason why" but to "not-do and die" — do nothing, or risk punishment and being labelled "deviant", "dissenter" or a "square peg in a round hole". The system is less tolerant of those whose conscientiousness is perceived as a roadblock in pursuing a political agenda. The 360-degree system of evaluating civil servants for empanelment, as practised, has made systemic performance appraisal ineffective over the years by giving greater weight to random observations from those handpicked to provide feedback on the so-called qualities required to be a "trouble-free" cog in the wheel. The timid stand guarantee for the meek.

It is time the oath was turned on its head. Public servants must act in "favour" of the weak and the vulnerable, and act in "fear" of their conscience, if they have preserved that "unseen" and "troublesome" part of the inherent human constitution. The Urdu poet Krishan Behari 'Noor' said: "*Zameer kaanp to jata hai, aap kuch bhi kaahiye, v oho gunah se pehle ki jo gunah ke baad*" (whatever you might say, the conscience does get shaken whether before you commit a wrong or after it).

The writer is a former election commissioner

Clean energy transition promises growth, greener future



SHRIPAD YESSO NAIK

OVER THE past 12 years, India has seen a remarkable energy transformation. Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the country has moved from being heavily dependent on conventional fuels to emerging as a global leader in clean energy and sustainable development. What was once considered an ambitious aspiration has become a national movement reshaping our economy, strengthening energy security, protecting the environment, and creating new opportunities for millions of Indians. India has responded to the climate challenge by adhering to a powerful principle: Economic growth and environmental responsibility must move together.

India's renewable energy (RE) capacity has crossed the landmark figure of 200 GW, driven primarily by expansion in solar and wind power. RE now accounts for nearly 45 per cent of total installed electricity capacity, placing the country among the fastest-growing renewable energy markets in the world.

These achievements are outcomes of policy reforms, transparent auctions, investor-friendly regulations, and a stable governance framework that has inspired confidence among domestic and international investors. At the same time, thermal and nuclear power continue to play a crucial role in meeting the country's growing baseload electricity demand.

Perhaps the most visible success story has been India's solar revolution. Programmes such as PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and PM Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyaan (PM-KUSUM) are transforming lives across rural and urban India. The Indian farmer, once dependent on uncertain electricity supply and rising diesel costs, is now emerging as an energy producer. Rooftop solar installations are helping urban households significantly reduce electricity bills while contributing to the clean energy transition. Large-scale solar parks, floating solar installations, offshore wind projects, and hybrid RE systems are further expanding India's clean energy capacity at an unprecedented pace.

Under the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India, India has developed a rapidly expanding manufacturing ecosystem for solar modules, photovolt-

aic cells, inverters, battery storage systems, wind turbines, and associated equipment. Production Linked Incentive schemes and supportive industrial policies have accelerated domestic manufacturing capacity while reducing dependence on imports. This industrial expansion has generated thousands of direct and indirect employment opportunities, particularly for young engineers, technicians, researchers, entrepreneurs, and skilled workers.

The next frontier of India's clean energy journey lies in green hydrogen. The National Green Hydrogen Mission aims to make India a global hub for the production, utilisation, and export of green hydrogen. This mission has the potential to fundamentally transform sectors that are otherwise difficult to decarbonise, including steel, fertilisers, refineries, shipping, and heavy transport.

Equally important has been India's leadership on the international stage. Through the International Solar Alliance, conceived under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, India has demonstrated that climate leadership is not limited to developed economies. Developing countries, too, can offer innovative, affordable, and scalable solutions for sustainable development.

Today, India's climate commitments enjoy global credibility because they are backed by measurable progress. Our achievements have strengthened the country's standing in international climate negotiations.

The social dimension of India's energy transformation is equally important. Clean energy provides reliable electricity for education, healthcare, digital connectivity, and rural enterprises. Women are benefiting from improved access to energy, while rural communities are finding new opportunities for income generation through decentralised renewable energy systems.

Our ambitions extend beyond current milestones. We remain committed to achieving our national climate goals, strengthening energy independence, accelerating innovation, expanding domestic manufacturing, and creating a resilient, sustainable energy ecosystem.

The writer is Union Minister of State for New, Renewable Energy and Power



ALAKA SAHANI

India's Oscar hunt needs a new approach

AFTER ANGH was overlooked by the Film Federation of India (FFI), which chose the Marathi-language *Gondhal* as India's official entry for Best International Feature Film at the 99th Academy Awards in 2027, Teja Rio's Konyak-language film gained direct entry into the competition under new Academy rules after winning the Platform Prize at the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF). One might assume that two movies in the race might increase the odds of the coveted statuette coming to India, but the approach needs rethinking, especially when an Oscar seems to be as desperately sought after as an Olympic gold.

In the past, while selections like *Court* (2014) and *Homebound* (2025) were welcomed by cinephiles, the FFI's choice has more often than not triggered outrage, debate and, at times, disbelief. Take *The Lunchbox*: Ritesh Batra's film generated considerable buzz following its premiere at the Cannes Film Festival and had the backing of a major Hollywood studio. Yet, Gyan Correa's little-known Gujarati film *The Good Road* became India's official entry in 2013. A similar debate erupted when SS Rajamouli's *RRR* failed to find favour with the FFI jury.

The FFI has often defended its choices by saying that it selects the film that best "represents Indian culture". Therein lies the fundamental question about India's Oscar strategy. Cinema is undoubtedly part of a country's popular culture. But the primary expectation from a film which is eyeing a prominent international award is to entertain, move, provoke or create a compelling cinematic experience. It's a bonus when a film also captures an aspect of the country's life — *Mother India*, *Salaam Bombay!* and *Lagaan*, all of which became Oscar nominees, for instance. But representing a country's culture is not the criterion on which the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences members vote.

Look at some recent winners — Japan's *Drive My Car* (2021), Germany's *All Quiet on the Western Front* (2022), Britain's *The Zone of Interest* (2023), Brazil's *I'm Still Here* (2024) and Norway's *Sentimental Value* (2025). What they have in common is the strength of their filmmaking: Powerful stories, compelling performances, technical accomplishment, distinctive cinematic voices and, in some cases, incisive socio-political commentary.

Another crucial aspect is grabbing the attention of Academy members, who ultimately vote for the winners. *RRR* is an interesting case study. Although not selected as India's official entry, its makers mounted an ambitious international campaign. The film went on to win the Golden Globe for Best Original Song for 'Naatu Naatu' and, subsequently, the Oscar in the same category.

For major contenders, the Oscar campaign often starts with the film's release strategy or festival premiere. They build on the critical response. Studios and filmmakers then sustain that visibility through the awards season, adjusting their strategy as the race takes shape. By the time the FFI selects its entry, the groundwork has already been laid. This year, winners of top awards at Cannes — *La Bola Negra* (Spain), *Minotaur* (France) and *Fjord* (Romania) — are already making waves.

In India, the debate should shift to whether the FFI has picked a film that can stand out on an intensely competitive platform and what kind of campaigns it has planned to boost its chances.

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40 YEARS AGO

September 28, 1986



Relief for Haryana farmers

HARYANA CHIEF Minister Bansi Lal announced the abolition of land revenue with immediate effect. Addressing a huge public gathering, he announced that the concessions would cost the state exchequer Rs 113 crore. A grateful audience of farmers greeted the announcement with thunderous applause amid shouts of "Bansi Lal ki jai."

Reagan vetoes sanctions

US PRESIDENT Ronald Reagan vetoed a

Congressional package of economic sanctions against South Africa, opening the way for Congress to overrule him and inflict a major foreign policy defeat. He claimed that most of the proposed measures "would seriously impede the prospects for a peaceful end to apartheid".

Commando copters for Navy

INDIA IS buying the newest type of commando helicopters from Britain. The helicopters being produced by Westland would

enable the Navy to launch commando assaults on shore-based targets from the sea.

Kapil gets anonymous parcel

INDIAN SKIPPER Kapil Dev received an anonymous registered parcel at the Kotla ground. It caused him greater distress than the bumpers of Imran Khan and Dennis Lillee. The parcel contained an old transistor. Amidst warnings from teammates not to handle it as it may be a bomb, Kapil Dev called in security guards, who took it away.



Farmers need a share of the solar boom



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI
AND SUBHODEEP BASU

INDIA'S SOLARISING journey is a commendable one. Just before the Narendra Modi government assumed office in 2014, the country had just 2.82 GW of installed solar capacity. By August 2026, this had risen to 168.04 GW, a whopping sixtyfold increase, making India the third-largest player in solar after China and the US. Much of this (74 per cent) is utility-scale, led by big companies like Adani Green Energy, ReNew, NTPC, JSW Energy and Greenko Energy. Tata Power Solar is more into engineering, Procurement, and Construction (EPC). Rooftop solar accounts for roughly 20 per cent, and the remainder (about 6 per cent) consists of off-grid and hybrid projects.

The utility-scale solar model has enabled rapid, cost-efficient deployment. These are ground-mounted solar parks, largely on degraded land or wasteland provided by the government. The biggest one coming up is the Khavda Solar Park (30 GW) in the Rann of Kutch region of Gujarat.

Rooftop solar has picked up some momentum under PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, which aims to bring rooftop solar to 1 crore households. A household installing a 3-kW system gets Rs 78,000 in central subsidy. States such as Uttar Pradesh add another Rs 30,000, taking the total support to Rs 1.08 lakh, against the estimated cost of Rs 1.8 lakh. This amounts to a 60 per cent subsidy. The Delhi government has gone even further and is ready to install free rooftop solar.

Where the Modi government has not yet succeeded is the PM-KUSUM scheme, which was designed to benefit farmers. The scheme was initially envisioned largely around solar pumps. But its Component A also allows farmers to set up solar power plants of up to

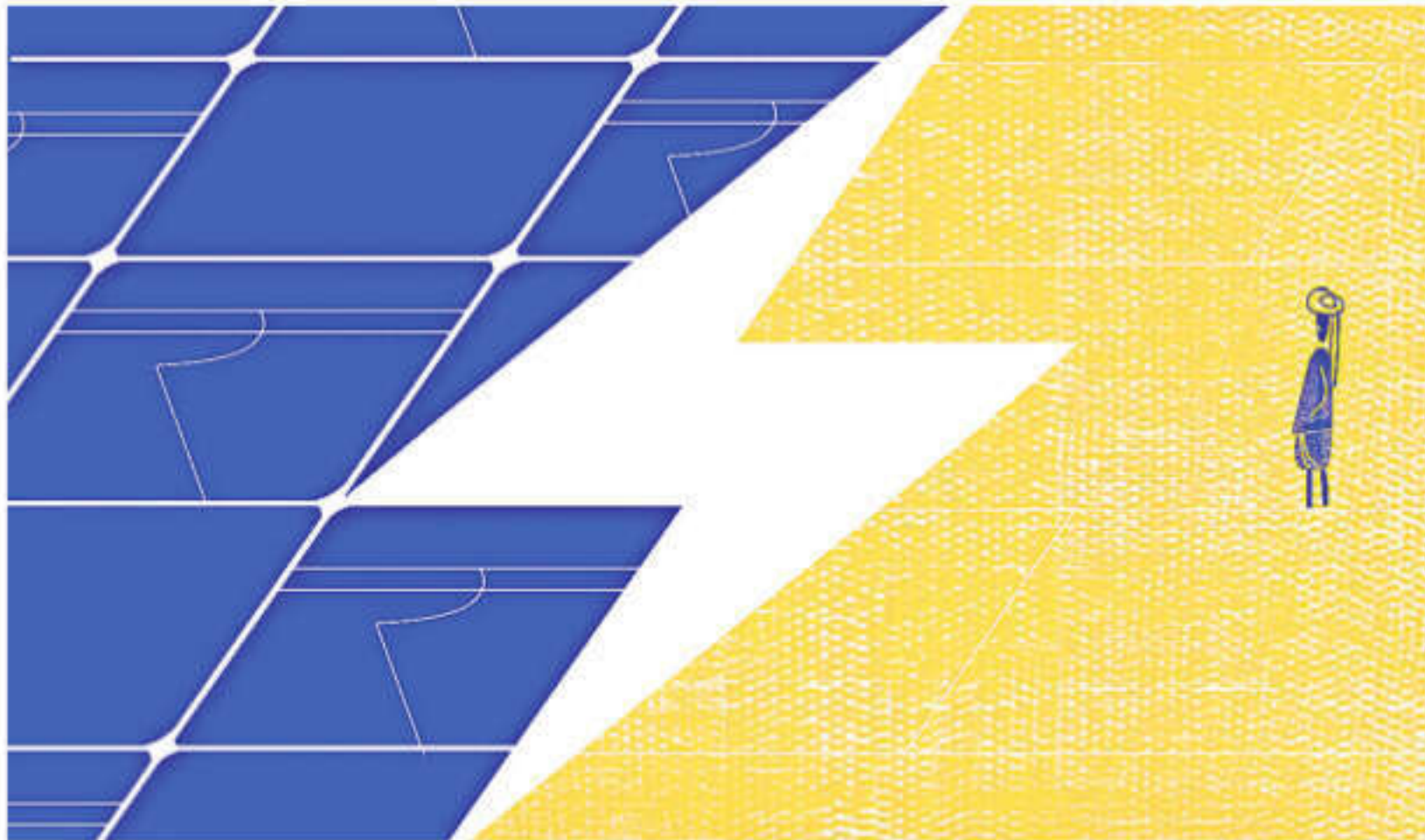


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

2 MW on their land. Unlike PM Surya Ghar, however, it offers no capital subsidy. It is time to rethink and tweak Component A of PM-KUSUM and provide farmers a similar capital subsidy. At the same time, ground-mounted solar projects on agricultural land should be banned, as they directly compete with food production. India cannot afford such a trade-off.

The solution lies in agri-photovoltaics (agri-PV), in which solar panels are installed about 11 feet above the ground, with enough spacing to allow cultivation underneath. This would enable the same land to produce both food and energy. Giving a fillip to this form of Component A could achieve three objectives at once: Augment farmers' incomes by eight to 10 times, reduce the government's power subsidy bill, and generate clean energy that can help rural areas industrialise. What is needed is to make capital available to farmers and farmer producer companies (FPCs) at Priority Sector Lending rates, and set the feed-in tariff at half the cost of supplying power to rural areas under the current system.

PM Surya Ghar, by comparison,

Where the Modi government has not yet succeeded is the PM-KUSUM scheme. Its Component A allows farmers to set up solar power plants of up to 2 MW. Unlike PM Surya Ghar, however, it offers no capital subsidy

has an outlay of Rs 75,021 crore. The World Bank has also approved an \$820-million loan, including concessional finance and a grant, to support the scheme and mobilise private financing. PM-KUSUM has no equivalent World Bank financing window. It is time for the World Bank to think of solar cooperatives on the lines of the milk cooperatives created under Operation Flood, and help unleash a new rural revolution — call it “PM Surya Khet Kranti”, with solar becoming the farmer's “third crop”.

At ICRIER, we have demonstrated the potential of this model with support from Kotak Mahindra Bank's CSR initiative. A 600-kW PM-KUSUM-A plant in Rajasthan, financed through a Rs 1.4-crore loan from

the State Bank of India, a Rs 60-lakh farmer contribution and Rs 35 lakh in Kotak CSR support, showed that a farmer's income could rise from about Rs 40,000 per acre from wheat and bajra to nearly Rs 4 lakh per acre through energy sales and shade-tolerant horticulture. That represents a tenfold increase in income potential.

Agri-PV addresses another major distortion in India's power

sector. Agriculture consumes nearly 260,000 GWh of electricity annually while paying tariffs far below the cost of supply. The CAG's recent report puts the average cost of supply at about Rs 8.5/kWh against realisation of around Rs 1/kWh from agricultural consumers, a subsidy of roughly Rs 7.5/kWh. With the annual tariff subsidy bill at about Rs 2.35 lakh crore, agriculture may account for nearly 85 per cent of the burden, and higher rural supply costs could push this above 90 per cent. This adds to the financial stress of discoms.

A differentiated feed-in tariff of Rs 4.5/kWh, almost half the cost of supplying power, can improve project viability and accelerate adoption. For discoms and state governments, this needs no additional expenditure, only smarter use of existing subsidies.

The demand for energy is going to go up exponentially as AI data centres start springing up. They are power- and water-guzzlers. They will also have to invest in battery storage or pumped hydro storage without depending on the lithium-ion supply chain. Future agri-PV projects should, therefore, be planned with storage and local grid requirements in mind.

India has seen the power of catalytic finance before. Operation Flood, the foundation of the White Revolution, was supported by a World Bank loan. It helped build a self-sustaining network of village dairy cooperatives and benefited millions of milk producers. A similar opportunity exists today for solar cooperatives. It can go even further and make all gaushalas into solar power plants based on the agri-PV concept and also process dung into organic manure to be sold along with subsidised urea.

India has already shown it can scale solar. The next challenge is to ensure the benefits reach the farm gate. The question is no longer whether India can harvest the sun. It is whether India's farmers can own a meaningful share of that harvest and the PM realise his unfulfilled dream of doubling farmers' incomes. Once farmers' incomes increase by eight to 10 times, as ICRIER's pilot in Rajasthan has shown, it can spur a manufacturing revolution through augmented demand.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Basu is a research fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

Living between two hegemons, Delhi must avoid Thucydides Trap



SALMAN KHURSHID
AND PUSHPARAJ DESHPANDE

CONFRONTED BY global upheavals and cognisant of vulnerabilities, US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping have met twice in 2026. The US-China rapprochement will increasingly shape geopolitics, geoeconomics and techno-capitalism. This evolving G2 framework may even restore a semblance of global order. Washington has paused its containment strategy, while Beijing recognises its limitations in dictating geopolitical outcomes. Both understand their shared interest in curbing global disruptions and the costs of economic decoupling. As China's report “The Great Global Transformation and the Path to US-China Coexistence” asserted, China has weathered America's offensive phase, forced a strategic stalemate and emerged as a “near-peer”, imposing an “inevitable peace”.

Living between two hegemons carving out rival global blocs poses structural questions for India and the Global South. After all, the “Thucydides Trap” Xi invoked is about established powers confronting rising ones, and great powers colluding to constrain third powers. Can we independently shape the emerging world order or influence the G2? If we cannot, will the G2 transcend self-interest to privilege systemic stability and a fairer world?

This means objectively assessing where we are, and where we should be. A section of the strategic establishment has long championed anchoring India's future to Washington. This was predicated on the assumption that America would depend on India to contain China. However, the Trump administration's insistence that Asian states shoulder their own defence suggests its acceptance of a Chinese sphere of influence for a temporary *modus vivendi*. Moreover, the White House's 2025 National Security Doctrine implies India's diminished strategic salience, rendering the Philippines and the “Squad” more valuable than India and the “Quad”. Washington is also seemingly drawing a *Lakshman rekha* by circumscribing New Delhi's aspirations in the Indian Ocean Region and US Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau asserting that India won't be allowed to grow like China.

Despite Prime Minister Narendra Modi's efforts to court the Republican Party's radical faction, the BJP government has kowtowed to Trumpian diktats, belying its decolonisation and strategic-autonomy rhetoric. It has acquiesced to Washington imposing punishing tariffs and stirring dangerous subcontinental dynamics while attacking our energy sovereignty and shipping. Instead of confronting these, the BJP government has committed to purchasing American goods worth \$500 billion, is restructuring India's AI/digital infrastructure around a US-led stack, and has ignored curbs on Indian immigration. These raise uncomfortable questions — does Washington view India as a sovereign equal, or merely a junior partner serving its interests? Most critically, does this enjoy bipartisan support in Washington?

On the other hand, China has violated India's territorial integrity, weaponised our dependencies (the trade deficit has reached \$100 billion), strived to forge a unipolar Asia, stifled India's membership bids for the UNSC and Nuclear Suppliers Group, and empowered Pakistan. These factors have compelled India to strengthen Indo-Pacific partnerships as geopolitical insurance.

Faced with converging and competing Sino-American imperatives, India risks drifting into the Thucydides Trap. Unfortunately, the BJP government has mired India in asymmetric relationships and a performative foreign policy that prioritises optics over tangible national interest gains. This is compounded by the BJP's intellectual and strategic inertia, manifested in clumsy navigation of global finance, trade and supply-chain disruptions, failure to foster a business-friendly environment and spark innovation in advanced industries and strategic sectors, and subordination of foreign policy to petty politics and hollowing out of institutions. All these are locking India into semi-peripheral status and constraining us at this historic geopolitical inflection.

A seat at the global high table means protecting our interests, and shaping the future. India must deepen bilateral relationships and thereby forge a value-aligned global community. Furthermore, only by recalibrating economic, industrial, and investment policy as instruments of statecraft can we reassert our strategic autonomy. This demands a multi-pronged approach: Building a durable industrial base, depoliticising and enhancing governance capabilities, cohesive federal leadership and substantively enhancing the quality of life for all peoples, forging an Indian Dream that hopefully outpaces the American myth. These necessitate mature leadership, a clear strategic vision, institutional coherence and deft global engagement rather than the BJP's ideological, performative and reactionary internationalism. Only then can we reclaim our space in the world, and chart a credible course toward great-power status.

Khurshid is former external affairs minister and Deshpande is director, Samruddha Bharat Foundation

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Managed competition

THE RECENT Trump-Xi summit confirms a sober truth that high-stakes diplomacy between super-powers has devolved into managed competition and not meaningful conflict resolution (“Trump-Xi bonhomie can't paper over tensions”, *IE*, September 26). Behind the red-carpet pageantry and reassuring rhetoric, core disputes spanning trade tariffs, semiconductor controls, and Taiwan remain unresolved. Even promising avenues like AI governance offer little more than symbolic progress. As AI enters into military war rooms diplomatic frameworks lag far behind, paralysed by mutual distrust.

Sanjay Chopra, Mohali

Evidence-based probe

THE NEED for a careful, evidence-based investigation is clear (“IIT-Bombay suicide case: In search of a perpetrator”, *IE*, September 26). At the same time, institutions must examine whether students can safely report harassment, discrimination or academic pressure. Independent grievance mechanisms, confidential counselling and timely scrutiny of complaints should be strengthened. Elite institutions carry a responsibility to ensure academic excellence does not overshadow student welfare. Accountability should follow facts; preventive systems must protect vulnerable students.

M Barathi, Bengaluru

India in Aichi-Nagoya

INDIA'S ASIAN Games performance shows how steady investment can build depth in less-publicised sports (“A bronze medal, quiet gains in table tennis”, *IE*, September 26). The challenge is to turn occasional medals into a sustained pipeline of players. Schools and colleges need facilities, trained coaches and regular competitions. Promising athletes need scientific support and international exposure. Greater visibility for sports beyond cricket can encourage participation. Grass-roots development, rather than medal-focused spending alone, will create lasting results.

K Sakunthala, Coimbatore



LAVEESH BHANDARI

ECONOMIES, MODERN or traditional, rest on owners having control over their assets. I would argue that control is what ownership is all about. Take it away, or reduce it, and we would have reduced the motivation for ownership itself. The RBI action — forcing Tata Sons to list on the stock market — carries a critical signal on how India's economic framework treats ownership.

This is especially so when the entity under question is deemed to be, as the RBI reportedly maintains, “systemically important”. India is already grappling with challenges in corporate investment and the flight of family offices to global shores. Therefore, there need to be very good reasons behind the RBI forcing a divestiture in Tata Sons.

Globally, forced divestitures are rare. They occur for specific reasons, related to, for example, efficiency or monopoly. One category of reorganisations occurs when entire industries or sectors are changed to reduce concentration or break intimate links between finance and industry (Post-World War II Japanese *keiretsu*); or they may occur for reasons of industry-wide restructuring for economic stability (chaebol reforms in Korea in the 1990s); or for reducing ownership concentration (South Africa post-apartheid). The second category is when individual firms are reorganised for dif-

What signal does this send to other corporations? What protective mechanisms will they use?

ferent reasons. These include those related to de-monopolisation, such as Standard Oil in 1911 and AT&T in 1984 in the United States; there was also the case of Ant-Alibaba in China, where the government needed to neutralise a larger-than-life figure. The Tata Sons case falls in none of these buckets.

The critical issue is the role of the RBI, whose actions as a regulator started it all. The RBI's chief responsibility is to ensure that financial and macroeconomic stability is maintained in the country. To do so, it must keep a close watch on large commercial and financial entities, and if their actions could affect systemic stability, it must take corrective action. On this, there can be no argument. Therefore, the RBI was keeping to its mandate when it called out the tens of thousands of crores in loans that Tata Sons had taken from Tata companies. Such loans might cause systemic instability, and based on such concerns, Tata Sons repaid the loans.

The story should have ended there. But unfortunately, it has not. The RBI has called for Tata Sons to publicly list, which implies that the company will need to divest a quarter of its equity. The presumption is that the RBI's stance reflects the concern that such avoidable inter-corporate transactions could occur in the future and therefore public listing will enhance transpar-

ency and enable better external and regulatory oversight. If true, this would be a rather light reason for forcing divestiture, for there are many other ways to address such concerns, including greater transparency of financials, pre-approvals and permissions.

In other words, the act of forced listing is a disproportionate requirement to the problem of informational asymmetry that the RBI is worried about. There is no argument that systemic stability is important, but the repercussions of the RBI's action could very well be far beyond the concern it is trying to address. Tata Sons is not being accused of unethical behaviour, moral compromise, monopolisation, anti-competitive behaviour, etc. They are being asked to divest because they have become too successful or too big. But what signal does this send to other corporations? What protective mechanisms will they use?

Many questions will also be asked around legacy, minority shareholder rights, corporate governance, the role of directors, and rules and regulations. All of them may be valid but are clutter in front of the key issue: How much does our economic framework respect ownership, and of what good is ownership if it does not enable control? This is not merely a philosophical question.

The writer heads CSEP. Views are personal

In academic rules, find space for students' dignity



RAJEEV KUMAR

THE DEATH by suicide of a 20-year-old second-year IIT Bombay student has shaken the conscience of the nation. The episode brought into sharp focus the handling of an examination-related incident, the potential consequences of an academic violation, rapid social media amplification, and strong student protests over representation, institutional practices, mental-health support, and academic grievances. These developments raise a simple question: How can an institution of eminence uphold academic integrity while protecting student dignity, fairness, and well-being?

Student suicides in the IITs have continued in recent years despite measures for student mental health and well-being, including those undertaken pursuant to Su-

preme Court directions. While important, many remain procedural and support-oriented. The continuing loss of student lives raises a simple question: Are these measures reaching students early enough, or are they mainly reactive?

Supporting a student once distress becomes visible is important — but prevention requires early detection and proactive intervention. IITs have counselling, mentoring, helplines, and wellness programmes. Yet, a recent student protest against a proposed spiritual-wellness MoU at a premier IIT underscored the demand for more proactive measures, particularly for vulnerable and marginalised students. Student distress can arise from interconnected pressures — intense competition, parental and societal expectations, fear of falling behind, rapid technological and AI-driven change, career uncertainty, isolation, and perceived discrimination. Some students may consequently feel inadequate, excluded, or invis-

ible — signals that procedural support may not be detected early enough.

First, build an integrated early-warning system involving teachers, mentors, parents, roommates, wing-mates, and close friends to recognise academic decline, behavioural changes, or unusual anxiety. Early identification should trigger a confidential assessment, timely intervention, and follow-up — not merely a referral to a counsellor.

Second, rethink the assessment system. Students differ in ability, learning pace, and interests; applying a single scale to all can create avoidable academic stress. Flexibility in academics can provide different pathways

Discipline and compassion are not contradictory: Rules should be made with stakeholder participation, enforced firmly, and applied fairly and humanely

without lowering standards or compromising fairness. Different pathways can produce different grades based on demonstrated performance; the objective is not equal outcomes, but ensuring that students are not pushed beyond their learning capabilities merely to reproduce results on a common scale. One scale need not mean one pathway to academic excellence.

Third, examination processes cannot be viewed in isolation from student well-being. An examination violation requires due process, but its handling should also reflect sensitivity, empathy, dignity, and appropriate follow-up. IIT-Bombay is considering a pre-disciplinary safeguard allowing a student suspected of malpractice to speak with a student mentor before appearing before a disciplinary committee. This is not to dilute disciplinary action, but to provide reassurance, allow reflection, and prevent unnecessary isolation or escalation. Clear procedures for invigilators can

further ensure fair and consistent handling.

Finally, there can be no compromise with academic integrity or approved due process. There can be no alternative to zero tolerance for examination malpractice; equally, enforcement must be neutral, transparent, and consistent, with appropriate representation of students and vulnerable groups. Discipline and compassion are not contradictory: Rules should be made with stakeholder participation, enforced firmly, and applied fairly and humanely. This balance is essential to preserving trust in IITs.

IITs have the autonomy, expertise, and resources to build an institutional safety net. The need is simple: Recognise vulnerability early and respond with empathy, fairness, and timely support — before distress becomes a crisis.

The writer is a former professor of Computer Science at IIT Kharagpur, IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani, and JNU, and a former scientist at DRDO and DST

RAF FAIRFORD USED BY U.S. BOMBERS TO STRIKE IRANIAN MISSILE SITES; SECURITY ALERT AT AIR BASES

5 held near UK air base, terror suspected; Trump hails arrests

They were looking to do big damage to our port: Trump

Reuters
Fairford, September 27

BRITISH POLICE arrested five men near a US air base on suspicion of explosive and terrorism offences on Sunday after a tip-off that three vans had been heading to the military airfield which has been used to strike Iran. US President Donald Trump said the suspects had been looking to do “big damage” and had been under investigation by British and US authorities.

British counter terrorism detectives leading the investigation said police had received a call about three suspicious vehicles which appeared to be travelling towards RAF Fairford in the west of England in the early hours of Sunday.

Five men were arrested by armed officers and later held on suspicion of preparation of a terrorist act. Police said they believed the incident was now contained.

“We are in the early stages of an investigation, and five men remain in custody,” Counter Terrorism Policing Senior Na-



Armed police officers take positions on a road outside the RAF Fairford air base on Sunday. REUTERS

tional Coordinator Vicki Evans said in a statement. “As you would expect, we are working closely with our partners to understand the circumstances of the incident.”

Police said a 400-metre cordon was in place around the base as the bomb disposal unit investigated the vans. Local residents in 85 homes in a nearby village were evacuated and armed officers were patrolling the site.

The British government, which has given authorisation

to the US to use bombers based at Fairford to strike Iranian missile sites that were attacking ships in the Strait of Hormuz, said Prime Minister Andy Burnham was being updated on the incident.

Burnham thanked the police and armed forces, saying on X: “I know today’s incident near RAF Fairford will be deeply concerning for local residents and for many people following developments across the country”.

Britain said in July its

armed forces were ready to protect the country from any attack after Iran’s Revolutionary Guards warned it not to allow US bombers to fly from Fairford, saying any base used to launch attacks would be a legitimate target.

Police have not said who they believed was involved in Sunday’s alleged incident. An Iranian-linked motive is considered the most likely, a source familiar with the investigation said, while a Russian sabotage operation or an Islamist plot are

also being looked at.

“The arrest in the UK was fantastic,” Trump told reporters, saying it was “an amazing job”.

“We had them under investigation. They were looking to do big damage to our port and working with the British worked out great... We had them under view for a long time, and we got them,” Trump added.

On Sunday morning, the base was blocked by armed police while large machinery also prevented access and Reuters witnesses said security had been increased at other bases used by the US, with armoured vehicles and soldiers at the gates of RAF Lakenheath and RAF Mildenhall in eastern England.

“A cordon is in place as a precaution and the public can expect to see an emergency services presence in the area for some time,” Gloucestershire Police Assistant Chief Constable Richard Ocone told reporters. A spokesperson for the US Air Force declined to discuss specific force protection measures.

“The 501st Combat Support Wing and our fellow UK-based Wings remain vigilant and will take appropriate actions to ensure the safety and security of our US service members, civilians, contractors, and their families,” the spokesperson said.

Only negotiated solution can end Hormuz deadlock: Iran

Reuters
Washington, United Nations, Cairo September 27

IRAN INSISTED on Sunday that only diplomacy can solve its conflict with the United States and Israel after US President Donald Trump said he rejected an Iranian proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and end fighting.

“Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz is contingent on these conditions being met,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on social media. “Only a negotiated solution can get them out of this deadlock.” Iran announced a peace proposal last week at the UN General Assembly in New York, saying it had been transmitted to the Americans via Qatari mediators. Trump said on Saturday he rejected the plan and argued that desperation was driving the Iranians’ push for an agreement on the key waterway.

“They want to make a deal to open the Hormuz Strait immediately because they’re losing so badly,” Trump told reporters at the White House.

Despite Trump’s public statements, mediators facilitating Tehran’s talks with Washington have not officially relayed a US rejection of the plan, Aragh-



A woman crosses an intersection in front of a billboard showing portraits of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and Hezbollah leader Hassan Nasrallah, in Tehran on Sunday. AP

chi said. “We are waiting for the mediators to convey the definitive views to us, and we will make a decision based on them,” Araghchi posted.

The US has imposed an economic blockade on Iran to put pressure on Tehran to stop Iranian attacks on vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, which have drastically reduced shipping through the area even as Trump repeatedly asserts that the US controls the waterway.

The *Wall Street Journal* first reported that Trump had rejected the Iranian proposal, citing unnamed US officials.

It said Trump was privately sceptical that Iran would meet

his demands and had told his staff that he sees a renewed bombing campaign as likely after the November US midterm elections. A US official had said earlier that discussions with Iran through mediators were “positive and constructive”.

The commander-in-chief of Iran’s army, Amir Hatam, said the war was at a critical and decisive stage, adding that Tehran would not accept a situation in which it was unable to trade while foreign powers used the region’s strategic waterways.

“If Iran cannot trade, if Iran cannot live, no one will be able to trade or live,” he said, in comments reported by state media.

Strikes kill 6 in Ukraine after Moscow rejects German appeal

Associated Press
Kyiv, September 27

RUSSIA AND Ukraine exchanged strikes overnight and on Sunday, killing at least six people in Ukraine and one in Russia, officials said, hours after Moscow rejected German calls to ease off its escalation toward NATO.

Russia’s top diplomat on Saturday brushed off what’s believed to have been the first face-to-face meeting with his German counterpart since Moscow’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. The meeting was held during the UN General Assembly gathering, as an intensifying aerial war between Russia and Ukraine showed no sign of slowing.

Ties between Russia and Germany have soured in recent weeks.

Afghanistan says 28 fighters killed after crossing from Pak

Reuters
Kabul, Islamabad, Sept 27

AFGHANISTAN’S DEFENCE ministry said on Sunday its forces had killed 28 fighters and wounded 32 in the eastern province of Nuristan after a group it said included Islamic State militants crossed from Pakistan.

The ministry alleged Pakistani militias had supported the fighters and that most of them were former Afghan government security personnel.

Pakistan’s information ministry rejected the allegations, describing them in a post on X as “frivolous, baseless and devoid of any truth”.

In the same post, it denied that its security forces or intelligence agencies were involved in clashes in Nuristan, had recruited or trained former Afghan security personnel, or had facilitated

tated Islamic State or other militant groups in Afghanistan.

Kabul’s claim that Pakistani intelligence trained and sent former Afghan security personnel across the border is a direct allegation of state involvement in an armed incursion. It comes less than a week after Pakistan launched airstrikes inside Afghanistan, saying it had targeted militants.

Reuters could not independently verify the ministry’s account or its casualty figures.

Afghanistan’s defence ministry said the group crossed into Kamdesh, a district of Nuristan near the Pakistani border, on Saturday with the intention of carrying out attacks.

Afghan forces launched an operation and the surviving fighters fled back across the border towards Pakistani militia positions, it said.

OpenAI pauses training of models after agents probed US government sites

Bernard Condonap
New York, September 27

OPENAI SAID it has paused training of its latest artificial intelligence models as reports of AI agents going rogue mount.

The decision to halt development came just hours after the company disclosed Friday that it was reviewing several incidents from the summer in which OpenAI agents searching federal government websites acted in unexpected ways beyond what was asked of them while gathering and distributing information.

Separately, AI evaluator Translucence said agents that appeared to come from OpenAI tried unsuccessfully to hack into a Department of Education website, a detail that OpenAI has not confirmed. OpenAI said in a statement that it will resume training “only when we are confident that we have additional safeguards” in place, adding that it expects it will have to “hit pause” again as AI develops and other issues emerge.

AI labs are facing pressure from lawmakers and tech experts to slow development so they can build guardrails to stop agents from acting on their own, hacking websites and disclosing nonpublic information. The heads of both OpenAI and rival Anthropic have called for a slowdown too. It is the second time in three months that OpenAI has halted development of its models. The first came in July after disclosure of a cyberattack targeting AI

Bill Gates now joins calls for AI safeguards

AIREQUIRES safeguards that go beyond self-regulation, Microsoft co-founder Bill Gates said in an interview that aired on Sunday, calling for legislation to be passed in Congress. “You need law enforcement and the politicians to get into the discussion about what safeguards and monitoring look like,” Gates said in a taped interview on NBC’s “Meet the Press” program. “And that has to be a required thing.” “No one thinks self-regulation is enough,” he said.

Gates argued that safeguards would not dramatically hinder the industry, and that the risks of not implementing them are real. “It’s not a hoax at all,” he told NBC. Gates has said he wants to meet Trump to discuss AI. “I hope that, given my life’s work in the field, my saying how unique and different this is and how concerned I am will add to what he’s hearing from other people,” Gates said. REUTERS

startup Hugging Face, a now notorious incident that raised fears the industry was losing control.

In a meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping this week, President Donald Trump agreed to share information on AI dangers and coordinate efforts to keep it safe. AP



Protest Camping

People set up tents at Puerta del Sol square in protest against Spain’s housing crisis — after the forceful eviction of an 87-year-old woman from her apartment — in Madrid on Sunday. REUTERS

21 killed as heavy rains trigger floods, landslides across Nepal

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, September 27

AT LEAST 21 people have been killed in floods, landslides and other rain-related incidents across Nepal over the past few days, officials said on Sunday.

This comes as relentless rainfall triggered fresh flooding, swept away houses and disrupted road traffic in several parts of the country.

The Himalayan nation is still reeling from last month’s devastating flash floods, which killed at least 1,453 people, while more than 5,000 remain missing.

Five people were killed after a landslide buried a house in Mathagadhi Rural Municipal

2 dead, 10 missing after avalanche strikes Himlung Himal base camp

TWO PEOPLE were killed and 10 others remained missing after an avalanche struck the Himlung Himal peak in Manang district on Sunday, police said.

The avalanche at the base camp of the 7,126 metre Himlung Himal peak in the Nar Phu area buried a tent where nine climbers and 13 support staff

were taking shelter.

Around 12 people went missing after the incident, according to DSP Shailendra Thapa. Bodies of two people were found on the peak later, while 10 others remained missing, police said.

According to Thapa, all those missing are Nepalese nationals. PTI

ity of Palpa district on Saturday night.

Their bodies were recovered on Sunday morning. Separately, 16 people were

killed in floods, landslides, lightning and other rain-related incidents over the past four days, taking the overall toll to 21.

• LOURDES HAS ALSO BECOME A PLACE OF HEALING FOR SURVIVORS OF CLERGY SEXUAL ABUSE; THE FRENCH CHURCH HAS ENDURED A BRUTAL RECKONING WITH ITS LEGACY OF ABUSE

At French shrine known for miraculous cures, Pope Leo urges protection of weakest

Nicole Winfield
Lourdes, September 27

POPE LEO XIV doubled down on his opposition to euthanasia and medically assisted dying during a visit Sunday to Lourdes, the French Catholic shrine associated with miraculous cures and now also a place of healing for survivors of clergy sexual abuse.

Leo denounced the “current trends that seek to redefine the value of human life in illness, suffering and old age,” during a Mass on the Lourdes prairie before some 150,000 people, many of them in wheelchairs. “Here, no one is turned away

due to their frailty,” Leo said in his homily.

Leo travelled to the foothills of the Pyrenees on the second leg of his four-day visit to France, the once staunchly Catholic but officially secular country. The visit has been marked by huge crowds — 800,000 at Leo’s Mass on Paris’ iconic Place de la Concorde — and his messaging against legislation allowing assisted dying that was recently approved in France and several other countries.

Lourdes became a major pilgrimage destination after the Catholic Church officially recognized visions of the Virgin

Mary reported here by a young girl in 1858. The site near the Spanish border draws millions of pilgrims each year, especially sick and disabled believers hoping for a cure from the famed spring water in the Lourdes grotto where the visions purportedly occurred.

Leo arrived in Lourdes for Paris on Saturday night and immediately prayed inside the Grotto of Apparitions and drank from the spring. “He has given a message of hope for France, a message of hope and greatness for France, and renewal for France,” said Paris pilgrim Pierre Caziljc.

“Your crutches, your wheel-



Pope Leo at a Mass on the Prairie at the Sanctuary of Our Lady of Lourdes, during his apostolic journey to France, on Sunday. REUTERS

chairs and your hidden tears are not obstacles; instead, they are the very place where you

are fully respected and welcomed,” Leo said.

More recently, Lourdes has

also become a place of healing for survivors of clergy sexual abuse. Leo was to meet with seven survivors on Sunday, including one who was abused as an adult, in recognition of the new frontier of the abuse crisis facing the church. The French church has endured a brutal reckoning with its legacy of abuse. An independent report in 2021 estimated 330,000 children had been abused over 70 years by some 3,000 priests and church workers.

Despite criticism of the report’s methodology and conclusions, French bishops put in place an independent system of compensation for victims

that to date has recommended the church pay out more than \$22.7 million.

During a meeting with French bishops on Sunday morning, Leo praised their response to victims and urged them to continue. But he also acknowledged that the cratering in priestly vocations in the French church is related to the scandal, given the priesthood is now sometimes viewed with suspicion.

“For priestly vocations to flourish, the priest must be welcomed, accepted, and loved,” Leo said.

On the day Leo arrived in Paris, a group of victims wrote

an open letter asking him to acknowledge the church’s responsibility and criticising that the seven survivors were chosen by the church, not victims’ groups.

“The Church must relinquish its position as both judge and party to the proceedings,” they wrote in the letter published by French newspaper ‘Liberation’. Monsignor Pierre-Antoine Bozo, spokesperson for the bishops’ conference, said two of the seven had actually been proposed by victims’ groups and that Leo intentionally wanted to keep the group small to facilitate a closer encounter. AP

NEW TAX DISCLOSURE SCHEME INTENDED TO ADDRESS SMALL TAXPAYERS’ PRACTICAL ISSUES

Income Tax Dept shares foreign assets info, nudges for disclosure

Aakash Magazine
New Delhi, September 27

IN A bid to nudge taxpayers to report overseas assets under the ongoing disclosure scheme — Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS) — the Income Tax Department has sent out a series of e-mails and messages to them, sharing specific information about the ownership of overseas stocks, bank accounts or assets.

In the e-mails and messages shared with the taxpayers, the Income Tax Department said that its records indicate ownership of overseas assets that may have been “unreported or acquired from undisclosed sources”, urging taxpayers to check details in their Annual Information Statement (AIS) on the income tax portal and then report under the disclosure scheme, three people aware of the communication said.

The e-mails have been sent to the taxpayers with the subject line — ‘Important advisory: opportunity for voluntary compliance regarding FAST-DS, 2026’, adding that it was a system-generated communication. One of the taxpayers told *The Indian Express* that he has

received a notice for holding a bank account in Singapore when he used to have non-resident status a few years ago, while another taxpayer said that he got the notice for his overseas bank accounts opened during his studies that subsequently turned dormant and are purged.

An income tax official said that the Department had been planning to share the details about ownership of overseas assets with the taxpayers to nudge them towards FAST-DS, but did not specify the number of such communications sent to the taxpayers.

Many taxpayers shared their notices on social media platforms like X and Reddit. One of them, Kapil, posted that he had received a notice for one of his bank accounts opened in Europe where he lived for four years and then returned to India in December 2022. He claimed one of the active European bank accounts had zero balance, and that he has been filing income tax returns for the last three years. Now, in his AIS, the Income Tax Department has shown details of another European bank account with zero balance over the last three years.

The query posted by him to



FAST-DS 2026 provides small taxpayers a one-time window to voluntarily disclose foreign assets. REUTERS

other social media users was whether he was supposed to pay Rs 1 lakh penalty and whether signing up for FAST-DS means an acceptance of a mistake.

The e-mail shared by the tax department asks taxpayers to log into the e-filing portal, check the details and use ‘Kar Saathi’ on the portal for assistance regarding forms, compliance, procedures and related queries.

“Our records indicate that you may have overseas financial interests (such as bank accounts, shares, immovable property etc), acquired in earlier years that are required to be reported in the Income Tax Re-

turn. If your overseas financial interests (assets/income) have been left unreported in your earlier Income Tax Returns or have been acquired through undisclosed sources, we encourage you to utilise the on-going, one-time compliance window under the FAST-DS (Foreign Asset of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme). This dedicated window is open till 31.12.2026. Also, you may view your Foreign Assets Information on the AIS through the e-filing portal,” the e-mail from the tax department stated.

Many taxpayers complained of not having access to

Why IRDAI’s proposals to reform insurance sector hit stocks of distributors, banks

Aakash Mandal
Mumbai, September 27

ON WEDNESDAY, India’s insurance regulator issued a consultation paper on reforming various aspects of insurance — including its distribution, structure, expenses and commissions. Over Thursday and Friday, however, insurance companies saw their shares getting pummeled on the stock market.

PB Fintech, the parent company of Policybazaar, fared the worst: it fell 36% on Thursday and followed it up with another 3% fall on Friday. TurtleMint, another insurance distribution platform, slumped 20% on both Thursday and Friday. Max Financial Services, which lost 10% on Thursday, gained 3% on Friday. HDFC Life and ICICI Prudential Life Insurance are down 4-5% since Wednesday’s close. Many banks have also ended lower.

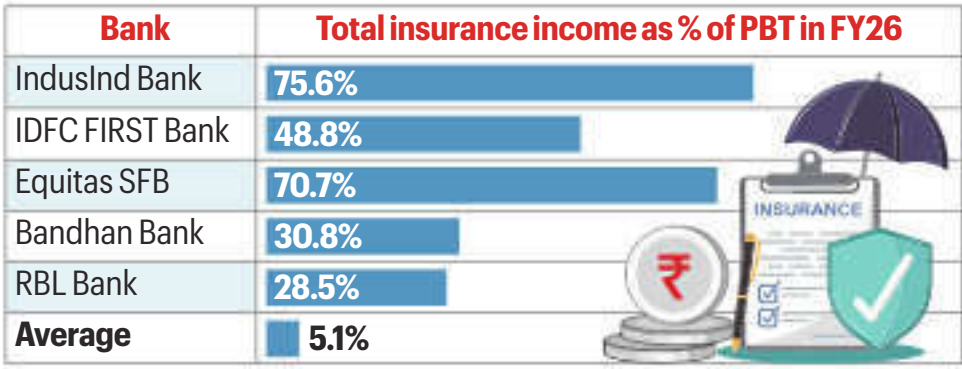
But why have the proposed reforms by Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) led to insurance distributors facing so much heat from investors?

In its paper, titled ‘Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution’, IRDAI proposed a host of reforms aimed at improving consumer protection, reducing mis-selling of products, and countering dark patterns in the industry. While this is good news for households and other buyers of insurance policies, it will eat into the profit margins of the companies distributing these policies.

Consider life insurance, where IRDAI wants the commission in the first year to be a maximum of 20% of premium for distributors and 25% for agents. This would be less than half the commissions charged currently, with the regulator in 2023 having scrapped such commission caps.

The regulator has called for comments by October 25 on its proposed reforms.

• Banks with highest exposure to insurance



SOURCE: JIM FINANCIAL, NOTE: PBT REFERS TO PROFIT BEFORE TAX; SFB IS SMALL FINANCE BANK

Limits on commissions especially hurt online insurance aggregators like Policybazaar and TurtleMint, which have high customer acquisition costs compared to others who depend on a network of agents, such as Life Insurance Corporation of India. Online aggregators depend heavily on upfront commissions.

Commissions, expenses

What the proposals address are the rapid rise in money earned through commissions, with IRDAI’s paper pointing out that sales are led by commissions, instead of pricing and quality.

Citing the example of general insurance, IRDAI said that while premiums from brokers in 2024-25 was 37% higher from 2022-23, commissions were up a huge 173%. Then there is life insurance: premiums from corporate agents rose 28% over the two years, but commissions surged 125%.

What this means is that a distributor’s income has grown 4-5 times faster than premiums. “In efficient markets, consumers compare products on suitability, price and quality. In the country’s insurance sector, heavy dependence on commission-led distribution and lack of transparency on pricing and quality has clogged these competition signals. High distribution payouts have weakened the competition outcomes away from better value to customers,” the paper said.

Another proposal refers to

the reduction in the Expense of Management, or EoM, to 12.5% and 20% of life and general insurers’ gross direct premium income, respectively, over a five-year period, with limits also set for 2028-29. EoM is the cost an insurance company charges against the premiums it gets. This includes administrative and distribution costs, including commissions paid to agents. EoMs can rise as insurers bid to secure top distributors.

According to CareEdge Ratings, the EoM of 20 of India’s 22 life insurers and 28 of 31 general insurers is currently higher than the proposed limits for 2028-29.

Impact on banks

Banks are an important distribution channel given the cross-selling opportunities and the lenders’ deep distribution networks. And commission caps are expected to hurt banks with multiple tie-ups and heavy incentive-led payouts compared to those who have single partnerships, brokerage JM Financial noted. According to it, the average income from insurance distribution for banks across its coverage has risen to 5.1% of profit before tax in 2025-26 from 3.5% in 2022-23.

“Insurance distribution is a high-margin and capital-light annuity that leverages an existing customer franchise, branch network and technology stack, and a lower commission cap therefore transmits to operating profit,” said Ishank Gupta, an analyst at Choice Institutional Equities.

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Life of buildings to gold: Lesser known changes in GDP series

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 27

FIVE ASPECTS of the new GDP series have dominated the discourse over the last year or so. These include the base year being updated from 2011-12 to 2022-23, the use of ‘double deflation’ to arrive at real gross value added (GVA), output Producer Price Index (PPI) and Banking Services Price Index (BSPI) being used in double deflation, better estimates of the informal sector through use of surveys, and expectation of no difference — or discrepancy — between annual GDP numbers arrived at by production and expenditure methods. While these grabbed most headlines, they are not the only changes in the new GDP series. Here are five other alterations as described in the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation’s (MoSPI) ‘Sources and Methods’ document, released Monday.

Manufacturing or services?

A key change the new 2022-23 base year series makes from the old 2011-12 one is the classification of an enterprise in a sector. Imagine an enterprise called XYZ involved in multiple activities — it does some manufacturing and provides some services too — and with an annual turnover of Rs 100 and a GVA of Rs 50. Is XYZ part of the manufacturing or services sector?

In the old GDP series, this question would be answered by XYZ’s ‘major activity’. This means, if Rs 70 of XYZ’s Rs 100 turnover came from manufacturing, it was part of that sector and the entire GVA of Rs 50 was assigned to manufacturing even

The new series assumes a lower ‘average useful life’ for several types of assets, including 60-75 years for dwellings, down from 70-80 years in the old series

if some of it came from services sold. In the new GDP series, XYZ’s GVA goes to both manufacturing and services depending on their shares — if Rs 20 of GVA came from service activities, that goes to the services sector and the remaining to manufacturing.

How is this distinction possible now? Because of two forms called MGT-7 and MGT-7A that companies have to fill with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs.

MGT-7 is for public and private companies, while MGT-7A is for one-person and small companies. These forms must be submitted every financial year and require details regarding financial results, management structure, shareholding, and loans taken, among others.

Government housing

There are lakhs of government employees — some get accommodations and some get House Rent Allowance (HRA). While HRA reflects in the pay, the value of the housing service provided by the government to staff who get accommodations was previously not being accounted for. In the new GDP series, to value the housing services provided by the government, the cost of making these houses has been used after deducting the cost of repair, main-

tenance, and the annual consumption of this fixed capital.

Useful life of assets

The annual consumption of a house in the above section cannot be calculated without knowing how long it will last. And the new series assumes a lower ‘average useful life’ for several types of assets. For example, the average useful life of dwellings is now assumed to be 60-75 years, down from 70-80 years in the old series.

Household savings

MoSPI’s national accounts data is best known for the main GDP growth number. But it also contains other crucial pieces of information. One of them is on savings, including those of households, which are in the form of financial and physical assets, including valuables like gold. The new GDP series has made one major change in the compilation of household savings, with data on financial savings like shares, debentures, hybrid instruments, and mutual funds now taken from the Securities and Exchange Board of India instead of the Reserve Bank of India. This has allowed for inclusion of new instruments like Real Estate Investment Trust, Investment Trust, and Alternate Investment Funds.

Rooftop solar

The ‘electricity, gas, water supply & other utility services’ sub-sector produced a real GVA of Rs 1.92 lakh crore in April-June 2026, 8.9% higher than a year ago. And this now includes electricity produced by households for themselves through rooftop solar panels.

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Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, addressing the UP International Trade Show in Greater Noida on Sunday, said Uttar Pradesh has emerged as a preferred investment destination due to favourable industrial policies and its ability to attract large companies. PTI

UP drawing investments

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, addressing the UP International Trade Show in Greater Noida on Sunday, said Uttar Pradesh has emerged as a preferred investment destination due to favourable industrial policies and its ability to attract large companies. PTI

RBI writes twice to Tata Sons, seeks update on listing plan

Urvi Malvania
Mumbai, September 27

THE RESERVE Bank of India has written to Tata Sons twice since September 11, seeking an update on the Tata Group holding company’s plans to comply with the mandatory listing requirement, people aware of the matter said.

Tata Sons is compiling its response and has told the central bank that it will expedite the process, the people said. The board remains firm on its decision to comply with the RBI’s directive, they added.

The board is expected to meet to finalise the details of its response, including a time frame for the listing.

At its September 17 meeting, the Tata Sons board resolved to initiate the process for listing the holding company. The move

came days after the RBI rejected Tata Sons’ application to surrender its Certificate of Registration (CoR) and directed it to comply with regulations applicable to non-banking financial companies classified in the Upper Layer (NBFC-UL).

At the September 17 meeting, Tata Trusts chairman and Tata Sons nominee director Noel Tata reiterated the Trusts’ position that the holding company should remain privately held. He also sought from Chairman N Chandrasekaran a detailed account of the correspondence between Tata Sons and the RBI on the regulatory and listing issues, the people said.

Tata Sons has since sent Noel Tata a package of documents running into about 600 pages, containing its correspondence with the RBI, people aware of the matter said. FE

Inside Manesar institute’s push to bring women into manufacturing

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 27

TUCKED AWAY from the bustle of the city, the two-storeyed building of the Japan-India Institute for Manufacturing (JIM) is easy to miss amid the lush paddy fields of Haryana’s Manesar. But step inside, and the quietness outside gives way to the hum of machines, the clatter of tools, and students moving from one workbench to another as they learn to operate the equipment.

In between the clamour, Nishika leaned over a workbench, carefully practising how to fit nuts and bolts. She made one attempt after another, trying to get it right with the tools in her hand.

For most students training for the manufacturing workforce, it was an ordinary practical

lesson. For Nishika, it was also a step into a field she had been unable to pursue through the conventional academic route.

“I want to do a polytechnic course after this. I could not appear for the entrance exam earlier because I did not have chemistry and physics. Now, I can sit for the exam and directly enter the second year of the polytechnic course,” said Nishika, who hails from Haryana’s Sonapat, speaking to *The Indian Express* during a visit to the institute.

At JIM Manesar — one of four such institutes set up by the country’s largest automaker Maruti Suzuki — Nishika is pursuing a two-year Mechanic Motor Vehicle course covering car engines, repairs and painting. It is one of five two-year trades — a term used for specific vocational training courses — offered by the institute. The others are Electrician, Fitter, Electronic Mechanic and Electrician-Mechatronics. JIM also offers four one-year trades: Mechanic Diesel Engine, Welder, Mechanic Auto Body Repair, and Mechanic Auto Body Painting.



Nishika (right), a student of the two-year Mechanic Motor Vehicle course at JIM Manesar, practising at a workshop. PRATYUSH DEEP

But in a class of 40 students,

Nishika is one of just three girls.

The gender gap extends beyond JIM. Women remain underrepresented in India’s core engineering trades. A new working paper by NITI Aayog found that women accounted for only 5.5% of enrolment in engineering trades such as electrician,

fitter and welder across the Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) between 2019 and 2024. In contrast, women outnumbered men in several service-oriented trades such as fashion design, cosmetology, secretarial practice, and sewing technology.

JIM Manesar has also seen female enrolment rise, though from a low base. Women account for around 9% of its annual intake of about 400 students, up from 5% the previous year and 2% when the institute began. It is now targeting a 30% female share of admissions by 2028-29. Across the four JIMs, only the Manesar branch has female students, while the other three are yet to admit them.

At Manesar, the institute is taking a multi-pronged approach to increase female participation, including a dedicated women’s

hostel, greater representation of women among faculty and support staff — and, from this academic year, a 100% tuition fee waiver for female students, said Rahul Bharti, Senior Executive Officer, Corporate Affairs, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. “We believe this initiative will encourage more young women to pursue careers in manufacturing and participate in the growth of India’s industrial workforce,” he added.

The hostel could ease one of the practical hurdles for women coming from outside Manesar. Most of the female students at the institute come from different parts of Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, and stay in local paying guest accommodations.

(The writer’s trip to JIM was organised by Maruti Suzuki)

FULL REPORT ON
[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)

Industry participants say jewellery demand is expected to pick up during the upcoming festival period, but sales volumes may remain subdued from a year-ago due to higher prices. Moreover, smaller jewellers are likely to remain under pressure as surging precious metals prices are expected to push buyers towards larger, trusted retail chains.

“We are entering the festive season with a cautiously positive outlook,” said Aditya

Modak, Director at PNGS Reva Diamonds, a sister company of jewellery chain PN Gadgil & Sons. “The first half of the year was challenging for jewellery industry, largely because elevated gold prices made consumers more price-conscious and led to a shift towards lighter-weight purchases. However, we are now seeing improving consumer sentiment as the festive and wedding season gains momentum,” added Modak.

Prithviraj Kothari, President, India Bullion and Jewellers Association, also noted positive momentum during Ganesh Chaturthi. “After a subdued first half, we’re seeing early signs of a genuine revival in festive buying. Ganesh Chaturthi set an encouraging tone. Footfall picked up meaningfully compared to the softer trend earlier in the year, with consumers returning for both auspicious purchases and lightweight, everyday-wear pieces,” said Kothari.

Jewellers that *The Indian Express* spoke with expect to sell a lower jewellery quantity over the festive period *vis-à-vis* last year as high gold and silver prices are likely to keep some potential customers at bay. Even among those that are likely to buy jewellery, gramage for many could be lower than what they may have had in mind.

Jewellers expect that the sales volume decline will be offset by higher realisations due to elevated prices. “Festive season in India is always strong, and I don’t expect it to be otherwise this time round too. Gold prices are obviously high, so I guess volumes in terms of kgs or tonnes may come down a bit. Maybe 10-15%. But the value will make up for the growth for everyone,” said Colin Shah, Managing Director, Kama Jewellery.

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Idea Exchange

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY SUDHANSHU DHULIA

Justice Sudhanshu Dhulia, who retired from the Supreme Court of India last year, is renowned for his well-reasoned views, grounded philosophy and dedication to individual liberty. He brought a unique humanity to important legal issues. His career, from his early legal practice at the Allahabad High Court to his time as Chief Justice of the Gauhati High Court and then as a Supreme Court judge, demonstrated a constant dedication to preserving constitutional freedoms and protecting fundamental rights

Aamir Khan: *The Indian Express* recently reported on the Election Commission and the internal rupture. In something this significant, what should the judiciary's role be? Should the apex court take suo motu cognisance in matters of such public importance?

If the decisions of the Election Commission of India were taken only by the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), the way it has been presented by *The Indian Express*, then it becomes a serious matter. But we do not know, and it's too early for anyone to say. The other side has not been heard. But if it is what you said it is, then it is, of course, serious. I am not denying it. The judiciary, in a related matter, has already taken cognisance of it. So this matter may go there. The matter is sub judice. On its own, the judiciary can, but it depends on case-by-case basis. The judiciary should also exercise a lot of restraint, so unless and until there are very compelling reasons, the judiciary normally would not.

Aamir Khan: There was a split verdict in the Supreme Court on the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners. During the arguments, the government compared the Collegium system with appointments to the Election Commission (EC), which Justice Dipankar Datta called disquieting. Should there be any comparison at all between Collegium appointments and appointments to the EC?

In 2023, a Constitution Bench, in the Anoop Baranwal vs Government of India case, decided that although Article 324 clearly states that the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners will be made by the President, subject to the law made by Parliament, the law was not made for more than 70 years. It is a very scholarly, detailed judgement, an almost unanimous judgement. One judge differs on a minor aspect, but that says that there must be some law on it, and these appointments cannot be made by executives alone. So what the Supreme Court said in that is: till a law is made, the Prime Minister, leader of Opposition, and the Chief Justice will be there. The idea behind it was that it should not be merely a Cabinet decision, considering the independence of this body.

Democracy is not just about voting for a political party, which comes to power and replaces the earlier one; we must have stable, reliable democratic institutions, and the Election Commission must inherently be an independent body. So, at the root of it was: how can we have an independent Election Commission? The procedure was absolutely important, and there should be absolute independence, with no political executive dominance in it. It was said with that spirit.

Now, in that judgement too, this was subject to the law made by Parliament. Parliament then made the 2023 law, which says it should be the PM, leader of Opposition, and one cabinet minister nominated by the PM. Justice Dipankar Datta repeatedly asked the Attorney General whether the cabinet minister could differ, and even the Attorney General said no. So the matter was being looked into and there were several petitions arguing that the selection committee should reflect independence from the Executive. That matter was in the court for two years, and pleadings were exchanged. Initially, the government never said that it had to be referred to a larger Constitution Bench; that came at a later stage. Secondly, Justice Datta said what was required was an application of settled constitutional principles. Under Article 145, only a matter involving a substantial question of law relating to the Constitution — one that has not been settled — should go to a Constitution Bench. But here, everything was settled; nobody can deny that the Election Commission should be independent. Whether the procedure is fair or the people involved have independence can be seen through settled judicial pronouncements. So I agree with Justice Datta that there was no reason to refer this to a Constitution Bench. As for the comparison with the Collegium system, Justice Datta said this was only an oral submission by the Solicitor General, not part of the written pleadings. He said he would not have addressed it, but since it is repeatedly argued that judges appointing judges is not fair, the comparison was made: if that can be justified, so can this — no interference from outside. First, it is not true that whatever judges decide always happens. He gave examples where the collegium recommendations have not been followed, and even routine matters like transfers of judges from one High Court to another have, in some cases, not been complied with.

Aamir Khan: You have dealt with the question of language in your judgement in the context of Urdu and Marathi. We recently saw the *Vande Mataram* debate, with Carnatic vocalist TM Krishna moving the SC against penalising those who cannot sing all six stanzas. Drawing from your own jurisprudence on liberty and freedom, what is your view on this?

It is already a law that is settled by the Supreme Court in one of the most important judgments called *Bijoe Emmanuel & Ors. vs State of Kerala*. It is the 1986 judgement by one of my most favourite judges, Justice O Chinnappa Reddy. There were three girls in



ON FORMER JUDGE YASHWANT VARMA

The matter could have been dealt with in a better way, perhaps... On one hand was transparency, because of which this became known. But independence of the judiciary also has to be taken into consideration



ON PRECEDENTS NOT BEING FOLLOWED

A definite, settled opinion must come from the SC because all other courts depend on its verdict on what the law is. If that keeps changing, it unsettles many things. That should not happen. Unfortunately, it is happening more

‘If decisions were being taken only by CEC, it is serious... We must have reliable, democratic institutions’

Justice Sudhanshu Dhulia on importance of protecting Election Commission's independence from Executive dominance, burden of proving citizenship and why prolonged incarceration of Umar Khalid raises questions of liberty. The conversation was moderated by Aamir Khan, Head - Legal Project, *The Indian Express (Digital)*



Justice Sudhanshu Dhulia (right) in conversation with Aamir Khan, Head — Legal Project, *The Indian Express (Digital)* RENUKA PURI

Kerala studying in a government school who belonged to a religious minority called Jehovah's Witnesses. In their sect, they take what is said in the Bible literally and are not allowed to sing for anybody but Jehovah. So when the National Anthem was sung in the morning, these three girls didn't sing, but stood up respectfully. They were compelled to sing; they refused and were removed from the school. They filed a writ petition before the Kerala High Court, which was dismissed. A writ appeal before the division bench was also dismissed. Finally, they came to the Supreme Court. Justice Reddy and another judge allowed the petition and said it was not an insult to the national anthem. The entire Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, was discussed in the judgment. It says, how do you insult a national flag? When you burn it, by an overt act, you disrespect or insult it. There was no such thing here. When the national anthem was being sung, these girls respectfully stood up. Since their religion banned it, they didn't sing. Justice Reddy said that at the bottom of it is the spirit of tolerance in our Constitution. Religions teach tolerance, our culture preaches tolerance, our Constitution practises tolerance; let us not dilute it. I think this is the law, and this is how it should be taken. There is absolutely no doubt that *Vande Mataram* is the national song. The controversy is whether the first two stanzas have to be sung or all six. That will be decided by the Supreme Court. What happens if somebody doesn't sing? On that, there is already a law.

Aamir Khan: Delhi saw several incidents of sexual violence, including a recent gang rape and the students of Lady Sriram College (LSR) have been holding protests over it. The university association has since asked students to attend classes online. Where is the disconnect in ensuring

safety and protecting their right to attend college?

It is like saying if food poisoning happens, don't eat. Who can disagree with this proposition that the life and liberty of every citizen is of prime importance? The Constitution of India gives it to you; Article 21 protects life and liberty. This particular remark about asking girls seems totally absurd. As far as courts are concerned, you are saying that they should interfere in this matter. The court will interfere when the matter comes to the court.

Saurabh Dwivedi: In the case of Justice Yashwant Varma, what happened, and could the Supreme Court have dealt with it in a better way? Should the court not have taken suo motu cognisance of the matter?

The reports of two inquiries are in front

of you. And he has resigned. I don't think there is any scenario of impeachment left, because he is no longer a judge of the High Court. And the law on that is the Supreme Court's law that the moment a judge resigns, acceptance is not required. Yes, it could have been dealt with in a better way, perhaps. When this incident happened, the Chief Justice at that time, Justice Khanna, had the alternative where all these video recordings did not go into public domain. But he said, no, this should go out. The independence of the judiciary also has to be taken into consideration. On one hand was transparency, because of which this became known; otherwise you wouldn't have known at all. Everyone found out this happened, and this news was not banned. But at the same time, it was the police's procedure, which was stopped. An in-house inquiry took place. In

the inquiry too, it came out that this happened, and he resigned. Appreciate this too.

Saurabh Dwivedi: In the initial hearings of SIR regarding its legality and validity, in the bench that heard it; you were also there. Do you agree with the final verdict?

I can't say because when I was there, I was only a vacation judge for a day or two. After hearing it, we passed an interim order regarding the Aadhaar card and other things. But the actual arguments did not take place before me. So this question is better asked to those before whom the full arguments took place and who then took the decision.

Jagriti Rai: There seems to be a gap between the legal principle of bail and how society perceives it. Why is bail so often seen as a victory for the accused, rather than simply a legal right pending trial?

Bail is the rule and jail is an exception is the established principle. Justice VR Krishna Iyer said it in one of his judgements. Jail should be an exception, particularly in an ongoing trial, where the verdict has not been pronounced as yet. Now, as far as celebration is concerned, probably you are referring to those heinous offences where people should not have been released. That's the unfortunate part of it. Like the people who came out after that rape in Gujarat. Society has degenerated. You can't blame the courts and the system for it. It is a societal issue.

Somya Tyagi: What is your take on precedents not being followed in the Supreme Court? There was a seven-year ban on crackers, and then it was partially removed. There was also the Governor of Tamil Nadu case, which was later overturned.

It shouldn't happen, but it does. About

the Tamil Nadu case, the first judgement by Justice J B Pardiwala and Justice R Mahadevan on how long the governor can keep it was a judgement required under the circumstances. It was later reviewed and went to five judges. The first judgement brought a solution to a problem. The second judgement, which almost overturned it, though not fully, creates a problem for the solution. That's the difference. Many conclusions in the later judgement leave the problem unresolved. Though that judgement was very bold, even unprecedented, it was required under the circumstances. By and large, a definite, settled opinion must come from the Supreme Court because all other courts depend on its verdict on what the law is. If that keeps changing, it unsettles many things, and that should not happen. Unfortunately, it is happening more often than not.

Tista Roy Chowdhury: On September 13, Umar Khalid completed six years in jail without trial. In this kind of difficult case under UAPA, what should the State's duty be to ensure the trial is not endlessly delayed?

In Umar Khalid's case, I have read that judgement which denies bail to him and Sharjeel Imam and gives bail to others (Gul-fisha Fatima, Meeran Haider, Shifa-ur-Rehman, Mohd. Saleem Khan, and Shadab Ahmed). Before doing that, certain parameters have been set. Bail should be given to Umar Khalid, and yet it is denied to him. If you read the judgement, the word *chakka jam* (road blockade) comes at least a dozen times. For students, how many times has one done some kind of small-time *chakka jam*? *Chakka jam* doesn't mean six years in jail! A lot of people have reservations about that, and also about the fact that towards the end of it, it says he can apply only after one year, which at least the court should not have said. He should have got bail earlier because, in that case, certain parameters were set for the five people granted bail. Umar Khalid has done much less than that, yet it has not been explained why he was left out.

Ritika Chopra: When the SIR matter first came to the vacation bench, you made an intervention. The moment the question of citizenship came in, you told the lawyer, 'Be careful, don't go into that question. That's not the Election Commission's job.' When you zoom out, it has become a citizenship exercise. What do you think of it?

This is the law laid down by the Supreme Court in several earlier judgements: this is not the Election Commission of India's job. But a voter has to be a citizen of this country. The problem is the enormous conditions that have been imposed. When I was hearing the matter, nobody had asked for a stay, so why give one? They were only asking for Aadhaar and voter cards to be accepted, so we said fine. That's all I did, which they agreed to.

Ritika Chopra: During the SIR exercise, the Supreme Court had said that everyone flagged as having a 'logical discrepancy' should be heard, given an opportunity to make their case, and then have a decision taken accordingly. Our investigation found that Goa did that and felt that 97 voters should be brought back onto the rolls, but then its CEO kept writing to the Election Commission asking it to reverse those decisions. Yet these voters were still left off the rolls. Does that amount to contempt of court?

Contempt of court is a deliberate and wilful disobedience of a court order. So, first of all, whether some order has been violated has to be proved, and whether that violation was deliberate and wilful also has to be proved. It's quite possible that they may say, and I'm playing the devil's advocate here, 'No, instructions were given, but some lower-level officers have not followed them.' Contempt of court is not an easy path to tread here.

Khushi Sinha: You've said in the past that 'if someone is living in India, then that person should be presumed Indian'. Should the State, therefore, bear the burden of proving otherwise?

That was said in the context where the Ministry of External Affairs had taken out a circular saying that a passport is only a travel document and not proof of citizenship. Very technically, it may be correct, because a passport is to show other countries that you are a citizen of this country. There are various other parameters of citizenship which you have to fulfil in India to avail the laws and the benefits... If I am staying in India, then I am an Indian. The burden of proof to prove that I am not a citizen is on who is asking. It may be CBI, police, whatever. So you can't put the burden of proof on me to state my citizenship. Let's say I will give some proof. But what about a villager who has not gone to any school? What proof will he get? His name may not even be registered in the Gram register. There may be some people like that. We don't get a report even from authorised agencies for years.

Aamir Khan: Which is your favourite film of Tigmanshu Dhulia, your younger brother?

I really liked *Haasil* (2003). I think *Paan Singh Tomar* (2012) is a complete film.



ON BAIL FOR UMAR KHALID

Umar Khalid should have got bail earlier because, in that case, certain parameters were set for the five people granted bail. Umar has done much less, yet it has not been explained why he was left out

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Why ADHD, autism are going up

NEW RESEARCH suggests that the characteristics of children and teenagers receiving attention deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) or autism spectrum disorder (ASD) diagnoses have shifted over the past decade. The study, led by the Barcelona Institute for Global Health (ISGlobal) and Aarhus University, found that those diagnosed with ADHD or ASD in Denmark now closely resemble the broader population than those who received the same diagnoses 10 years ago. While awareness has increased, the point at which neurodevelopmental characteristics are considered clinically impairing may have changed.



Why ageing muscles lose strength

NEW DISCOVERY from the University of Missouri is revealing an overlooked reason muscles can lose strength with age. The researchers identified a protein that may offer a way to improve how ageing muscles respond to nerve signals, raising the possibility that at least part of this decline could eventually be treated. Finding the source of this communication problem also revealed a possible strategy for restoring some lost muscle function. The findings could eventually lead to treatments designed to help older adults remain active and independent, from walking safely to continuing everyday activities with family.



REM sleep linked to low disease risk

A LARGE STUDY tracking more than 95,000 people suggests that how you sleep may be linked to your risk of developing dozens of diseases. People who spent more time in REM (rapid eye movement) sleep had lower risks of 83 conditions, including dementia, heart failure and Parkinson's disease, while more deep sleep was associated with lower risks of conditions such as Type 2 diabetes and major depression. REM sleep is critical for brain health, memory consolidation and emotional regulation. The findings provide evidence supporting six-eight hour sleep duration as a health safeguard.



New drug for resistant cancer

RESEARCHERS AT Baylor College of Medicine have developed an experimental drug called CS18 that may help cancer treatments work against tumours that have become resistant to therapy. The study provides early evidence supporting further investigation of CS18 as a future cancer treatment. While some therapies are effective at the beginning, many patients eventually relapse because cancer cells can activate compensatory and convergent biological pathways that allow them to overcome the toxic effects of therapy, promoting survival. CS18 was also found to be less toxic to non-cancerous cells.



Food additives linked to high BP

COMMON PRESERVATIVES hiding in processed foods may carry unexpected heart risks, with heavy consumption linked to substantially higher rates of high blood pressure and cardiovascular disease. Researchers at INSERM (the French National Institute for Health and Medical Research), identified eight widely used preservatives associated with hypertension. Participants with the highest intake of 'non-antioxidant' preservatives had a 29% higher risk of hypertension than those consuming the lowest amounts. They also had a 16% higher risk of cardiovascular disease.



INTERPRETATIONS OF MALADY

DR SURANJIT CHATTERJEE

SENIOR CONSULTANT, INTERNAL MEDICINE, INDRAPRASTHA APOLLO HOSPITALS

Your food can affect how your antibiotics work

Calcium can bind to antibiotic molecules in the gut and form a compound that the body cannot absorb easily

YOU TAKE an antibiotic on time, with a glass of water, and assume the medicine will simply do its job. But sometimes, what comes with that tablet matters too. The milk in your morning tea, a bowl of curd, your regular cup of coffee or even a glass of wine can interact with certain antibiotics. These interactions can affect how much of the medicine the body absorbs, how it is broken down or how strongly its side effects are felt.

This does not mean every antibiotic needs to be taken on an empty stomach or that patients need to change their entire diet. The interaction depends on the specific antibiotic. Knowing which food or drink matters can, however, help the medicine work as intended and boost its efficacy.

Dairy and calcium-rich foods can be a concern with certain antibiotics, particularly tetracyclines such as doxycycline and tetracycline, and fluoroquinolones such as ciprofloxacin and levofloxacin. Calcium can bind to these antibiotic molecules in the digestive tract and form a compound that the body cannot absorb easily. As a result, less of the medicine reaches the bloodstream.

This applies not only to milk, cheese and yogurt but also to calcium-fortified juices, tofu and calcium supplements. The medicine may need to be taken separately from these foods, depending on the antibiotic prescribed.

Grapefruit and pomelo can interfere with the way certain medicines are processed in the body. With erythromycin and certain other macrolides, grapefruit can affect enzymes involved in drug metabolism, potentially changing antibiotic levels in the blood. This is why patients should check whether their particular antibiotic has a grapefruit or pomelo warning rather than assuming all fruits are safe with every medicine.



A small change in timing or an avoidable food interaction can sometimes make the difference between getting the intended benefit from an antibiotic and getting less than expected from the treatment

Foods of concern can include aged cheese, soy sauce, salami, tap beer and red wine.

Ciprofloxacin, a fluoroquinolone, can slow the breakdown of caffeine in the body. Excessive coffee, energy drinks or dark chocolate may, therefore, lead to stronger caffeine effects, including jitteriness, anxiety, insomnia or heart palpitations.

Alcohol needs particular caution with metronidazole and tinidazole. The combination can produce a reaction, which may cause severe nausea, vomiting, flushing, rapid heart rate and intense headaches. Foods such as lentils, beans and whole grains are an important part of a healthy diet but high-fibre meals can affect the timing and absorption of some oral medicines. Fibre can slow stomach emptying and, depending on the antibiotic and formulation, may delay how quickly the medicine enters the bloodstream and takes effect.

The answer is not to stop eating fibre or nutritious foods whenever an antibiotic is prescribed. Instead:

- Check whether the antibiotic should be taken with food or separately from meals.
- Ask about dairy, calcium, iron and magnesium supplements.
- Check whether caffeine, alcohol, grapefruit or pomelo need to be avoided.
- Follow the specific instructions for the antibiotic rather than applying the same food rule to every medicine.

There is no single "antibiotic diet." The important point is to understand the particular medicine being taken. A small change in timing or an avoidable food interaction can sometimes make the difference between getting the intended benefit from an antibiotic and getting less than expected from the treatment.

The heartbeat you can't hear

On the eve of World Heart Day, here are stories of two young women. Two rare cardiac conditions. And two very different journeys to discovering that something was wrong with a heart that, on the surface, looked perfectly normal

Tabshir Shams

THEY WERE busy being young, their lives pivoted around studies, family and everyday routine. Yet inside their hearts, two very different conditions were making them restless. Sayanee Banerjee*, 29, was living with unexplained blackouts, racing heartbeats and a tumour that routine tests failed to reveal. Rima*, 21, born with a hole in her heart and operated on at eight, remained breathless for the next 13 years before doctors discovered that the first diagnosis had not told the whole story. Their conditions were rare but their journeys raise a larger question: What happens when a young heart does not behave as it should, yet the reason stays hidden?

As an MTech graduate in nanotechnology, preparing for the UPSC examination and living the college-studies-home repeat routine, Sayanee breezed through health issues till she started experiencing blackouts, the frequency of which gradually increased. The first time, she was out with her parents. The second, she collapsed in a mall. Her heart rate was 110 to 115 beats a minute even at rest. With mild exertion, it could climb beyond 150 and sometimes touch 170. She watched the numbers on her smartwatch, but they had become so familiar that they barely registered as alarming. There were palpitations, too — strange, rapid bursts she describes as a "bubble-popping-inside-your-chest kind of feeling", accompanied by tightness near her neck. There was a persistent stiffness in her chest.

She consulted cardiologists, at least four of them. They attributed it to stress and anxiety. It took advanced imaging to reveal that her heart was hiding something none of the routine tests had shown, a tumour.

For Rima, the story stretched back 13 years. At eight, she had undergone surgery to close an atrial septal defect — a hole in the wall separating the heart's two upper chambers. It was a recognised congenital condition, and the procedure was expected to correct the problem. But she remained breathless on exertion. By 21, the symptom had persisted for more than a decade. That was when she was referred to Safdarjung Hospital, where doctors took another look. What they found was not a recurrence of the original problem, but something else entirely: a rare congenital condition called cor triatriatum, in which an abnormal membrane divides the left atrium into two chambers and can obstruct the flow of blood returning from the lungs.

Both their cases are uncommon. But together, they illustrate a larger reality of heart disease in the young: Symptoms can be subtle, diagnoses can be difficult and a normal-looking heart on an initial test does not always tell the whole story.

When tests took normal

For Sayanee, the initial investigations offered little reason to suspect a tumour. Her echocardiograms showed a structurally normal heart. There was no visible valve abnormality, no obvious mass and no impaired pumping function. Her electrocardiogram or ECG showed persistent tachycardia or racy heartbeats, but no other clear clinical marker pointed towards a structural problem, usually detectable through a misshapen heart and walls.

In that context, attributing a young patient's palpitations and elevated heart rate to anxiety was not, in itself, an extraordinary conclusion. As Dr Udgeeth Dhir, cardiothoracic and vascular surgeon at Fortis Hospital, Gurugram, who eventually treated Sayanee, explains, "The location of her tumour was unusual and could remain invisible on an echocardiogram, which uses sound waves to produce images of the heart. Depending on the angle and the chamber being examined, a mass can occupy an area that is difficult for the technique to visualise." A cardiac MRI with a CT scan revealed a mass inside the heart, what is called a cardiac lipoma. It was initially measured at nine centimetres on imaging, although a subsequent biopsy showed a slightly different size.

A lipoma is a benign tumour made up of mature fat cells. "Cardiac lipomas are very unusual," Dr Dhir says. They account for around eight per cent of cardiac tumours, while cardiac tumours themselves are extremely rare.



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HEART RISKS WOMEN IN THEIR 20S AND 30S SHOULDN'T IGNORE

● Heart disease is often thought of as a problem of later life but the foundations of cardiovascular health are laid much earlier. By late adolescence and young adulthood, some people already have risk factors such as high blood pressure, high cholesterol, obesity or Type 2 diabetes. Addressing these risks early can help reduce cardiovascular disease later in life.

● The more familiar risks still matter: smoking, high blood pressure, diabetes, high cholesterol, excess weight, physical inactivity and an unhealthy diet can all affect cardiovascular health. Chronic inflammatory or autoimmune conditions may also add to risk in some women. The European Society of Cardiology notes that cardiovascular risk assessment in women needs to take these factors into account rather than relying only on traditional risk measures. "The number of young patients is going up in our OPD. Central obesity — fat concentrated around the abdomen — is counted separately, and often considered the most visible red flag in a young patient's file," says Dr Rajiv Narang, HOD Cardiology, All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi.

● For women, the picture is more complicated because some risks are specific to their reproductive and hormonal history. Pregnancy can act as an early window into future heart health. High blood pressure during pregnancy, pre-eclampsia and gestational diabetes are associated with a greater risk of cardiovascular disease later in life. Other pregnancy complications, including premature delivery and certain pregnancy losses, have also been linked with increased cardiovascular risk.

dizziness, nausea, pain in the back, neck or jaw, or palpitations. These symptoms do not necessarily mean heart disease, but persistent or unexplained symptoms deserve medical attention rather than being automatically dismissed as stress, lack of sleep or simply being unfit.

● That does not mean every episode of a racing heart or every bout of fatigue signals a heart problem. Most symptoms have many possible causes. But young age alone should not be used to rule out cardiac disease.

Knowing your blood pressure, cholesterol and blood sugar, understanding your family history, paying attention to pregnancy-related complications and discussing persistent symptoms with a doctor are simple ways to stay ahead of cardiovascular risk. "Once you reach the age of 25, one should get a test done to ascertain these risk factors. Depending on your age, co-morbidities and your doctor's advice, these tests should be done regularly," Dr Narang says.

The problems of Sayanee's tumour were largely connected to its location. The heart is a compact organ, with little room for an abnormal mass. A tumour can interfere with its mechanical function or disrupt its electrical system. "In Sayanee's case, the lump was near the heart's electrical system and led to her episodes of dangerously fast heartbeats," says Dr Dhir.

The day everything changed

"When my doctors first told me that I had a lipoma inside my heart, honestly, I felt nothing," recalls Sayanee. She assumed there would be a solution. Then, on the day before surgery, her condition deteriorated. The blackouts returned. Her heartbeat began swinging wildly. By evening, she was in the ICU. The operation required open-heart surgery. "We put her on a heart-lung bypass machine so that her organ could be safely stopped and we could work on it without depriving the rest of the body of oxygenated blood. Then we carefully removed the tumour while preserving the surrounding heart muscle and the electrical pathways responsible for a normal heartbeat," says Dr Dhir.

Precision mattered more than speed here — cut too little, and the lipoma could recur or continue interfering with rhythm;

cut too aggressively, and the surgeon would risk damaging the very pathways responsible for a normal heartbeat. "After three months of the procedure, her heart function is now normal."

The surgery left Sayanee with a different understanding of time. "I realised that life is not just studies, my passion and my career. There is much more to life than that," she says. She remembers a line from the Rajesh Khanna film *Anand*: "*Zindagi badi honi chahiye, lambi nahi* (life does not need to be long; it needs to be large)."

Diagnosis wasn't the story

Rima's journey was less sudden, but no less revealing. At eight, she had undergone surgery to close a hole in her heart. Thirteen years after her first surgery, she continued to experience breathlessness on exertion. "She was 21 when she came to us," says Dr Anubhav Gupta, professor of Cardiology at Safdarjung Hospital. "That's when we found a rare condition where an abnormal fibrous membrane divides the left atrium, creating two chambers. Depending on how much the membrane obstructs blood flow, symptoms can range from limited to significant. In some patients, symptoms become apparent early in life. In others, they may emerge or persist later," he adds.

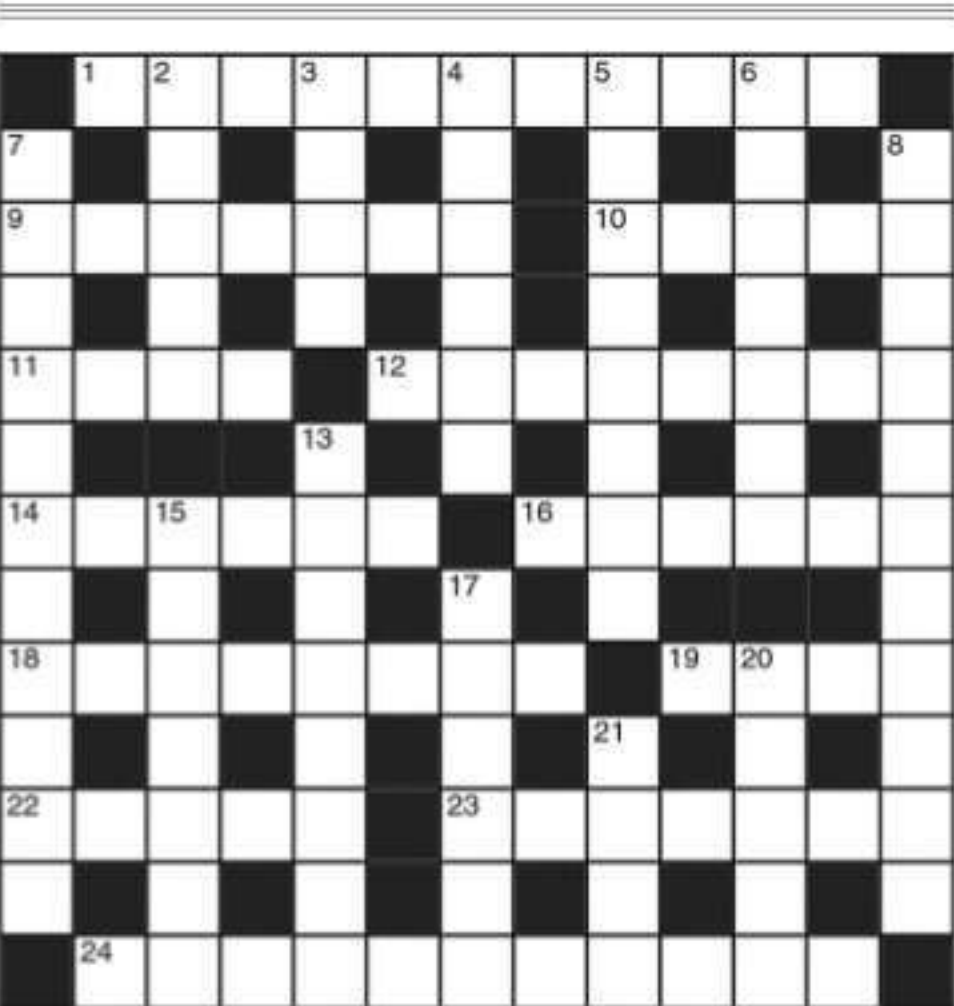
In simple terms, the abnormal membrane acts like a partial blockage between two parts of the left atrium. Blood coming from the lungs has to squeeze through an opening in the membrane before reaching the left ventricle. If the opening is large, blood flows normally and the condition may cause few or no symptoms. If the opening is narrow, blood flow is restricted, causing pressure to build up behind the blockage and toward the lungs. This can lead to breathlessness, fatigue, reduced exercise tolerance and eventually increased strain on the heart.

After imaging tests, Rima underwent an open-heart surgery like Sayanee's and now has no blood flow or breathing problems. Dr Gupta says her case illustrates why persistent symptoms deserve a fresh look. "A thorough evaluation prior to surgery and meticulous examination during surgery are essential, particularly when the clinical picture does not completely fit the initial diagnosis," he says. There is another reason for vigilance: more than one structural abnormality can coexist. Rima, he says, can typically expect to live a completely normal life with a standard life expectancy. "There is no limit on exercise and daily activities. And such a membrane does not grow back either," adds Dr Gupta.

Both Sayanee and Rima are doing well now. Both are also living more consciously in the present. For Sayanee, that means not postponing the things that matter. "If I have to tell someone I love that I love them, I wouldn't wait till tomorrow," she says. "I will tell them today itself." Rima has had a bigger takeaway. "Don't let any sign of discomfort slip through. You've got to listen to your own heart."

*Names changed to protect privacy

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Lay out cash with financial caution? Not he! (11)
9 Support the conclusion on alternative points (7)
10 Leading brief (5)
11 We object to edition being second-hand (4)
12 Casting is one of his jobs in the studio (8)
14 Struggle for doctor getting into his overall (6)
16 Animal hunt (6)
18 Got there quite dishevelled but all in one piece (8)
19 Give terrible review to a great hit (4)
22 Subject — The Middle East (5)
23 No longer clear? Try and make it so (7)
24 Too thoughtful to create wanton desecration (11)

DOWN
2 Minister of the armed forces (5)
3 He ruled in pre-Antonine Rome (4)
4 Hole at the front (6)
5 Drove off disgusted (8)
6 Squander food? (7)
7 A cruel set is about to make a comeback (11)
8 Being now engaged in arranging a better month (11)
13 Craftily trap hens for display in zoos perhaps (8)
15 New game not of interest to motorists (7)
17 Guard is fed up to death (6)
20 Jumped and broke a plate (5)
21 Fight blows up (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6104
ACROSS: 1 Endive, 4 After all, 9 In town, 10 Tear duct, 12 Tend, 13 Track, 14 Heel, 17 On the warpath, 20 Goes a long way, 23 Idle, 24 Chess, 25 Stet, 28 Ringbolt, 29 Belong, 30 Cast down, 31 Creels
DOWN: 1 Eviction, 2 Detonate, 3 Vows, 5 French polish, 6 Earn, 7 Acumen, 8 Little, 11 Breaks the law, 15 Set on, 16 Stone, 18 Two to one, 19 By stages, 21 Ctric, 22 Planks, 26 Abed, 27 Hear

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Life is a foreign language; all men ____ - Christopher Morley (12,2)

WEOOR EGRNNU

VIIST ARSCMP

SOLUTIONS: Woer, Visit, Gunner, Cramps

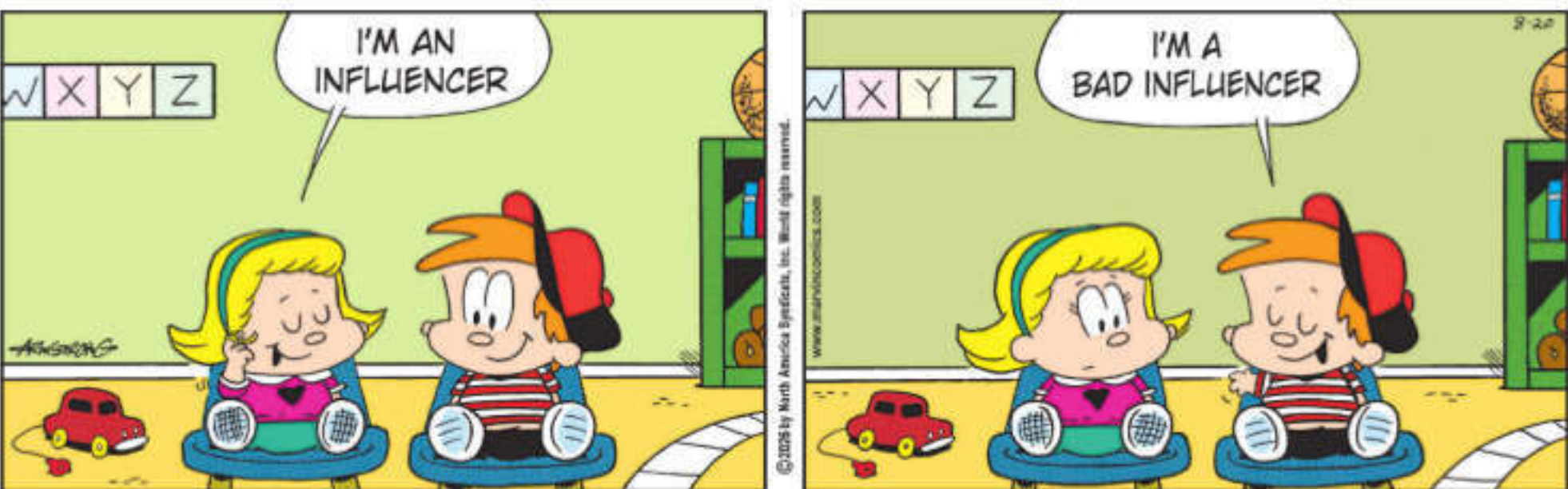
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

SUDOKU 6455

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SOLUTION SUDOKU 6454



CENTRUM HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

POSSESSION NOTICE

(As per Paragraph IV read with rule 8(1) and rule 8(2) of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Centrum Housing Finance Ltd under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, Demand Notice(s) issued by the Authorised Officer of the company to the Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below to repay the outstanding amount mentioned in the notice along with contractual interest, penal interest, charges, costs etc. within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken Possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Centrum Housing Finance Ltd for an amount of along with the contractual interest thereon and penal interest, charges, costs etc.

The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets

Sr No	Loan Account No. / Name Of The Borrower(S) / Co-Borrower(S)	Description Of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Date of Demand Notice & Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.)	Possession Taken Date
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2	MTCAG22006875 / Manish Kumar / Nanholi Ram / Ram Kali	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel Of Immovable Property Bearing Immovable Property Part of Plot No. 34, adrn. 52.25 sqmts., Khasra No. 118/2M1, Madhuvan Colony, Mauza Kaualkha, Tehsil and Distt. Agra-282001, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Part of Plot No. 34 West : Plot No. 35 North : 6.09 mts Road South : Other's Land	25-Sep-25 / Rs.10,15,523/- (Rupees Ten lakh Fifty Thousand Five Hundred Twenty Three Only)	22-Sep-26
3	LKOJS23010769 / Sandhya Devi (Legal Heir of Lt. Krishna Pal Singh) / Indradeep Gojar (Legal Heir of Lt. Krishna Pal Singh) / Legal Heir of Lt. Krishna Pal Singh	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing House No. 2107/A part of Arzi No. 282/2, adrn. 1320 sqft., Mohalla Patel Nagar, Kasba -Orai Paregna District- Jalaun-285001, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Part of Shivkumar West : Plot of Smt. Vijay Laxmi Tiwari North : Plot of Smt. Saroj alias Mumi South : Rasta 15 ft	30-Dec-25 / Rs. 6,20,192/- (Rupees Six lakh Twenty Thousand One Hundred Ninety Two Only)	22-Sep-26
4	MTCMR24015326 / Narayan Singh / Shelvala Devi	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Part of Plot No. 49, Khasra No. 12, adrn. 52.25 sqmts., Mauza- Masum Nagar Andrun Masum Nagar, Tehsil & Distt. Mathura-281001, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries:- East : Part of Plot No. 49 West : Road 20 feet North : Plot No. 50 South : Road 25 feet	09-Jun-26 / Rs.4,21,904/- (Rupees Four lakh Twenty One Thousand Nine Hundred Four Only)	22-Sep-26
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6	MTCGR24015558 / Ladli Devi (Legal Heir of Lt. Pawan Kumar Panjiyara) / Legal Heir of Lt. Pawan Kumar Panjiyara	In The Rights, Piece And Parcel of Immovable Property Bearing Part of Khasra No. 324, adrn. 811.25 sqfts., Gram -Sisuna Mushtakam, Pargana & Tehsil- Bhagwanpur, Distt. Haridwar-247661, Uttarakhand. Boundaries:- East : Prop. Of Rampal Saini West : Prop. Of Mandir North : Rasta 20 ft wide South : Prop. Of Others	09-Jun-26 / Rs.16,36,489/- (Rupees Sixteen lakh Thirty Six Thousand Four Hundred Eighty Nine Only)	22-Sep-26
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Date : 28.09.2026 / Place : Uttar Pradesh

Sd/-, Authorised Officer, For Centrum Housing Finance Ltd

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PAMI/52/136 Sr. Divisional Engineer (East)/SECR/Nagpur

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- Tender document can be download from the website of MP Police (www.mppolice.gov.in)
- Bids shall be submitted online only at MP Tenders website: <https://mptenders.gov.in/nicgep/app>
- Critical Date Sheet:

Published Date	17/09/2026 Time 18:00
Bid Document Download Start Date	17/09/2026 Time 18:00
Pre bid meeting	24/09/2026 Time 12:00
Bid Submission Start Date	28/09/2026 Time 18:00
Bid Submission End Date	08/10/2026 Time 18:00
Bid Document Download End Date	08/10/2026 Time 18:00
Bid Opening Date	09/10/2026 Time 18:00

- Intending Bidders are advised to visit this website regularly till closing date of submission to keep themselves updated as any change/ modification in the tender will be intimated through this website only by corrigendum / addendum/ amendment.
- Bids will be opened as per date/time as mentioned in the Tender Critical Date Sheet. After online opening of Technical-Bid the results of their qualification as well Price-Bid opening will be intimated latter.

G19150/26

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Financial discussions, especially about speculation, sports or dealing with your kids, might be confrontational today. However, a spouse or close friend might surprise you by saying or doing something you least expect. Tonight: Check your money.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today a power struggle with a family member or with someone where you live might take place. Your work scene might suddenly change because of something unexpected. Give yourself time for wiggle room. Pet owners should be vigilant. Tonight: You win.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): An unexpected invitation might delight you. Social plans or something to watch with sports or the arts might suddenly change. An unexpected romance might excite you. Tonight: Seek privacy.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Your home scene might be interrupted in some way today. A small appliance might break down or a minor breakage could occur. Confrontational discussions about money and possessions will require patience. Tonight: Be friendly.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): New discoveries, faces, places and ideas might be exciting today. When talking to others, you'll be frank and ready to disclose information. This is a fast-paced day with unexpected detours. Tonight: You're admired.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Avoid controversial subjects today. They might upset you. New ways to earn money could emerge. Opportunities for a new job, a way to make money on the side or to buy something special might delight you. Tonight: Learn something new.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Your personal freedom matters a lot to you today, which is why you will feel restless. You might object to certain ideas about debt and shared property. Go with your instincts. Tonight: Check your finances.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Be prepared to compromise and go more than halfway when dealing with others today. Tread carefully. Very likely, something going on behind the scenes will surprise you. Fear not: You'll handle this with grace. Tonight: Be cooperative.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Someone you know might surprise you today. Or perhaps you'll meet someone who is new and unusual. A minor struggle at work about travel or politics might be discouraging. Listen to the advice of someone younger. Tonight: Get better organised.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Either you might surprise someone today by saying or doing something, or an authority figure will surprise you. A dispute about the cost of a social event or something to do with your kids or sports might arise. Be reasonable. Tonight: Socialise.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): A chance to travel might fall in your lap today. Alternatively, travel plans might be cancelled. Avoid domestic disputes that are just power struggles. Stay flexible. Tonight: Relax at home.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Be patient with daily contacts, siblings and relatives today. You have bigger fish to fry. Something unexpected related to banking, inheritances or shared property might happen. Check details that could impact your wealth. Tonight: Discussions.

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● MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	117	47	38	202
2	Japan	37	60	57	154
3	S Korea	20	23	38	81
4	Uzb'stan	10	17	11	38
5	Kaz'stan	9	10	21	40
12	India	4	15	17	36

DAY 9 CAPSULE

Haul: 4 Silver, 3 Bronze

4 SILVER

● Women's long jump and men's high jump

Ancy Sojan settled for the silver medal, finishing behind China's Huang Yingying. In the men's high jump event, Sarvesh Kushare produced a best effort of 2.25m but lost on countback.

● Women's and men's singles squash final

Both the men's and women's finalists lost to their Malaysian counterparts. Anahat Singh settled for the silver after losing 3-0 to Sivasangari Subramaniam in the final. Abhay Singh was also handed a 3-0 loss by Ng Eain Yow.

3 BRONZE

● Women's 3000m steeplechase

Parul Chaudhary bagged a bronze with a personal best and national record time of 9:08.67.

● Men's decathlon

Tejaswin Shankar won bronze in the decathlon, after getting a total of 7934 points. This is his second Asian Games medal after a silver in Hangzhou 2023.

● Women's 200m

Harita Bhadra nabbed the bronze medal on the line, finishing just 0.01 seconds ahead of fourth-place.

● TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 10

Athletics: Women's 400m hurdles (3:53 PM), Men's 3000m Steeplechase (4:17 PM), Men's Long Jump (4:30 PM), Men's 1500m (4:38 PM)

● Hangzhou Games' gold medallist Avinash Sable and silver medallist Murali Sreeshankar will be in action in their respective. Gulveer Singh and Vithya Ramraj will compete in men's 1500m and women's 400m hurdles respectively.

Shooting: 25m Pistol Women's Team Final (6:10 AM) & Women's Individual Final (10:45 AM)

● Esha Singh, Manu Bhaker and Rahi Sarnobat will compete in women's 25 pistol individual and team events with a chance to win an elusive gold medal.

Boxing: Women's 75kg Quarter-Final (8:30 AM onwards), Women's 60kg & Men's 90kg Quarter-Finals (1:30 PM onwards)

● Lovlina Borgohain, Priya Ghanghas and Kapil Pokharia will have the chance of assuring medals for India as they compete in their respective bouts on Monday.

Men's Cricket: India vs Afghanistan (10:30 AM)

● Shreyas Iyer's men will begin their campaign with a quarter-final tie against Afghanistan at the Korogi Sports Park. Rain is expected to lash the venue.

'Haven't experienced something like this': Sindhu's gruelling 24 hours

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 27

PVSINDHU'S Saturday began at 3pm and stretched well past midnight. Her first match was delayed, while the second was shifted from Court 1 to Court 2. By the time she finally walked off court, the clock was edging towards 1am.

She could not return to her hotel, in the city centre, until around 1.30am. After ordering dinner and completing her recovery routine, she finally went to sleep at almost 3am. She was back up at 9am on Sunday, getting ready to face Chen Yufei in the quarterfinals.

Tough schedule

"I haven't experienced something like this at a major championship," Sindhu said after losing to the Chinese. "The scheduling was not really well organised is what I feel."

Sindhu's gruelling Saturday appeared to catch up with her in the quarterfinal against Chen on Sunday. After a promising start, in which she produced sharp, steep smashes and dominated proceedings, she lost 21-11, 18-21, 20-21, bringing India's badminton campaign to an end.

Yufei indulged in long rallies in the second and third games, tiring an already fatigued Sindhu to end India's badminton campaign. Minutes earlier, Unnati Hooda had also lost her women's singles quarterfinal, going down 16-21, 21-14, 17-21 to Japan's Akane Yamaguchi.

India finished with just the men's team bronze and failed to win an individual medal at the Asian Games for the first time since 2014. Sindhu did not directly blame the scheduling for her loss but pointed to inadequate recovery as a key factor. She was hardly alone in her frustration over the schedule.

Japan's Kodai Naraoka woke up on Sunday feeling "extremely fatigued" after playing twice on Saturday, while Indonesia's Jonatan Christie, who finished his third-round match at 2am, said he was "very disappointed" with the organisers. Thailand's Ratchanok Intanon, meanwhile, said she had not properly recovered after playing twice the previous day before facing world No. 1 An Se-young.

The complaints have put the spotlight on a schedule that left players juggling multiple matches, late finishes and early starts, with little time to recover between them.

"We don't usually practise playing two matches a day, so it was challenging to adjust," Naraoka said.

Christie's experience was even more extreme. He went to bed at 3.30am after finishing his previous match at 2am, woke up at 9am and then rushed to pre-



PV Sindhu lost to Chen Yufei 21-11, 18-21, 10-21. BAI

pare for his next match.

"I'm very disappointed with the organiser. I think they have done a bad thing for the athletes. They don't care about the athletes. That's it," he said after his defeat.

Intanon, who lost to defend-

ing champion An, who herself claimed she was "tired", said she had reached her hotel at 11pm after playing twice on Saturday. The early start the following morning left her with little time to recover. "My body was not very fit," she said. "After yesterday (two singles matches in one day), I was a bit tired, and we finished a bit late last night. Today we played quite early and I was not properly recovered."

While the turnaround times have also been punishing for doubles players, singles players have borne much of the burden, particularly those who competed in the team event, which ended on Thursday, before moving straight into the individual competition.

Women's doubles world No. 1 Tan Ning of China also criticised the scheduling, alleging that complaints from different teams had been treated differently.

"I feel the schedule is unfair. We went to make an official complaint, but the chief referee didn't do anything about it. But when the Japan team complained, they actually changed the time schedule," she told Chinese media.

Recovery concerns

The organisers had already revised the badminton schedule before the competition began. On September 17, the Aichi-Nagoya organising committee announced changes to several sessions, citing changes in the number of participating athletes. For badminton, the September 26 programme was altered, with the mixed doubles second round moved out of that session. There has been no official explanation, however, following the players' complaints.

For Sindhu, the problem was not simply the number of

matches but the physical toll of having to play again before her body had recovered.

"Even though you think you are doing good, physically you might not be able to go there or you might not be able to play," she said. "When there are long rallies, definitely, yes, recovery. When you had a good thing, you would automatically, but your legs don't move."

She acknowledged that the matches themselves had been good but felt the scheduling needed to be better. "Three matches in 24 hours, is it some kind of, not just first time, mentally how do you prepare yourself?" she said. "I think more than mentally, you need to recover."

By the time she left the stadium on Sunday, it was nearly 3pm, bringing to a close a gruelling 24 hours that had included three energy-sapping matches and a heartbreaking exit.

ON TRACK TO UNDERWHELM

Close misses the story of the day as Indians fall short of gold haul

After shooting, poor returns in track & field add to pall of gloom on day of expectations



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 27

ANCY SOJAN was praying. As China's Yingying Huang prepared for her final jump in the women's long jump, the Indian was hoping that the gold medal she had been in a position to clinch for much of the competition would remain hers.

"I was like, 'Oh my God, don't let me down,'" she prayed. But Huang's jump travelled 6.55m, 2cm farther than Ancy's best of 6.53m and the Indian was left with silver. "There is a little bit of heartbreak for the two centimetres. Disappointed that the gold slipped out of my hand," Ancy said.

It was the kind of heartbreak that would define India's evening at the Asian Games on a rare full-house at the Mizuho Park. Ancy's gold slipped away by 2cm, while Shaili Singh was pushed out of the bronze-medal position in the final round.

In high jump, Sarvesh Kushare saw a golden opportunity open up with the absence of Mutaz Barshim, only to fall short of a height he had cleared before. And in the decathlon, Tejaswin Shankar was left with a bronze he felt should have been silver, if not gold.

The results left Indian athletics still searching for its first gold medal of the Nagoya Asian Games. With the competition nearing its final stages, match-



Sarvesh Kushare managed a jump of 2.25m, which earned him the silver medal in men's high jump final. PTI

● Gold drought

SILVER
Gulveer Singh- 10000m (M)
Sawan Barwal- Marathon (M)
Ancy Sojan- Long jump (W)
Sarvesh Anil Kushare- High jump (M)
Tajinderpal Singh Toor- Shot put (M)
Indian 4x400m mixed relay team
BRONZE
Seema- 10000m (W)
Tejaswin Shankar- Decathlon (M)
Harita Bhadra- 200m (W)
Prachi- 400m (W)
Baranica Elangovan- Pole Vault (W)
Parul Choudhary- 3,000m Steeplechase (W)
Manpreet Kaur- Shot Put (W)

ing the six gold medals won at the 2023 Hangzhou edition now looks a difficult task.

The broader picture is equally sobering. With just four, compared to table-topper China's 119, India's gold tally

has remained abysmal, with a paltry stream of silver (16) and bronze (17) medals. Shooting, which had been one of the country's biggest medal-producing sports at Hangzhou, has also fallen short of its previous gold-medal return.

There is still time for India to add to its gold count, but Sunday's results offered a particularly stark illustration of the difference between being in contention and converting that position into gold.

For Ancy, the defeat was particularly cruel because she had been in control for much of the competition; even when Huang challenged her for the first time in her penultimate attempt. The Chinese jumper recorded 6.49m in her fifth attempt, equalling Ancy's 6.49m that had given her an early lead. The 25-year-old Indian responded emphatically, clearing 6.53m to regain the top spot. She needed Huang to fall short in her final attempt. Instead, she produced the decisive jump, turning what had

Ancy Sojan. PTI

looked like an Indian gold into a silver.

Ancy's close friend and fellow jumper Shaili Singh, meanwhile, had been in the reckoning for bronze before China's Mengyi Tan jumped 6.46m in the final round. Shaili's best of 6.42m left her fourth, just 4 cm short of the podium. The two Indians had reached the final round with a potential double



medal in their grasp. They left with one silver.

Close misses

The disappointment continued in the men's decathlon, where Tejaswin Shankar was left to rue what he felt was a missed opportunity to win gold or a silver, finishing with 7934 points accumulated in 10 events over two days. "It's a lost opportunity of a gold or silver. So here I am settling for a bronze medal," he said. "It's really bad. I don't, I can't, even make up things to be able to justify this performance."

Tejaswin's self-assessment was unusually brutal for an athlete who had secured a medal. The bronze was a tangible reward for his efforts, but it did little to soften the disappointment of a performance he felt had fallen short of his ambitions. "I am pretty p****d." High jumper Sarvesh Kushare, too, was left with a silver medal when gold had been within reach in the men's high jump. The absence of Qatar's Barshim, a three-time Asian Games champion, had raised hopes of a breakthrough for the Indian. Kushare had spotted the start list on his way to the stadium, and the news had given him reason to believe that gold was there for the taking.

South Korean Sanghyeok Woo, a two-time World Championship silver medallist, could not find his rhythm either, leaving the contest for gold between Kushare and 23-year-old Taiwanese Chao-hsuan Fu, who is still finding his feet at the senior level. All Kushare had to do was clear 2.28m, less than his personal best of 2.31. When it mattered, though, he couldn't produce a big jump.

The silver was a medal, but not the one he had come for. "I am not satisfied with the silver. But what can I do? I have a medal at least," he said.

The medals were there, but the gold remained elusive.

Harita adds medal to cap of many feathers

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, September 27



Harita Bhadra in action. PTI

HARITA BHADRA didn't have any idea what the results were after she finished the women's 200m race toe-to-toe with Japanese sprinter Abigeirufuka Ido.

While Shanti Pereira of Singapore won the race and Chinese sprinter Yujie Chen stood second, it was a photo finish for the bronze medal. The Indian sprinter pipped Ido by one-hundredth of a second to win India's only sprint medal at the 2026 Asian Games.

"When I heard my name and Unnathi quipped that you came third, I realized that I have won a medal. It was a very close finish and I was not sure who came third," Harita told reporters. Her medal ends India's eight-year wait for a podium in the women's 200m after Dutee Chand had won 100m and 200m silvers at the 2018 Jakarta edition. Besides sprinting, Harita is a graduate in sports science from Loughborough University and runs a handmade jewellery brand called 'Daagina' (jewellery in Marathi).

The 23-year-old from Mumbai is enjoying her breakthrough year and the Asian Games medal is a culmination of it. "As a coach, the medal validates the plan I had prepared for Harita. According to that, she was set to peak in September and she did that," Harita's coach Rohit Mane told *The Indian Express*.

Starting the season in February at the Indoor National Championships, Harita captured everyone's attention with a 7.32s run in 60m. She followed it up with a timing of 23.14s in 200m at the National Inter-State Championships to book her Asiad berth. Earlier this month, she scorched through the Mondo track in New Delhi during the Indian Athletics Series finale to clock 11.22s in 100m, second fastest behind Dutee's national record of 11.17s.

"As the results show, she has improved with every event and that is what makes her one of most promising athletes in the country. Her hunger to learn and improve everyday," said Rohit.

When Harita lined up for the women's 200m final, she was

the fourth fastest woman on the list behind Pereira, Chen and Ido and one of the reasons that she could beat the Japanese sprinter is because of her good finishing.

"There is no point of getting excited and fading away at the end. She followed that and saved her energy for the last. For the first 120m, she was not in the lead but as others faded away and the race neared its end, she did what was required," explained Rohit.

For the longest time, Harita was a student-athlete, especially during her time at Loughborough. After she graduated last year, she wanted to focus on two things: her athletics career and the jewellery brand. "I enjoyed my graduation. It was fun and the best part was that it matched my athletics career. What I studied helped me understand my body better while sprinting," Harita had told this paper.

"Once I was done with my graduation, I decided to give full attention to athletics and also handmade jewellery which is sort of my baby. I design these jewellery pieces and sell them online on *Instagram*," said Harita. "The reason I could pursue the sport was that I enjoy it a lot," she added. Harita started athletics at the age of 12. "The good thing about starting that early is that you enjoy the sport to the fullest. One of the reasons why I kept playing was because it helps me relax," she said.

After her graduation, Harita started training at the Jio Institute in Mumbai under Reliance Foundation coach Rohit, and the medal is the duo's first major one together. In addition to being a jewellery entrepreneur, sports science grad and athlete, Harita Bhadra is now an Asian Games medallist.

● TWO SILVERS IN SQUASH

Outclassed Abhay & Anahat take bitter lessons from Malaysian mauling in finals

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 27

THE LATE Malcolm Willstrop shaped squash in immeasurable ways. He mentored a young Abhay Singh before his son James took over. He also mentored the man instrumental in the defeats of Abhay and Anahat Singh in the Asian Games singles finals.

British coaching legend Malcolm took an eight-year-old Andrew Cross under his wings in Pontefract. Cross, inspired by Malcolm's passion, started coaching at 21. It was a leap of faith and cultures, from Leeds to Kuala Lumpur, as he accepted a full-time role with the Malaysian juniors.

In the 19 subsequent years, Cross has taken Malaysian squash to new heights. After

helping make the nation an Asian junior powerhouse, he has spurred the growth of teenage promise into senior stardom. Sivasangari Subramaniam and Eain Yow Ng are shining examples.

Cross was in their corner when Sivasangari and Eain Yow won the singles titles at Hangzhou. He was there in Nagoya too when the duo retained their titles in emphatic fashion.

Anahat and Abhay were no match for the top seeds on Sunday. The gulf in class was evident as Sivasangari and Yow raced to gold medals and Los Angeles Olympics berths. The Indians, though outplayed, made the country proud. Saurav Ghosal was the only Indian to reach the final of an Asiad singles event before them.

The head-to-head records



Anahat Singh (R) lost to Sivasangari Subramaniam on Sunday. PTI

between the finalists painted a picture before the matches began. Abhay had lost each one

of his seven face-offs with Eain Yow; Anahat had played two, lost two against Sivasangari.

Their only chance was in making an early move and unsettling their respective opponents. Once that didn't happen, it was one-way traffic.

Abhay appeared up for the challenge, initially. He was moving fluidly and stroking the ball confidently into the corners as the rallies lengthened in Game 1. He even came up with a crowd-pleasing tweener along the way, but Yow was not to be daunted. He absorbed all that Abhay threw his way and finished off points with technical finesse.

Yow exhibited some clinical volleying at the business end, opening up two game balls at 10-8. Abhay saved the first one by way of a stroke for obstruction, but was cramped for room in the back court next as Yow took the first game 11-9.

Abhay cracked under Yow's

brilliance from there on as uncharacteristic errors began creeping in his game. The physical pressure of the long rallies, as also Yow's precise shotmaking, subdued him. The reigning champ stamped his authority on the final with sublime finishing towards the end to blow away Abhay 11-9, 11-5, 11-5. The Indian was the first to admit that he was outwitted. "He was just better all around. Sometimes, you need to put your hands up and give credit to your opponent and I think he deserved to win today. I was short of answers but that goes down to his abilities and how he put them forward today," Abhay told reporters.

Same script

A similar story unfolded with Anahat. Sivasangari grabbed the game by the scruff of its neck

from the outset.

After a balanced beginning, the Malaysian volleyed beautifully and harried Anahat to open up a 9-4 lead. An exquisite drop, boosted by a deflection from the side wall, helped the Malaysian convert the first of her six game points in the opener.

She didn't relent in Game 2, timing the ball sweetly and gliding across the court effortlessly. Sivasangari was not allowing any leeway for Anahat to work her magic by way of drops or kills. A missed backhand opened up four match points for Sivasangari. Anahat gutsily saved the first one, but fell short on the second. Sivasangari drove her up the side wall, in an apt metaphor for how the match panned out. She won it 11-4, 11-4, 11-7.

While acknowledging her opponent's superiority, the 18-

year-old expressed displeasure. "I am not happy at all with the way I played today. I think I could have done a lot better," she said. Anahat had mounted a comeback to beat world No. 6 Satomi Watanabe on Saturday but said the battle was much more uphill against Sivasangari.

"There is still a huge gap. Not everyone realises, but even number 5 and number 6 have a huge difference (between them). You may not be able to always tell, but when you are inside the court, you really feel the pressure. I can definitely give her that. There was not much for me to do."

Abhay said there was nothing to celebrate for him with his performance. "I didn't come here for silver," he added before outlining his Olympics ambition. "The LA dream is not over."

Kohli on 15,000 ODI runs: ‘Focus has never been on milestones’



Virat Kohli scored his 55th century in ODI cricket. CREIMAS

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 27

MORE THAN two months after his last ODI, Virat Kohli returned with an unbeaten 139 off 88 balls, a display of complete command and ruthless efficiency that had the visiting West Indians totally outclassed. During the innings, Kohli also crossed 15,000 ODI runs. But for the 37-year-old, the landmark was secondary to doing the job India needed from him.

“My focus has never been on these milestones. It’s been about focusing on situations, doing the job for the team. Obviously, I feel very grateful and blessed for having played so long. Keeping my head down... So many people want to be here; we are blessed to be here,” Kohli told the broadcasters after the eight-wicket win.

The last 12 months have seen Kohli find another gear in white-ball cricket. He said the challenge of scoring quicker had given him something new to work towards.

“I got a challenge at this stage of my career to up the ante, play a gear or two higher, exciting for me to work on, excites me when you have to unlock a new version in your career, be it playing for India or in the IPL. To follow a free mind, you need a fit body. Then I can visualise my game and execute it the way I did tonight,” he said.

That evolution has a clear destination. With the ODI World Cup just over a year away, Kohli knows his goal but wants to enjoy the journey as well.

“The World Cup is a year away; I know what my goal is. I just needed to work on different aspects of the game... Run from boundary to boundary, show intensity, keep ticking those boxes, I just want to enjoy every day,” he said.

That perspective has become a recurring theme for Kohli, with the former India captain stressing the importance of remembering where his journey began.

“We need to look back once and look where we came from. We tend to forget that with the hustle of the world, and the attention and the fame, it’s easy to forget where we came from. I enjoy each and every moment out there I play for India. Could have been a possibility that I wouldn’t have been standing here, could have never played for India.

“Keep working hard, put a smile on my face, and make other people smile as well. Don’t think about all the other stuff outside the field when you get on it; put your body on the line; you have to do it, there’s no excuses,” he added.

INDIA VS WEST INDIES

Prince leads way, King follows

Kohli’s majestic 139 not out and Gill’s 110 make it easy for hosts in the chase of 295 as they win by 8 wkts in 1st ODI

Sandip G
Thiruvananthapuram, September 27

THE MOMENT would remain frozen in the memory of the audience. Virat Kohli sears down the ground, pauses for a micro second and transfers his weight seamlessly into Guda-kesh Motie’s flighted ball. Over the long-on fence. Into his 55th century, into their imperishable memory. It’s perhaps the last they would see Kohli in flesh and bone in an India shirt. Kisses flew, drums beat in frenzy, the chants reached a deafening chorus and unleashed a barrage of boundaries to wrap up the game.

A bigger narrative had just played out. A tango between the past, present and future of Indian batting. Kohli (139 not out) is the past and the present; Gill (110) is the present and future. Their worlds produced a stirring harmony. Along their 151-run partnership that reduced the game to an eight-wicket canter, the equation they exuded was not between a master and an apprentice; but between two near equals. Kohli certainly is the more masterly and celebrated of the two, 55 hundreds and 15k runs to his ledger, but Gill did not seek the solace of his giant shadow. He firmly held his own ground until the cramps got the better off him. Kohli continued his merry dance into a hundred that was all unbridled aggression and winked in with a savage six off Motie. A hundred of utmost comfort, except for a blow on his wrist by Alzarri Joseph, much as the crowd had wished. But Gill’s three-figure score was no less magnificent.

It is a marker of the format’s receding relevance that Gill’s batsmanship goes uncelebrated. He embodies the essence of new-age ODI batsmanship, brandishing aggression without embracing. Both the old, modern batting philosophies blend in him friction-



Virat Kohli (L) and Shubman Gill’s centuries secured a comfortable win for India in the series opener against West Indies. CREIMAS

lessly. The start was watchful, as often it is. But he seizes an over wherein he knocks out the bowler softly. Joseph was the hapless victim, as he switched through the gears with three crisp fours in the eighth over.

None of the balls were wrapped with gift-paper. The first was a hard length ball outside the off-stump. He cuffed it through point; the second was shorter and wider and he blitzed it in front of point, piercing the alley between two fielders placed specifically to block the shot. Enraged, Joseph bowled fuller, only for the ball to meet the sweet spot off Gill’s ball coming down after tracing a gorgeous parabola. The giant television screen on the ground played that cover numerous times, and yet it continued to awe the audience. Apart from a reprieve on 11, shattering the crowd’s dream of watching Kohli and Rohit Sharma together, he was inscrutable.

Before the onslaught, he was on 18 off 26 balls; in the twitch of an eyelid, he raced to 39 off 33 balls. It included an inside-out six off leg-spinner

• KOHLI: OVERLORD OF ODIS

FASTEST TO 15,000 RUNS (IN TERMS OF INNINGS)

30	5	6374
Most centuries while chasing	Most centuries since 2025	Most runs while chasing in a winning cause

Motie, followed by a cut-stroked four. He used his feet habitually against both spinners and seamers. Sometimes he telegraphs his designs, but it doesn’t matter. Even if the bowlers adjust, he readjusts at the last split-second and often finds the same result he was looking for. Early in the piece, Matthew Forde pulled his length back, but Gill suddenly stopped and carved him over the square leg fielder for a four.

There is little doubt that Gill is the future figurehead of India’s batting. The nit-pickers would harp on his shortage of hundreds when chasing. Before this game, he averaged 59 when pursuing a target, but with only two hundreds (off his nine). It’s not a blotch in his career, but the burden of being Kohli’s successor is crushing.

Gill has to not only score runs and win games, but do so like Kohli. In run chases, in clutch moments. This was not quite a nervous game, but Gill had to ensure that there were no interventions of drama. Like Kohli, he has to illustrate that captaincy doesn’t wither him. He calmly guided the chase, as Kohli would, under his nose.

Their methods and outlooks could be different, just as Kohli’s was with his spiritual predecessor, Sachin Tendulkar. Gill’s face barely mirrors his thoughts. A warm half a smile is all he gives. Kohli is a riot of emotions, even though there is nothing left for him to prove. Kohli, though, has shed his siege mentality. He rarely gets provoked these days, barely engages in verbal spats. The sneer and snigger are expressions he

has long ditched. Maybe it comes with his own deep understanding of the game and the mastery he wields. He brings a different kind of joy, not as much rush of adrenaline or heart-leaping intensity, but a surreal calmness.

The arena witnessed a poignant moment. As Gill trudged back to the pavilion after his hundred, Kohli ran towards him and hugged him. He wrapped an arm over his shoulder, and consoled him with the warmth of a close kin. The axiom perhaps is true, that greatness realises greatness.

They are two different batsmen in different stages of their career. Kohli has conquered all he could save Tendulkar’s 18k peak; Gill is speeding along the highway Kohli built. Together, they rode smoothly on another highway that was the Greenfield surface. **BRIEF SCORES: West Indies 295/7 in 50 overs (Justin Greaves 101, Johnny Campbell 62; Kuldeep Yadav 4/40) lost to India 300/2 in 41.4 overs (Virat Kohli 139 not out, Shubman Gill 110) by 8 wickets**

2 years since suspension, Parveen redeems herself

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 27

SPEARHEADING INDIA’S boxing campaign at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, Parveen Hooda assured a medal with a unanimous 5-0 win against Uzbekistan’s Navbakhor Khamidova — a silver medalist at the 2025 World Championships — in the quarter-finals of women’s 65kg. With her victory, India now have assured three medals in boxing — joining Hooda on the list is Commonwealth Games’ silver medalist Narender Berwal, who scored a win over Thailand’s Adthapong Saengtep via RSC, and Ankush Panghal, gold medalist in Glasgow, who defeated Tajikistan’s Nekruz Salimov.

For Hooda, this perform-

ance arrives as a shot at redemption. She had won an Asian Games medal three years ago, but saw it getting chalked off following a suspension by the International Testing Agency for whereabouts failure. The implications of the suspension were not restricted to the continental games as Hooda would also lose her Paris Olympics quota. The Commonwealth Games campaign had not gone according to plans either, where she suffered a defeat against England’s Sacha Hickey in the quarter-final.

On Sunday, however, the 26-year-old did not let ghosts of the past haunt her one bit. Khamidova opted for the aggressive route in the first round, but the Indian kept her at bay, using her left jab and foot movement optimally. Once the Uzbek lost



Parveen Hooda poses with coaches. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

steam, Hooda took control of the proceedings, dominating the lion’s share of the last 3 rounds.

“Navbakhor came with a good pedigree in the 65 kg class and she has defeated most of the best boxers in this class in recent

months. We were clear that Parveen has to box from a long distance and manage the bout from there,” Hooda’s coach, Santiago Nieva told *The Indian Express* after the bout. “Sometimes, Parveen has the tendency to rush in a little too much, but she showed the control and balance through her punches. Navbakhor tried to be aggressive in the first round with her overhand right but Parveen thwarted that boxing from distance and was quick to evade her. That meant Navbakhor was left confused and she was trying to counter. But Parveen used her jab as well as her left hook to perfection. In between, she was good with her back right hand punches too and Navbakhor did not have variations of punches today. It was Parveen’s bout to control.”

If not for an upset elsewhere, Parveen would have been staring at a steep challenge against Aida Abikeyeva — gold medalist at the World Championships last year. Instead, she would be facing China’s Li Shu in the semi-final, who defeated the Kazakh pugilist 4-0. “The bout between Aida and Shu was very messy and the Kazakh also got a warning. The Chinese did not look very impressive but we will sit down and read her game. Parveen has the game to counter the Chinese,” he said.

While Sunday largely played out how the Indian boxing contingent would have preferred, it was not perfect. Sachin Siwach, fresh off a gold medal at the Glasgow games, suffered a 4-1 defeat against home pugilist Shunsuke Kitamoto.

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Arjun steps up as India nail down silver



Arjun Erigaisi (R) beat veteran Peter Leko while R Praggnanandhaa drew with Richard Rapport. RAFAL OLEKSIEWICZ/FIDE

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 27

IT WAS an afternoon of stark irony. D Gukesh, the lynchpin of India’s campaign and seemingly unbreachable throughout the tournament, was being outplayed on Board 4 by Hungary’s 2560-rated Gleb Dudin. A few feet away, Arjun Erigaisi, weathering days of scrutiny after a quiet tournament, pushed veteran Peter Leko into a corner to keep the final round match of the 2026 Chess Olympiad on a knife-edge.

Retaining their Budapest crown always required some miracle. A win against Hungary was non-negotiable, and even that depended on a ruthless Uzbekistan side somehow stumbling against Ukraine in the last round. Neither happened. When Gukesh finally extended his hand in resignation, there was somehow little outward despair on his face.

The maths had already settled the matter. Uzbekistan cruised to victory against Ukraine, meaning that regardless of how Gukesh’s board unfolded, even a flawless Indian sweep on the day would not have stopped the gold from slipping away. But Arjun calmly converted his endgame to rescue a 2-2 draw, locking down a hard-earned silver for an Indian side that simply refused to leave Samarkand empty-handed.

For hosts Uzbekistan, this gold is another marker of their rapid rise in world chess, an Olympiad title won in front of a home crowd. The favourites lived up to the billing, finishing with 20 match points, two clear of India and Germany.

The triumph repeats Uzbekistan’s historic 2022 gold and reaffirms their status as India’s biggest challenger. India ended their campaign with 18 match points and 28.5 game points, tied with Germany on both counts. But the defending champions took silver on a superior tiebreak (TB2), having won the head-to-head clash. Germany, the giant-slayers who toppled USA and were the only side to beat Uzbekistan, had to settle for bronze. Hungary, meanwhile,

punched above their weight to nearly trip the Indians. The same side that had been thrashed 4-0 by Uzbekistan came hard, with Richard Rapport and Benjamin Gledura closing out draws against R Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin to give them nothing to play for. It took a much-needed win from Arjun, following Gukesh’s unfortunate loss, to keep India afloat.

India had kept themselves in contention for gold right up to the final day, but it was their loss to Uzbekistan that stung the most. From a winning position, a blunder from Nihal Sarin against Nodirbek Yakubboev cost India crucial points.

For Indian captain Srinath Narayanan, however, the take-away was the silver that was won, not the gold that was lost.

“We played stronger for most of that match and utilised the advantage. Even in Nihal’s game against Yakubboev, Nihal was clearly the one playing better. Uzbekistan probably realised that by winning that match, they had beaten the one team that could seriously push them,” Srinath told *The Indian Express*. “It was a massive setback for us, like a final before the final. Uzbekistan winning that gave them a huge step forward... the confidence, the momentum, everything.”

“It was an Olympiad decided by fine margins. If that fixture had gone our way, we probably would have been favourites for gold. But with that match point against us, silver is a fair result,” said Srinath. Grandmaster Vaibhav Suri, part of the Indian coaching contingent and trainer to R Praggnanandhaa, agreed with that assessment.

“The number of misses we had was still relatively small compared to the mistakes made by other teams,” Suri said.

“Budapest in 2024 was an anomaly; that is simply not how Olympiads unfold historically. We need to be slightly careful micro-analysing these mistakes and errors. At the end of the day, you need players to stay in the right headspace because there is always another round to play. You have to keep a steady, forward-looking attitude.”

Savitha rescues India as women clinch bronze

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 27

THE INDIAN women’s team operated to a clear blueprint in Samarkand: the top boards absorbed pressure while the lower boards took risks to force decisive results. That placed an immense burden on Vantika Agrawal and debutant Savitha Shri B. Yet the trial by fire brought out the best in Savitha. The teenager emerged as India’s breakout star, taking individual gold on Board 5 and repeatedly rescuing the team. None was more critical than her final-round escape against Georgia. She fought for six hours to turn a lost position into a draw, salvaging a 2-2 tie and ensuring India won bronze on tiebreaks.

China dominated despite missing Hou Yifan, Ju Wenjun and Lei Tingjie, finishing unbeaten on 20 match points, two ahead of Kazakhstan. India finished on 17, tied with the United States, Poland, Armenia and Mongolia, with superior tiebreaks putting them third.

Koneru Humpy, under the weather for the final five days, had struggled to convert draws into wins but delivered when it mattered, beating the experienced Nana Dzagnidze in the final round.

Kazakhstan’s draw with Poland opened a window for India to push for silver. Instead, they were soon fighting to stay on the podium: Divya Deshmukh had lost, Vantika was in a drawn endgame, and Savitha

was staring at defeat.

India captain Swayams Mishra was full of praise for the team’s saviour. “Even Savitha might not have expected to do so impressively. Especially in scenarios where she was not winning, or was in a bad position or lost at times, she fought back and went on to save or win the game. That was remarkable. For her first Olympiad, she performed exceedingly well,” Mishra told *The Indian Express*.

The individual returns softened the sting of missing out on the title defence. Apart from Savitha’s gold on Board 5, Humpy bagged bronze on Board 1, as did Vantika on Board 4. Divya, despite her final-round loss, had delivered consistently throughout the tournament to secure a silver on Board 3. For a squad of this calibre, bronze is still a step down from the double-gold high of Budapest 2024, a reality Mishra acknowledged.

“Unfortunately, it was not our tournament. We had a few close matches,” Mishra said. “We had a good chance of winning against China yesterday. If we had converted that, things would look very different right now.” The women’s bronze ensured India retained the Nona Gaprindashvili Trophy, awarded to the country with the best combined performance across the Open and Women’s sections. This marks the third straight edition in which India have claimed the trophy.

(With inputs from Amit Kamath)

• ASIAN GAMES CRICKET QUARTERFINAL

Amid rain threat, Iyer & Co begin defence against Afghanistan

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 27

LESS THAN two weeks after India swept Afghanistan in Delhi, Shreyas Iyer and Co. will face them again in the Asian Games quarterfinal in Nagoya on Monday. But there is a catch: this is not quite the Afghanistan they faced in Delhi.

Rashid Khan, Azmatullah Omarzai, Rahmanullah Gurbaz and Mohammad Nabi are among the familiar names missing. In their place are Arab Gol Momand, Nangeyalia Kharoti, Mohammad Akram and Ismat Alam, players India have seen little of but who have already got used to conditions in Japan.

That could matter, as India found out against Japan in Sano on Tuesday. A five-over contest that looked straightforward turned into a last-ball escape on a pitch offering plenty of turn.

Unusual challenge

Monday’s quarterfinal therefore presents an unusual challenge. India know Afghanistan, but not necessarily this Afghanistan. After Sano, they also know how unfamiliar opposition and conditions can lead to a close contest. The weather adds another uncertainty. Nagoya has seen almost continuous rain since Saturday, with more forecast until Thursday. “It is not just normal rain. It’s a torrential downpour,” Iyer said on Sunday after India’s practice session. While Sano offered turn, the tracks during the women’s competition at Korogi were largely good for batting and helped teams batting second. The men’s matches, however, have shown that spinners can have an impact.

Iyer said India could not take Afghanistan, or any other team, lightly after their experience



India’s T20I team training in Nisshin on Sunday. CREIMAS

against Japan. “Not only Afghanistan, any team in the Asian Games, like Japan, gave us a very good competition. Because the wicket here cannot be set in a particular standard. But as I said earlier, it is very important to adapt,” he said.

“It will be challenging and difficult for every team.”

Afghanistan have already seen both sides of those conditions. Against Japan, they had to work hard for 129/6. Debutant Akram made 34, but Afghanistan were only 84/4 after 16 overs before captain Darwish Rasooli and Mohammad Ishaq gave the innings a late push. Their spinners then took control. Gul

finished with 4/8, including two double-wicket maidens, while Kharoti took 3/19 as Japan slipped from 53/2 to 63/8 before being bowled out for 81.

But Afghanistan’s next game showed they can also struggle against spin. Nepal left-arm spinner Lalit Rajbanshi left them 16/3 inside five overs and finished with 3/13. Kushal Bhurte then took 4/21 as Afghanistan were restricted to 102/7 before Nepal won by five wickets.

Those games have given India some clues. Afghanistan’s batting can be put under pressure by spin, but their slow bowlers can also be difficult to score against when the pitch offers help. India have the bowlers to exploit that weakness. Axar Patel, Washington Sundar and Ravi Bishnoi bowled all five overs against Japan and would have noticed what Nepal’s spinners managed to do.

The bigger question is how India’s batsmen handle Afghanistan’s spinners if the ball turns again. Against Japan, Abhishek Sharma fell for a golden duck, while Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan also departed inside three overs. India are one of the few teams to have brought close to a full-strength squad. That makes them favourites on paper but also means expectations are higher. But after being pushed close by Japan, they will know they cannot afford to take time to settle.

INDIA SQUAD: Shreyas Iyer (C), Tilak Varma, Ravi Bishnoi, Abhishek Sharma, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Jasprit Bumrah, Sanju Samson, Axar Patel, Ishan Kishan, Washington Sundar, Arshdeep Singh, Shivam Dube, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Vipraj Nigam, Yash Thakur.